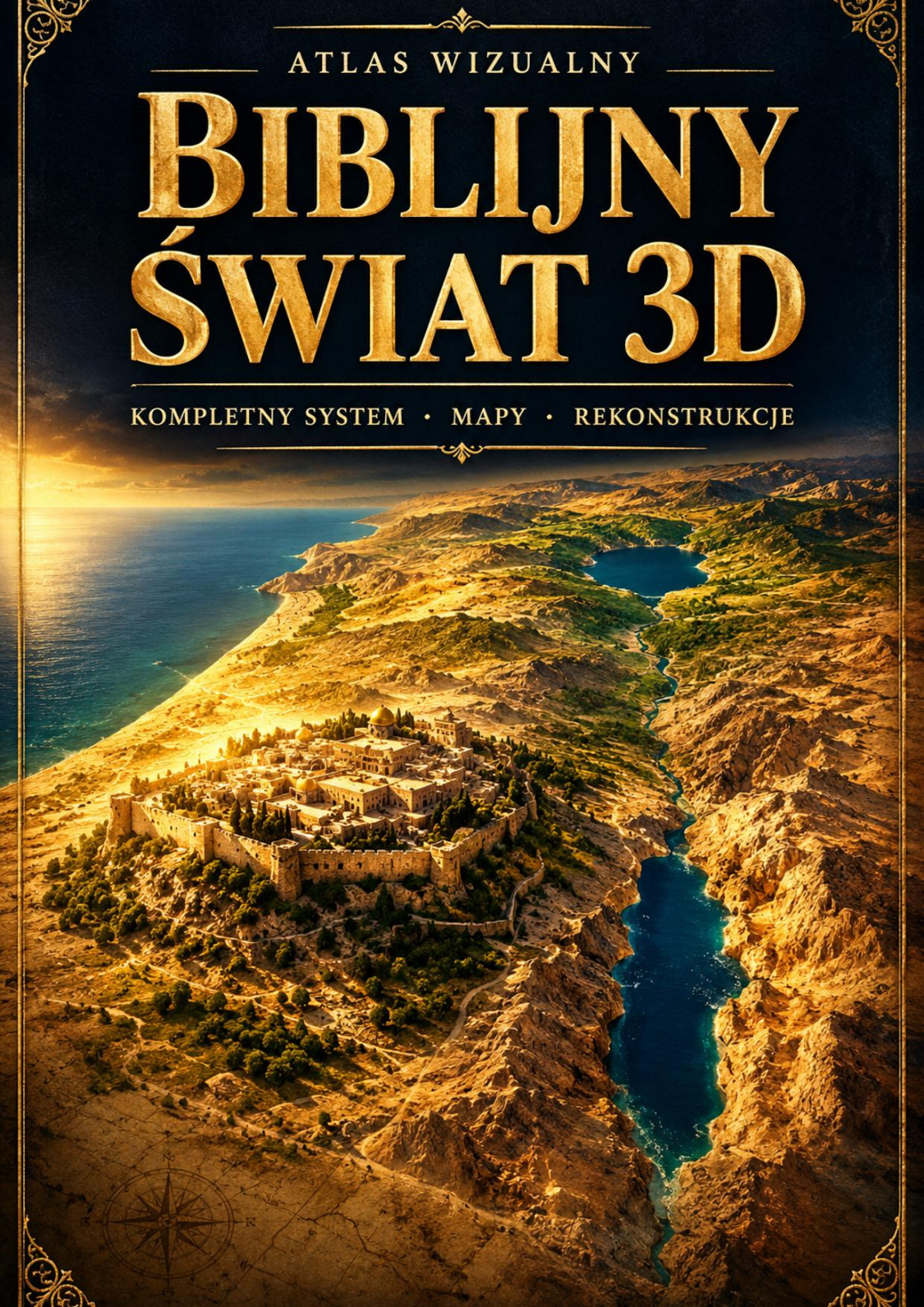
ATLAS WIZUALNY

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KOMPLETNY SYSTEM · MAPY · REKONSTRUKCJE



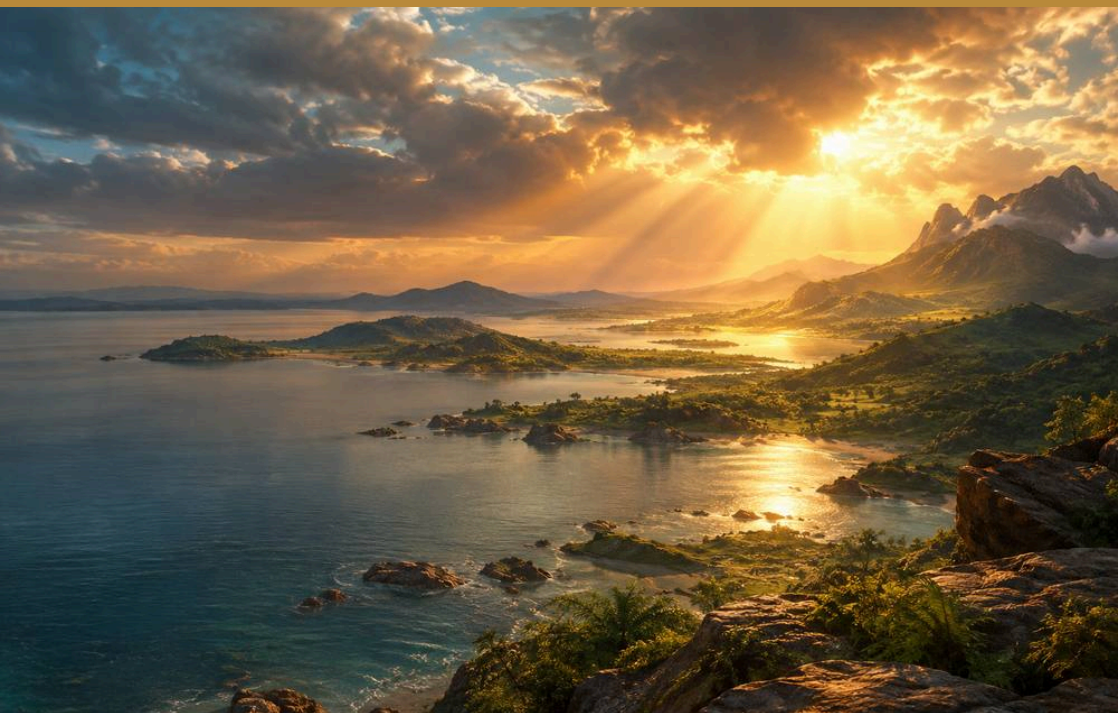
# 01

PART 1 OF 9

# Beginnings

GEN 1–11

*From the creation of the world to Abram's journey: the first chapters of the Bible set against the lands between Ararat and the Persian Gulf.*



# The World Where Everything Begins

Imagine opening a book whose first sentence embraces all of heaven and earth. That is how the Bible begins: with a story that has no map, cities, or borders yet, and still speaks from its first pages of order, goodness, and the relationship between humanity and God. We call chapters 1–11 of Genesis the primeval history. They are not a chronicle in the modern sense, but a grand introduction that answers the questions: where does everything come from, why is there suffering in the world, and where is humanity heading.

In this part of the atlas you will see that the story of beginnings only partly floats above the earth. Its second half has very concrete addresses: the mountains of Ararat on the Armenian highland, the plains of Shinar between the Tigris and the Euphrates, cities such as Babylon, Uruk, and Nineveh, and finally Ur of the Chaldeans and Haran. There archaeologists uncovered some of the oldest cities in the world, the first cuneiform writing, and monumental stepped towers called ziggurats. That is why the beginnings of the Bible can also be read with a map in hand.

It is worth remembering two layers of reading. The first is the message of faith that the Church and Christian tradition find in these texts: the world is good, humanity is called to relationship, and evil does not have the last word. The second is the cultural background of the ancient East, with its myths, laws, and cities. The reconstructions in this atlas are artistic interpreta-

tions based on excavations, not photographs. For places that cannot be pinpointed on a map, such as Eden, we honestly note that their location remains open.

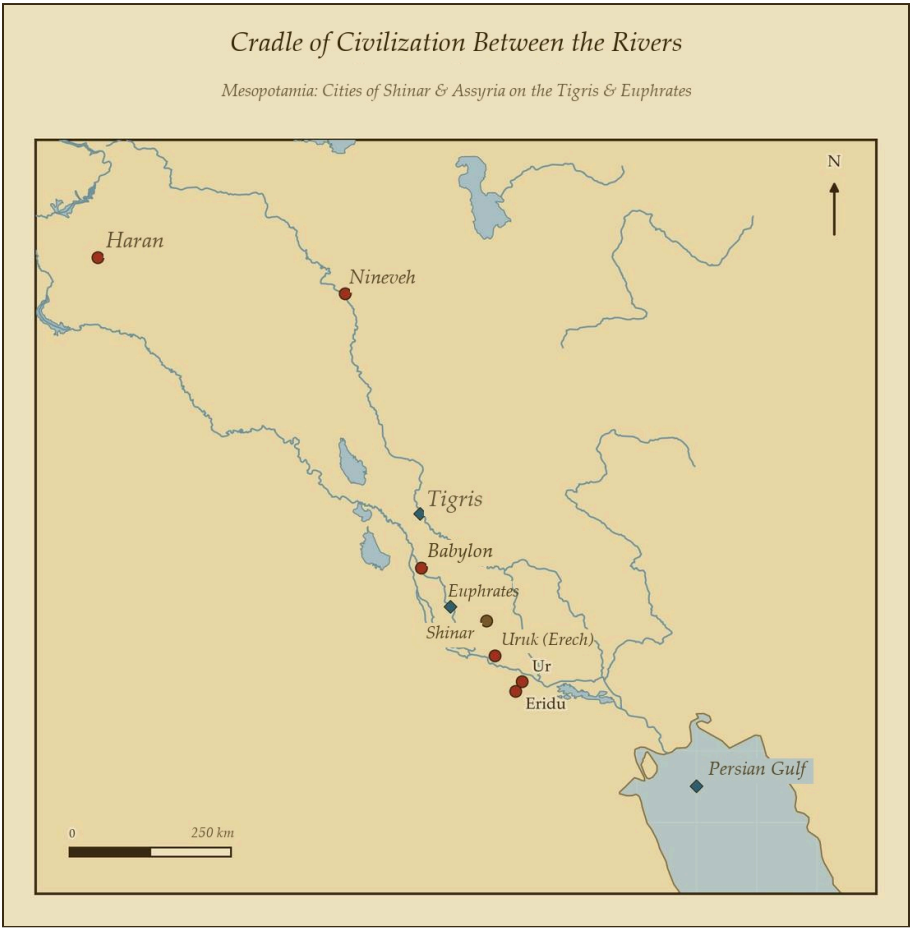
## INDEX OF PLACES AND SCENES


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HOW TO USE THIS ATLAS

Maps show routes and the locations of places; illustrations are artistic reconstructions based on archaeological knowledge, not photographs. Distances and dimensions are approximate.

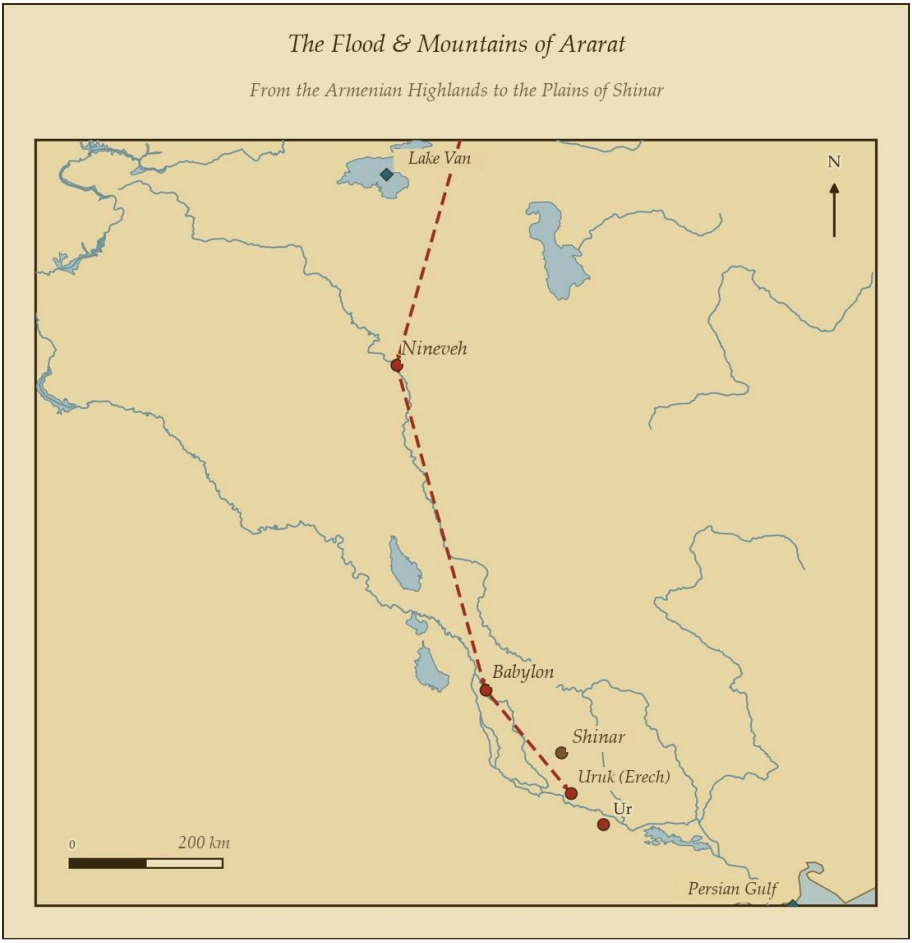
MAP 1.1




*The dots mark cities and lands from the Book of Genesis, and the blue dots indicate rivers and the sea. Read the map from north to south: from Nineveh to Eridu on the ancient coast.*

The map shows that Genesis tells of a real land between two rivers. All the cities named lie along the Tigris or the Euphrates, because water determined life and trade. The south, or Shinar, was a flat plain without stones, so people built with brick. The north, where Nineveh lies, was more mountainous. Notice that in ancient times the shoreline of the Persian Gulf reached farther inland, which explains why Eridu and Ur lay close to the sea.

MAP 1.2




*The line shows the direction in which people came down from the highland to the plain, in keeping with the account of settling in Shinar. It is an approximate route along the Tigris and Euphrates, not an exact road.*

Ararat lies on a high plateau from which waters flow down into Mesopotamia. That is why the story of the ark coming to rest in the mountains, followed by the settling of the plain, makes geographic sense. The extent of the region shows the difference in elevation: from over 5,000 m down to sea level. Note that the location of the peak where the ark rested is traditional, while the biblical text speaks generally of the mountains of Ararat, that is, the land of Urartu.

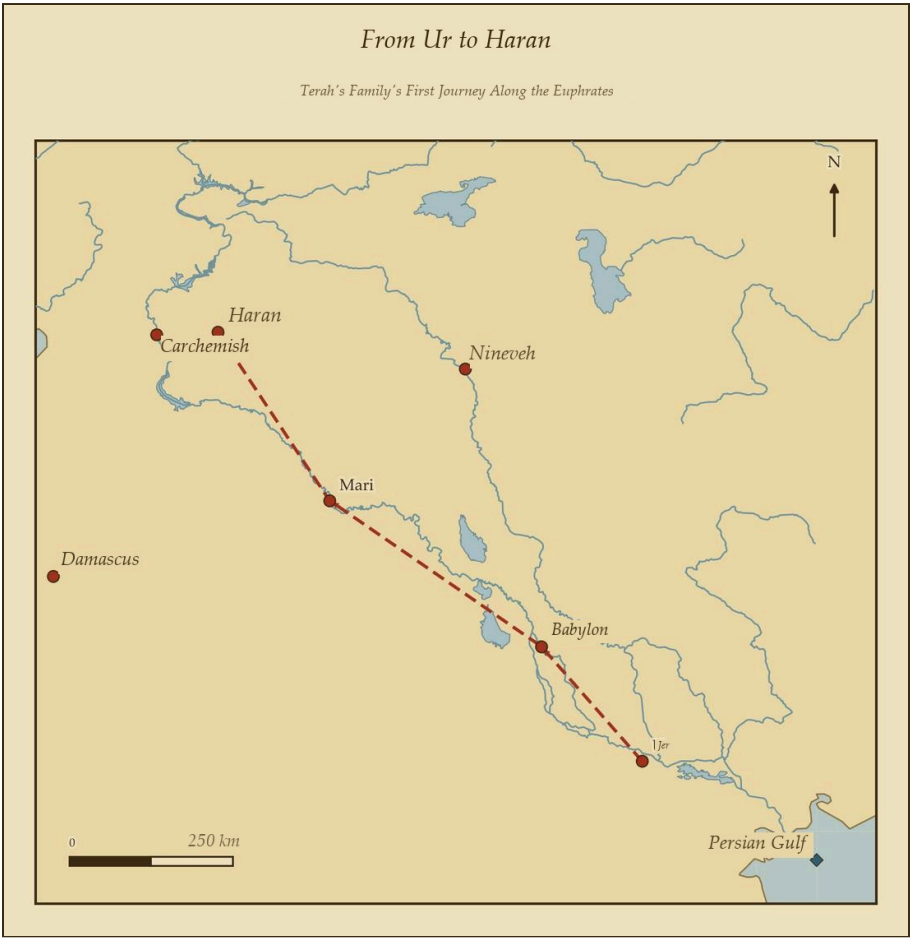
MAP 1.3




*The dots are the centers and lands that Genesis links with the descendants of Noah. The map is simplified: the Table of Nations describes cultural connections, not exact borders.*

Chapter 10 shows how the author pictured the surrounding world: from Greece in the west, through Egypt and the coast of Canaan, to Mesopotamia in the east. This arrangement is not a division by race, but a description of Israel's neighbors. The map shows that the center of this world was the basin of the eastern Mediterranean, and that Israel lay at the meeting point of great civilizations, which explains the later fate of the nation.

MAP 1.4




*The line marks the likely route along the Euphrates, the most convenient for caravans. The Bible does not describe the details of the journey, so the course is approximate.*

Caravans avoided the Syrian-Arabian desert and followed an arc along the Euphrates, where there was water and pasture. It is a longer but safer road than crossing the desert straight to Damascus. From Haran one could turn south toward Canaan, which is what Abram would do. The map shows that the decision to leave Ur was a journey stretched out over time, counted in weeks and months.

# 01 Creation of the World

GEN 1:1 – 2:4

*Seven stages in which the world receives order, light, and life.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows the world at the moment land emerges: broad waters, heavy light breaking through the clouds, and the first green slopes. It is not a specific landscape but a symbolic scene in which sky, sea, and earth are only just taking shape. You view it from high above, calm and free of people, to stress that the story begins with God's work, not with man.

The text that opens the Bible arranges creation in an orderly rhythm. God separates light from darkness, sets a vault of sky over the earth, gathers the waters, and lets the land appear. Then come plants, the heavenly bodies, fish, birds, and land animals. Finally humankind is created, male and female, in the image of God. The seventh day is a day of rest. The author does not describe physical processes, but teaches that the world is not the work of chance or of rival deities, but the good gift of one God. For the reader this has a practical dimension: the first chapter invites us to see everyday life as a gift, and work and rest as part of God's plan for humanity.

The geography in this account is cosmic rather than local, but it matters. The ancient Israelites lived among peoples who saw separate deities in the sun, the moon, and the sea. The biblical text simply calls them works of God: lamps in the sky and waters with boundaries set for them. For a farmer in Canaan, dependent on rainy and dry seasons, on the flooding of rivers and the rhythm of the year, this was a bold claim. The cycle of days and the week later became the basis of the calendar, and the Sabbath one of the most enduring customs of the community. It is also worth noting that Genesis took shape in a world full of competing stories, so its message of one Creator sounded clear and demanding.

FACTS

The text speaks of 6 days of creation and a seventh day, the day of rest.

# 02 Garden of Eden

GEN 2–3

*A garden with four rivers, where humankind is called to work and to trust.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a lush garden beside a stream: fruit trees, tall grass, flowers, and soft morning light. Two figures are seen from afar, from behind, walking along a path between the trees. The colors are warm, and the vegetation recalls the oases of ancient Mesopotamia. The scene is an imagining, not a recreation of a specific place, since Eden has no known location.

The second account of creation takes us to a garden that God planted in the east. The man, formed from the earth, is given the task of tending and keeping this place. Animals appear, and then the woman, a companion equal to the man. The prohibition against eating from one tree becomes a test of trust. The serpent questions God's word, the humans reach for the fruit, and their relationships are broken: shame, excuses, and expulsion appear. At the same time, the text mentions God's care in preparing clothing for his creatures. This helps us understand why many generations read this text as a story of longing for peace, closeness with God, and a return to harmony among people.

The text lists four rivers flowing from a single source, among them the Tigris and the Euphrates. We know two of them well: they flow through present-day Iraq and mark out the land of Mesopotamia, the country between the rivers. The other two, the Pishon and the Gihon, cannot be clearly identified, which is why the location of Eden remains unknown. The story is probably a literary picture of life in an oasis, where water, the shade of trees, and cultivation are a gift. For desert peoples, a garden with rivers was a symbol of fullness, and exile from it a symbol of lost harmony. A reader familiar with the desert landscapes of the Near East will more easily grasp why the vision of a garden with flowing water meant the height of prosperity and security to the people of that age.

FACTS

The text names 4 rivers; the Tigris and Euphrates flow today through Iraq, and their lengths are about 1,900 and about 2,800 km.

# 03 Cain and Abel — the Land of Nod

GEN 4

*A farmer and a shepherd, the first fratricide, and a wandering east of Eden.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a dry, open plain at dusk: a barley field on one side, a stony hill and a flock of sheep on the other. In the distance, two indistinct figures stand by a simple altar of stones, with smoke rising from it. The cloudy sky and long shadows give the scene tension without showing violence. The land of Nod remains undefined, so the background is generalized.

Cain works the soil, Abel tends sheep. Both bring offerings to God, but Abel's offering is accepted and Cain's is not. God warns Cain that sin is crouching at the door and must be mastered. Cain, however, invites his brother out to the field and kills him. Asked where Abel is, he answers with a question about whether he is his brother's keeper. Abel's blood cries out from the ground. Cain is condemned to wander, yet he receives a mark protecting him from vengeance. Thus begins a story of violence, but also of God's mercy. The whole event shows that evil grows by stages, from envy to deed, but God does not stop speaking with humankind even after its fall.

The account brings together two ways of life known from the Near East: settled farming and nomadic herding. Relations between them were often tense, because flocks damaged fields and crops reduced pasture. The land of Nod, where Cain departs, has a name linked to the Hebrew word for wandering, so it is probably symbolic and cannot be pointed out on a map. Later Cain founds a city, and his descendants develop herding, music, and metalworking, reflecting the birth of urban civilization. As a result, in Christian tradition the chapter became a call to responsibility for one's brother and to resistance against hatred.

FACTS

Cain is the first farmer and Abel the first shepherd in Genesis; Cain's lineage lists 7 generations.

# 04 Building Noah's Ark

GEN 6–8

*Noah prepares the ark, and the flood changes the face of the known world.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows an enormous wooden vessel in a shipyard on a riverbank, surrounded by scaffolding and beams. Several figures in the distance carry planks, while dark clouds in the background foretell a storm. The vessel has a rectangular hull, not the boat shape familiar from children's illustrations. The image is an imagining based on the description of the dimensions, not evidence of a discovered structure.

Genesis describes a world full of violence and says that God regrets having made people. Noah, a righteous man, is told to build an ark of wood, coated with pitch, with three decks and one window. His family and pairs of animals enter it. Rain falls, the waters rise and cover the earth. After a time the ark comes to rest, Noah sends out birds, and on leaving the ark he offers a sacrifice of thanks. God makes a covenant and sets the rainbow as the sign of his promise. Noah's family is thus the beginning of a new humanity, and the rainbow reminds us that the covenant embraces all creatures and endures despite human weakness.

The flood story has neighbors in the literature of Mesopotamia, for example in the Babylonian Epic of Gilgamesh and in older Sumerian texts. This shows that the memory of a great flood was shared across the region. That should not surprise us: the Tigris and Euphrates overflowed and changed their beds, and the plains of southern Iraq were at times flooded. The biblical author, however, gives this tradition a different meaning: instead of capricious deities there is one God who judges evil and at the same time cares about rescue. The dimensions of the ark, given in cubits, come to about 150 meters in length. The mention of olive oil points to the mature agricultural culture of the world in which this story was told and written down.

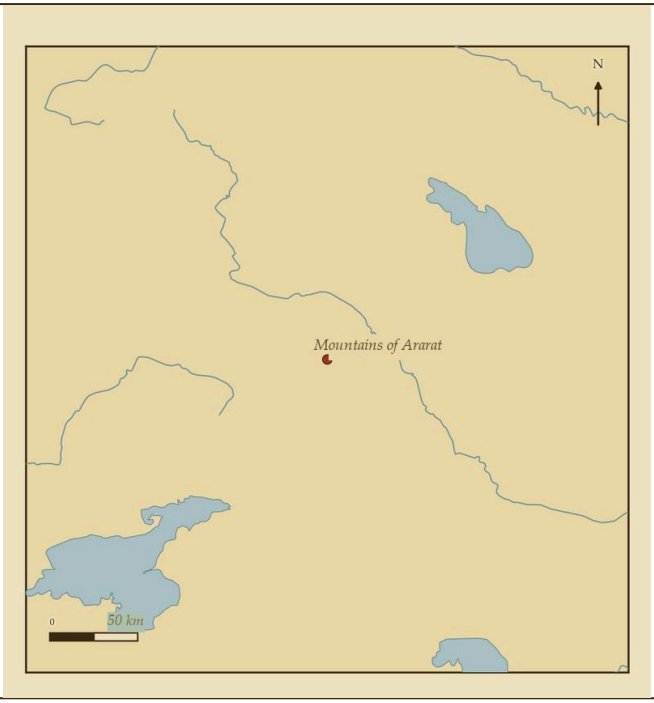
FACTS

Dimensions of the ark in the text: 300 cubits long, about 150 m, 50 cubits wide, and 30 cubits high.

# 05 Mountains of Ararat

GEN 8:4

*The highland where, according to tradition, the ark came to rest as the waters receded.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Artistic reconstruction: the place can be imagined as a stark volcanic massif: snow on the summits, rocky slopes, and cold, thin air. Below, valleys stretch out with fields and pastures. This is the present-day landscape, which lets us feel how remote and high this land must have seemed to the people of the Mesopotamian lowlands.

## 1.5 · MOUNTAINS OF ARARAT · GEN 8:4

When the floodwaters recede, the ark comes to rest on the mountains of Ararat. Noah waits, sends out a raven, and then a dove, which returns with an olive branch. After waiting again, the family leaves the ark and builds an altar. The text points not to a single peak but to a mountainous region. The Hebrew name Ararat corresponds to the Assyrian Urartu, a kingdom around Lake Van. Later, tradition attached the name to the tall, twin-peaked volcano Ararat, which today rises over eastern Turkey and can also be seen from Armenia. Today the area is nearly barren on the slopes and lush only in the valleys, which makes it easier to imagine that after the waters withdrew, people had to seek fertile land lower down.

Geographically this is the Armenian Highland, one of the highest areas of Western Asia. Both the Euphrates and the Tigris rise here, so waters flow from this place down into Mesopotamia. In the flood story this has symbolic meaning: the new world begins at the sources of the rivers, at a height from which the lowland can be seen. The road from Ararat to the plains of Shinar is about 800 km in a straight line. The location of the peak with the ark remains a matter of faith and tradition, not the result of scientific discoveries. For the reader it is a good example of how tradition and geography interweave into one story, without having to settle every detail.

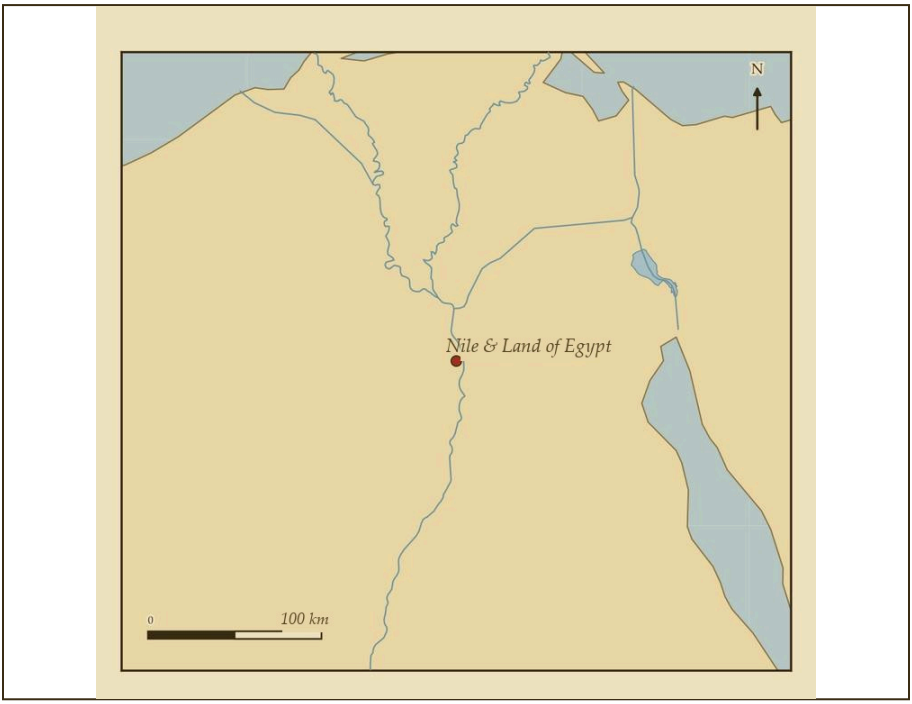
### FACTS

The Ararat massif rises to about 5,137 m above sea level; the location is traditional.

# 06 The Nile and the Land of Mizraim

GEN 10:6–14

*Egypt in the Table of Nations: the land of a great river and one of the first states in the world.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Artistic reconstruction: imagine a broad river in a narrow strip of green. On both sides rise yellowish desert cliffs, and along the bank stand fields, palms, and low brick houses. Wooden boats with sails glide on the water. The contrast between green and sand helps us understand why the Nile was a gift to the Egyptians.

Chapter 10 of Genesis is the Table of Nations: a list of the peoples who spread out after the flood. The author arranges them by the families of Shem, Ham, and Japheth, not by today's ethnography but by the political and cultural ties of his own era. Among the descendants of Ham are Mizraim, that is Egypt, and peoples linked with the Mediterranean coast. The text shows that Israel lived among neighbors it knew from trade, wars, and travel, and regarded them as part of one human family. On this map you can see that Egypt and Mesopotamia were the two poles of the ancient world, linked by routes through Canaan, where the patriarchs would later arrive.

For Egypt the Nile was all-important, flowing from south to north through the desert and feeding a fertile valley only a dozen or so kilometers wide. The yearly flood deposited silt and made harvests possible, so Egypt was the granary of the region. The area around Memphis, where the valley meets the delta, was the site where the country was united around 3000 BC. The distance from Memphis to the Mediterranean is about 160 km, and from Memphis to Jerusalem the overland road is about 450 km, which explains the frequent contact between the two lands. That is why the Bible often portrays Egypt as a place of refuge from famine, and also as a place of testing for Israel.

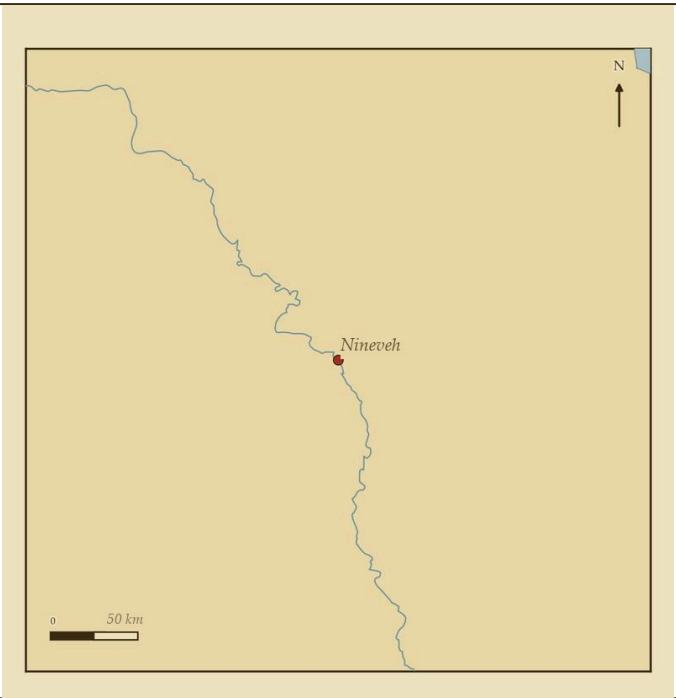
FACTS

The Nile is about 6,650 km long, and the valley in Egypt is often only about 10–20 km wide.

# 07 Nineveh

GEN 10:11–12

*A city on the upper Tigris, later the capital of Assyria.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a mighty city with brick walls, great gates, and palaces on a hill. Before the gate, merchants bustle about with donkeys and carts. In the background the broad Tigris flows, and gardens give shade around the palaces. The whole is an imagining based on archaeological discoveries and Assyrian reliefs, not an exact picture of a single moment.

Genesis mentions Nineveh in connection with Nimrod, the legendary hunter and ruler, of whom it is said that he went out from the land of Shinar to Asshur and built cities there. Among them Nineveh is named. Later in the Bible the city will return: the prophet Jonah will be sent to call its people to repentance, and Nahum will foretell its fall. The Genesis text is thus a brief mention, but it sets a geographic direction: from the southern plains toward northern Assyria. Through the Book of Jonah, Nineveh also became a symbol of a city called to repentance, which gives this mention in Genesis added weight.

Nineveh lay on the eastern bank of the Tigris, where the river leaves the hill country and enters a flatter lowland. This position gave access to water, fertile land, and routes leading to Anatolia and Syria. Under Sennacherib, around 700 BC, the city became the capital of the empire, surrounded by walls many kilometers long. The library of Ashurbanipal, with thousands of clay tablets, was discovered there. The location of Nineveh is certain and confirmed by excavations on the mounds of Kuyunjik and Nebi Yunus. Today part of the ruins lies beside a large modern city, which makes the archaeologists' work harder, yet it still yields new discoveries.

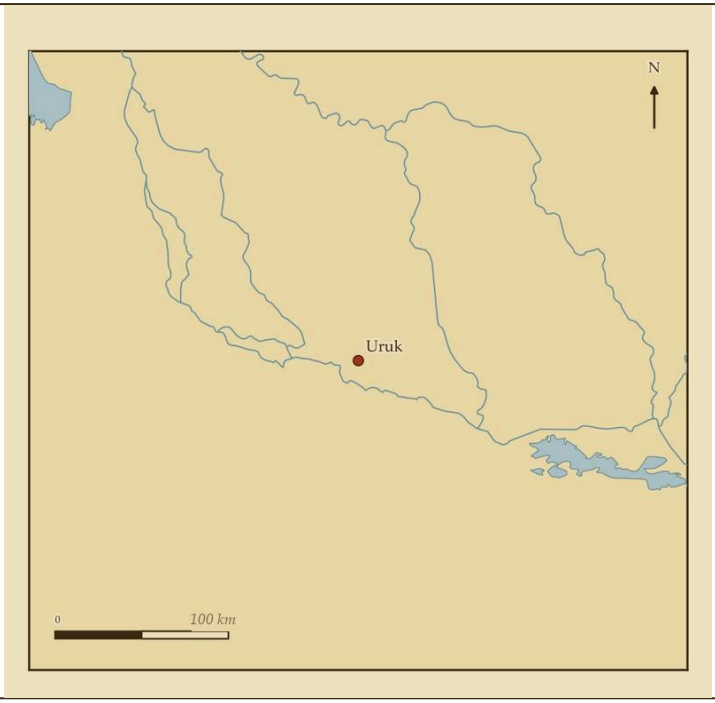
FACTS

According to research, the walls of Nineveh had a circumference of about 12 km; the city lies about 400 km from Babylon.

# 08 Uruk (Erech)

GEN 10:10

*One of the first great cities of the world, the cradle of writing.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a densely built city of mud brick, with a high temple terrace above the rooftops. The streets are narrow, and green strips of gardens run beside the canals. In the distance reed boats glide by, and farmers lead donkeys carrying baskets of grain. Earth tones and the blue of the canals give the impression of a warm, dry climate.

Genesis says that the beginning of Nimrod's kingdom was Babel, Erech, Akkad, and Calneh in the land of Shinar. Erech is Uruk, a city with an extraordinary role in human history. Here around 3300 BC the first signs of writing appeared, at first used for economic records. Among the legendary rulers of Uruk is Gilgamesh, the hero of the famous epic. The biblical author mentions the cities of Shinar to show that people very early began to build states and conduct politics. Thanks to this information, Uruk is for us proof that the urban civilization of the Bible is no fairy tale, but the real backdrop of the story of the origins of states and power.

Uruk lay on an ancient course of the Euphrates, in southern Mesopotamia, which is low and fertile but lacks stone and timber. Its inhabitants built with clay brick and relied on a system of irrigation canals. The city may have had tens of thousands of inhabitants, and its walls, according to Sumerian tradition, were about 9 km long. Today the ruins, called Warka, lie in the desert because the Euphrates changed its course, which shows how much the life of cities depended on water. The Epic of Gilgamesh, tied to this city, shows at the same time how ancient people sought answers to questions about death and the meaning of life.

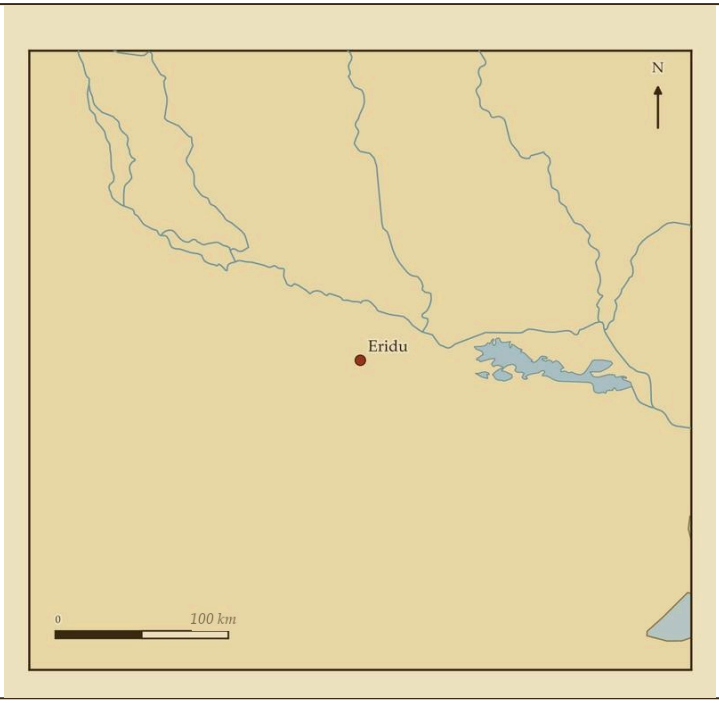
FACTS

According to research, Uruk covered about 5 km² and had about 40,000 inhabitants at its peak, around 3000 BC.

# 09 Eridu

GEN 10:10; 11:2

*One of the oldest cities of Sumer, on the ancient lagoon of the Persian Gulf.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a small town at the edge of the marshes: houses of reed and brick, a small temple on a raised platform, and narrow boats gliding between the reed beds. In the morning mist hangs over the water, and nets dry on the shore. The image is an imagining based on discoveries at Abu Shahrain and on the landscape of the marshes of southern Iraq.

1.9 · ERIDU · GEN 10:10; 11:2

When Genesis describes the descendants of Noah, it says that people journeying from the east found a plain in the land of Shinar and settled there. Shinar is the biblical term for southern Mesopotamia, that is, Sumer and Akkad. One of the first centers there was Eridu, today the ruins of Abu Shahrain. The Sumerians regarded it as the city where settled life first began and where the temple of the god Enki was built. The biblical text does not name it, but it describes the environment in which such cities arose. This shift in the shoreline shows that the landscape described in the Bible was dynamic, and that rivers could create and transform whole regions within a few millennia.

Eridu then lay close to the shoreline of the Persian Gulf, among the marshes and lagoons that filled the mouth of the Euphrates. Today the shoreline is about 200 km farther south, because the rivers deposited enormous amounts of silt. The surroundings were fertile but lacked stone and timber, so the inhabitants traded with the mountains to the north and east. Archaeologists have found here the layers of a temple built successively over many centuries, beginning around 5000 BC. It is not certain whether the biblical author knew Eridu by name, but he undoubtedly knew the whole cultural world to which it belonged.

FACTS

The temple layers at Eridu go back to about 5000 BC, and the present ruins lie about 200 km from the sea.

# 10 Tower of Babel in Babylon

GEN 11:1–9

*A city of brick and pitch, a tower reaching to heaven, and the scattering of languages.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

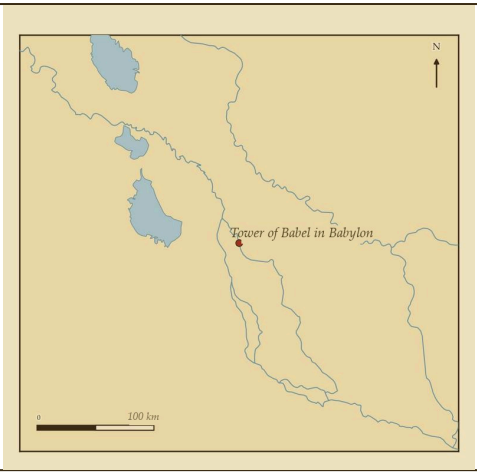
The artistic reconstruction shows an enormous stepped tower of brick rising above the city, with broad ramps and log scaffolding. At its foot is a crowd of workers, carts of bricks, and canals. The Euphrates flows along the edge. The whole is an interpretation based on excavations of ziggurats and descriptions in ancient sources, not a photograph of one particular structure.

The story says that all people had one language and the same words. Having come to the plain of Shinar, they decided to bake bricks, use pitch instead of mortar, and build a city with a tower reaching to heaven, to make a name for themselves and not be scattered over the earth. God comes down to see their work and confuses their speech. The building stops, and the city is named Babel. The text is a warning against the pride of a community that wants to replace God with its own work. Later the prophets and psalmists would refer to Babylon as a symbol of power hostile to God, but also as the place where the people of Israel would live in exile.

A wordplay in the text links the Hebrew word for confusion with the name Babel, that is, Babylon. The city lay on the Euphrates, about 85 km south of present-day Baghdad. The tower recalls the ziggurat Etemenanki, a stepped temple built in Babylon of baked bricks, using bitumen, the natural pitch from springs there. This was how the whole plain built: the lack of stone forced the use of brick. Thanks to this, the biblical author, knowing Babylonian realities, gave the story a distinct local color. For Christian readers, the story of the confusion of languages is completed by the event of Pentecost, in which people of different nations understand one message.

FACTS

Mesopotamian ziggurats usually had from 3 to 7 levels, and the ruins of Babylon lie about 85 km from Baghdad.


N
Tower of Babel in Babylon
0
100 km

# 11 Ur of the Chaldeans

GEN 11:27–31

*Abram's hometown, on the Euphrates, with a great temple of the moon.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a city with a broad ziggurat on a mound, surrounded by compact brick buildings and date palms. A merchant with a donkey walks along a street, and in the background the sun shines over the Euphrates. The image is based on the excavations at Ur, including the preserved base of the ziggurat. The figures are small and seen from a distance, and the details of clothing are conjectural.

Chapter 11 moves from the story of peoples to the history of a single family. Terah, his sons Abram, Nahor, and Haran, and Abram's wife Sarai live in Ur of the Chaldeans. Haran dies in his native city, and Terah sets out with part of the family toward Canaan, but stops in Haran and dies there. For the reader this is an important moment: from the universal story of humankind, the Bible narrows down to one clan, from which the people of Israel will develop. This lets us see that Abram's call meant giving up a secure, prosperous life in one of the most advanced cities in the world.

Ur lay on the Euphrates in southern Mesopotamia and was one of the largest urban centers of its age. Excavations revealed the ziggurat of the moon god Nanna, rich royal tombs, and tablets with commercial records. Its inhabitants traded wool, grain, and metals with distant lands. According to the records, Ur flourished around 2100 BC, so the probable time of Abram corresponds to the period of the city's greatness. The very name of the Chaldeans appears later, which scholars explain as an updating of the name for the reader. This gives his journey a believable and human dimension: he was leaving a home that offered security, not ruins or a village.

FACTS

The ziggurat at Ur had a base of about 64 × 45 m, and the city lies about 300 km from the Persian Gulf along the ancient shoreline.


N
Ur of the Chaldeans
0
100 km

# 12 Haran

GEN 11:31–32; 12:4

*A city on a trade route, where Terah's family stops.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Artistic reconstruction: imagine an open plain with a walled city, a well, and a trail along which caravans with donkeys travel. The area is dry, but green along the river. Flocks graze around the city, and in the evening women draw water from the well.

1.12 · HARAN · GEN 11:31–32; 12:4

After leaving Ur, Terah's family reaches Haran and decides to stay there. Terah dies at the age of two hundred and five. In the next chapter God calls Abram to leave his country and his father's house, and promises him blessing and descendants. Abram, seventy-five years old, sets out with his wife Sarai, his nephew Lot, and his possessions. Haran thus becomes the last stop before the real journey to Canaan and the beginning of the story of the covenant. Israelite tradition remembered Haran as the home of Nahor's family and the place from which Isaac and Jacob would seek wives, which shows the lasting strength of family ties.

Haran lay on the Balikh River, a tributary of the Euphrates, in northern Mesopotamia. Trade routes linking Mesopotamia with Syria and Anatolia passed through the city, so it was an important caravan center. The distance from Ur to Haran is about 900 km in a straight line, and the journey along the Euphrates took many weeks. The city was also a center of worship of the moon god, like Ur. Today it lies near the Turkish-Syrian border, and in the area stand characteristic dome-shaped brick houses. In this way the city becomes a bridge between the primeval history at the beginning of the Bible and the history of the patriarchs, to which the next part of the atlas is devoted.

FACTS

The road from Ur to Haran is about 900 km in a straight line; Haran lies about 40 km from Şanlıurfa.

# Questions for Reflection

1. Why does the author of Genesis describe creation in an orderly rhythm of days, and what does this orderly form say about trust in God as Creator?

2. How does knowing about Mesopotamia, its rivers, its brick, and its ziggurats change the way you read the stories of the flood and the Tower of Babel?

3. What does the move from the story of all humanity to the history of one family, that of Terah and Abram, mean for you?

# 02

PART 2 OF 9

# The Patriarchs

GEN 12–50

*From Ur of the Chaldeans to Goshen in Egypt: the journey of a family that carried a promise.*



PART 2 · GEN 12–50

# The Fathers of Faith on the Road

From the twelfth chapter of Genesis, the story changes scale. Instead of the history of all humanity, we read about one family that sets out from southern Mesopotamia and crosses the Fertile Crescent as far as the Nile delta. Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, and Joseph do not live in a misty land of legends, but beside real wells, on hills, at river fords, and along caravan routes. This part of the atlas shows that the story of the patriarchs is also the story of a landscape, where shepherds searched for water, pasture, and safety for their flocks.

Imagine a world where the boundary is not walls but the distance to the nearest spring. The patriarchs moved with their tents and flocks along the strip of land between desert and sea, avoiding the mighty city-states. They traveled along the watershed of the hills of Judea and Samaria, went down to the Negev in the dry season, and in times of famine looked for grain along the Nile. Such a life required trust, skill in negotiating with neighbors, and a memory of the places where water had once been found.

In this part you will visit twelve places and follow four maps. You will see Ur, Haran, and Shechem, the oak at Mamre, the area around the Dead Sea, Bethel, the ford of the Jabbok, Dothan, and Egypt. Remember that the locations of some places are traditional, and the reconstructions are artistic interpretations based on archaeological knowledge of the Bronze Age. Distances are given as approximations. This will help you understand why the promise given to one family was tied to this very land and this very road.

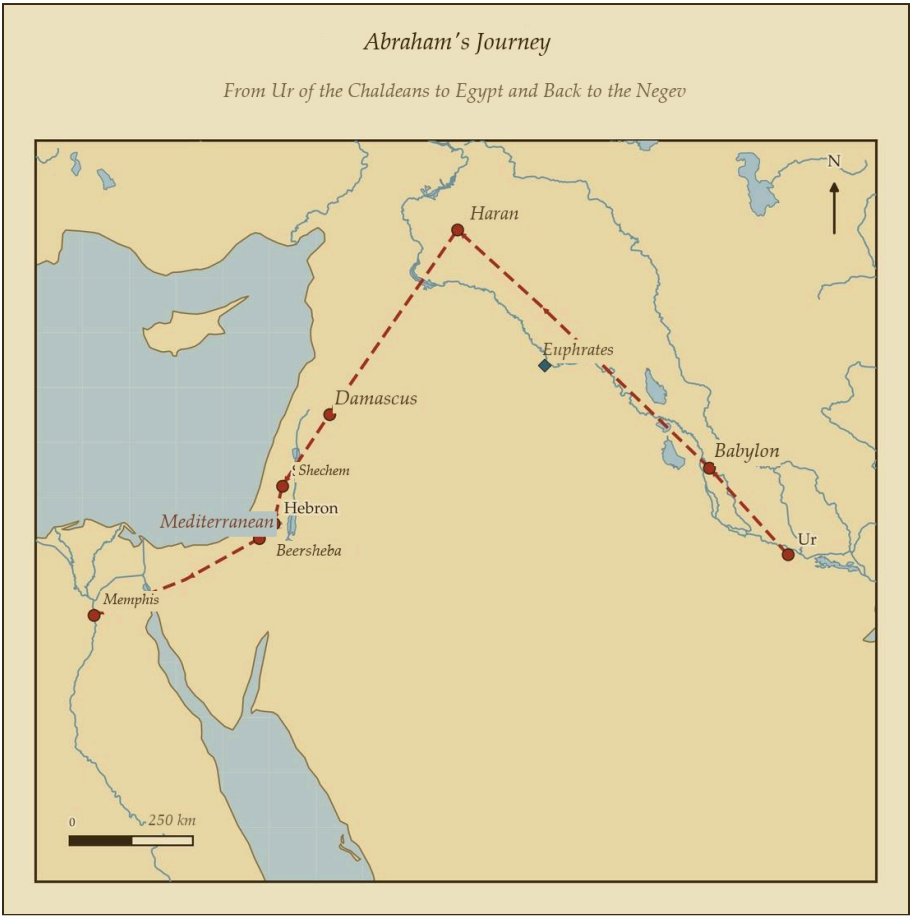
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HOW TO USE THIS ATLAS

The maps show routes and the locations of places; the illustrations are artistic reconstructions based on archaeological knowledge, not photographs. Distances and dimensions are approximate.

MAP 2.1




*The first route shows the road from southern Mesopotamia along the Euphrates through Haran and Damascus to Shechem. The second leads from Canaan to Egypt, where Abram seeks grain during a famine.*

The map compares the scale of two stages of Abraham's life. The first is a journey of over 1,500 km around the Fertile Crescent, which arcs around the Syrian desert. The second is a shorter trip of about 500 km through the Negev and Sinai to the delta of the

Nile. In both cases the road runs from spring to spring. All routes are approximate, because the Bible gives no details of the way, and the identification of some places is traditional.

MAP 2.2

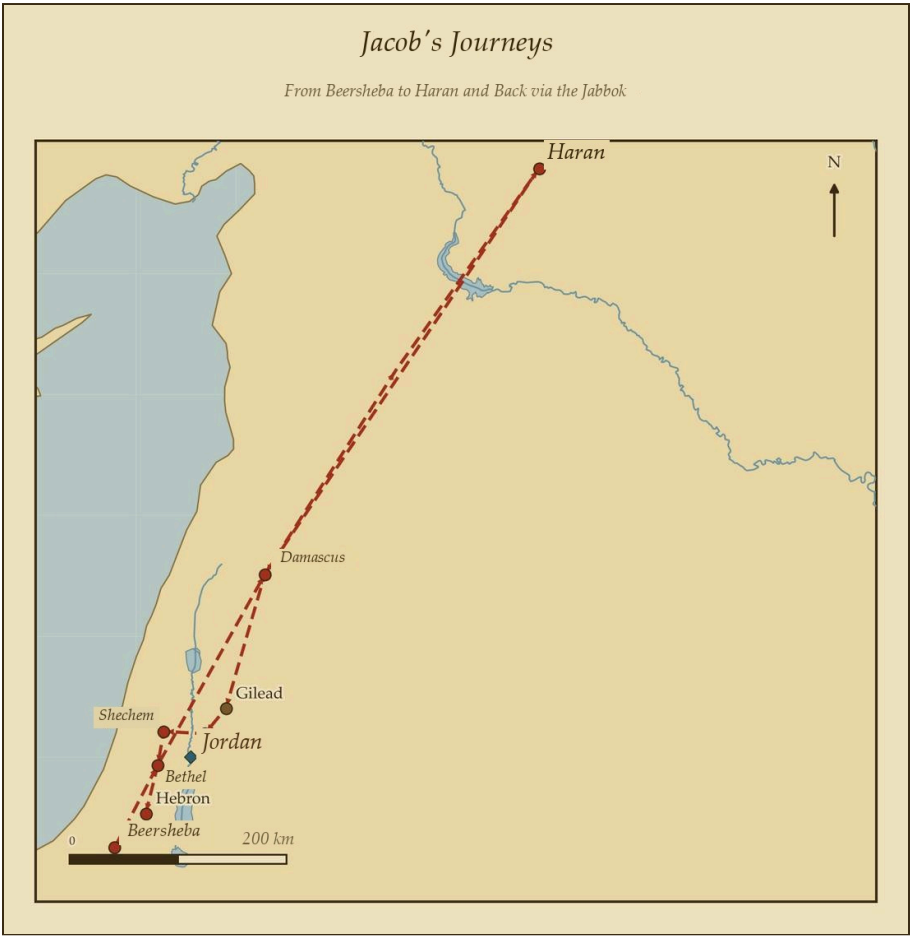



*The line shows the main road along the mountain ridge from Shechem in the north to Beersheba in the south. The Dead Sea lies to the east, in a deep rift valley.*

This map shows that all the important places in the lives of Abraham and Isaac lie within a stretch of less than 120 km. The family kept to the higher parts of the hills, where rainfall was greater and the road was safe. To the east the land dropped steeply into the

Jordan Rift, and to the south the Negev began. It is easy to see how small this territory is compared with the vast distances the patriarchs had earlier traveled in Mesopotamia.

MAP 2.3

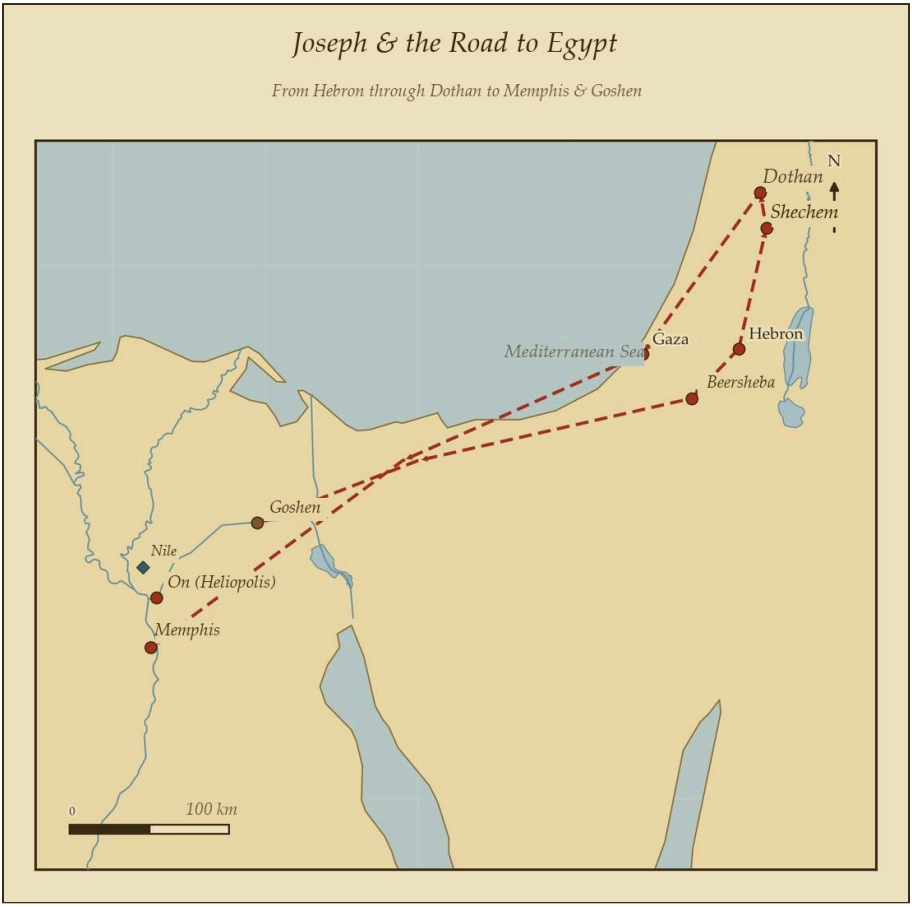



*The first line shows Jacob's flight north from Esau. The second shows his return years later through Gilead, the ford of the Jabbok, and Shechem as far as Hebron.*

Jacob travels about 1,500 km in each direction. The map shows that the return skirts the Jordan on the east, through Gilead, rather than taking the shortest route across the desert. This brings Jacob into Canaan from the side of the Jabbok, where the night trial awaits

him. Bethel, Shechem, and Hebron mark the successive stages of the return to his father's house. The routes are only indicative, since the biblical text mentions just some of the stopping places.

MAP 2.4



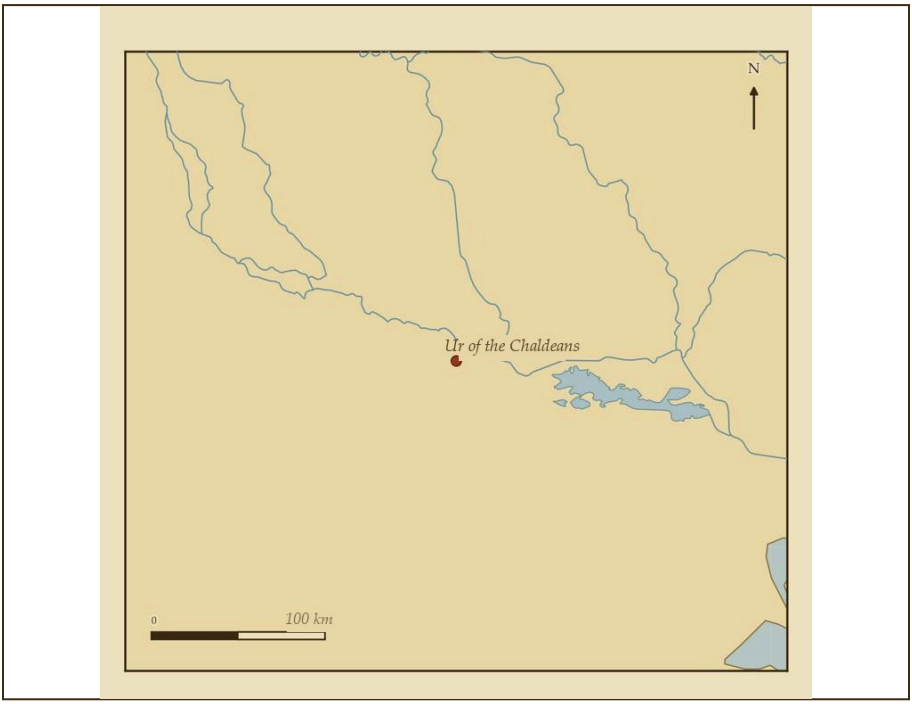

*The first route shows Joseph's journey from his father's house through Dothan along the coastal road to Memphis. The second takes Jacob from Hebron through Beersheba to the land of Goshen.*

The map shows that Egypt lay relatively close to Canaan: from Hebron to Goshen it is about 400 km, roughly two weeks on foot. The route along the coast and across northern Sinai was well known to merchants, and Egypt also drew Canaanites in times of famine. This allowed Jacob's family to find refuge quickly and keep its bond with the land of their fathers. The routes are approximate.

# 01 Ur of the Chaldeans

GEN 11:27–12:3

*From here Abram sets out at the call of a voice that promises him a land and a great nation.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a city of sun-dried and baked brick, surrounded by grain fields and date palms. Above the rooftops rises a multi-tiered temple tower called a ziggurat, visible from afar on the flat plain. Narrow streets wind between houses with courtyards, and canals link the districts to the river. Reed and wooden boats loaded with goods are moored at the quay. At Ur, archaeologists have uncovered rich tombs and buildings from the early third and second millennia before Christ.

Terah's family comes from Ur of the Chaldeans. According to Genesis, Terah leads his household out, including his son Abram, his grandson Lot, and his daughter-in-law Sarai, and heads toward Canaan. The journey stops at Haran, however, where the family settles. Only there does Abram hear the call to leave his native land and his father's house, and in return receives the promise of descendants, blessing, and a land. The text does not describe the reasons for the departure, but it shows that the decision meant a break with his entire social background.

Ur lay in southern Mesopotamia, near the old bed of the Euphrates, not far from the ancient shore of the Persian Gulf. The area was flat, irrigated by canals, and very fertile, so the city grew rich on trade and farming. The road northwest ran along the Euphrates, through Babylonia and on toward Syria. This route was over a thousand kilometers long and gave constant access to water, but it also meant passing the settlements of rulers who collected tolls from caravans. The family's journey was therefore an undertaking that required careful planning.

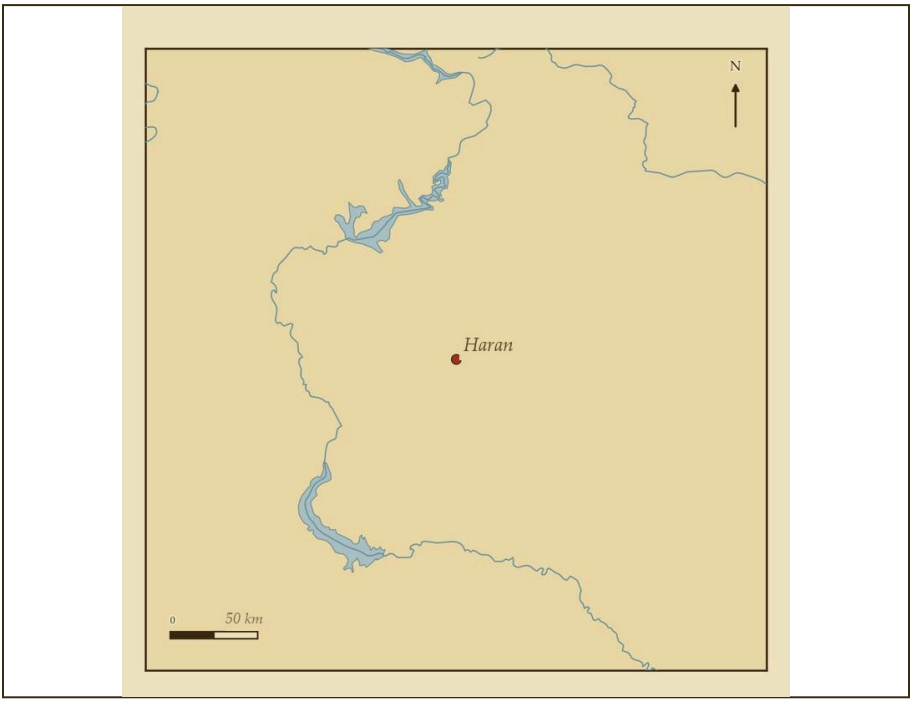
FACTS

Distance Ur–Haran along the Euphrates: about 1,000–1,200 km.

# 02 Haran

GEN 11:31–12:5

*A city in northern Mesopotamia, where Abram stays until his father's death and from which he moves on.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a fortified town on a gently raised plain, with walls of brick and stone and a cluster of houses around a temple. Fields and pastures stretch all around, and shepherds with sheep gather at the wells. Paths converge at the city gate, where donkey caravans unload their goods. In winter a cold wind blows here, and in summer the heat is severe. Important trade routes passed through the city.

Haran is a resting place that becomes a starting point. When Terah dies, Abram takes his wife Sarai, his nephew Lot, all the possessions they had gathered, and the people they had acquired in Haran, and heads south. The biblical tradition calls the surrounding region Aram Naharaim, the land by the rivers. Abraham's servant later seeks a wife for Isaac here, and Jacob flees here from the anger of his brother Esau. For generations, then, the family keeps ties with this land and remembers its roots.

Haran lay on the Balikh River, a tributary of the Euphrates, in what is now northern Syria and southern Turkey. The climate is semi-arid, yet the gentle hills and plains offer good pasture for sheep and goats. The city stood at the crossroads of routes leading to Anatolia, Syria, and Mesopotamia, which made it an important trading center. From here the road to Canaan ran through Aleppo and Damascus, about 800–900 km long. For slow-moving flocks, that meant a journey of several weeks.

Most scholars identify Haran with the modern city of Harran in Turkey.

FACTS

Haran to Shechem: about 700–800 km in a straight line, and more by road.

# 03 Shechem

GEN 12:6–7; 33:18–20; 34

*Abram's first stop in Canaan, between Mount Gerizim and Mount Ebal.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a narrow valley with two steep mountains on either side. An olive grove grows at their feet, and on a hillock stands a walled town with a gate tower. Beside the road, shepherds water their flocks at a well. In the distance, rocky slopes with sparse vegetation can be seen on the summits. In spring the valley is green, and in summer dry and golden. The patriarch's tents stand off to one side, outside the town walls.

After arriving in Canaan, Abram passes through the land as far as a place called Shechem, near the great tree of Moreh. Canaanites live there at that time. At this place God renews the promise of the land to his offspring, and the patriarch builds an altar. Many years later Jacob, returning from Haran, pitches his camp before the city and buys a plot of land from the sons of Hamor. Chapter 34 tells of a conflict that erupts after the violation of Dinah and leads to violence by Jacob's sons. Shechem thus remains a place of both promise and painful memory.

Shechem lies in a valley between two mountains, Gerizim and Ebal, which rise several hundred meters above it. The main north–south road runs through this spot along the ridge of the hills of Ephraim, easier and safer than the lowland routes where the city-states held sway. Abundant springs provided water, and the slopes favored the growing of olives and grain. It was therefore a natural place for shepherds to stop. From Shechem to Bethel it is about 30 km to the south, a day or two of travel with flocks.

The name Shechem is linked with present-day Tell Balata near Nablus.

FACTS

Height of the mountains: Gerizim about 881 m above sea level, Ebal about 940 m.

# 04 Mamre near Hebron

GEN 13:18; 18:1–15

*Under a great tree, Abraham welcomes three mysterious guests.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

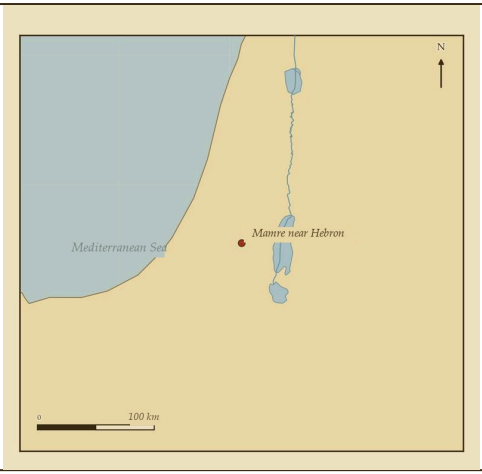
The artistic reconstruction depicts a hot noon. An old, spreading oak casts deep shade over a tent of black goat hair. An elderly man sits in front of it, and in the distance three figures approach. Sheep and goats graze all around, and vineyards and olive trees grow on the hillside. The air shimmers with heat, the ground is dry, and the sky is faded. All of it unfolds in the stillness of a pastoral afternoon.

After parting from Lot, Abram moves his tents to the grove of Mamre near Hebron and builds an altar there. In the heat of noon, as he sits at the entrance of his tent, he sees three men. He runs to meet them, bows low, has water brought to wash their feet, and asks Sarah to bake bread. The meal consists of milk, curds, and veal. The guests announce that in a year Sarah will bear a son. Sarah, hearing this at the tent, laughs, and the name Isaac will recall that laughter. Christian tradition sees in the scene hospitality as a virtue.

Hebron lies at an elevation of about 900 m above sea level, on the watershed of the hills of Judea, where rainfall is higher than in the desert and the soils suit the growing of grapes and olives. Winters can be cool, and in summer the altitude eases the heat. The ridge road linking Beersheba with Jerusalem passes through the area, about 70 km long. Ancient trees gave shade, and wells and pastures made it possible to sustain large flocks. Mamre was therefore an ideal place for the family's permanent camp, safely far from the great cities.

FACTS

Hebron lies about 900 m above sea level, about 30 km south of Jerusalem.


N
Mamre near Hebron
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

# 05 Sodom and Gomorrah by the Dead Sea

GEN 13:10–13; 18:16–19:29

*The Jordan Valley that Lot chose ends in the catastrophe of the cities of the plain.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows the valley at dawn, seen from a high ridge. Below, the smooth surface of a salt sea gleams, ringed by white salt deposits and bare cliffs. A streak of dark smoke rises from the plain. Closer by is a stony path, and on it a lone figure looks down, back turned. The air is thick with mist, and the light of the rising sun reddens the rocks on the far side.

## 2.5 · SODOM AND GOMORRAH BY THE DEAD SEA · GEN 13:10–13; 18,16-19,29

When the herdsmen of Abram and Lot begin to quarrel over pasture, Abram proposes that they part. Lot chooses the well-watered plain of the Jordan, which reminds him of a garden, and pitches his tents near Sodom. The inhabitants of the city are described as cruel to strangers. Abraham pleads with God on their behalf, but there are too few righteous people. Lot flees with his daughters, and the cities of Sodom and Gomorrah are destroyed. In the morning Abraham looks down from the height and sees smoke rising like smoke from a furnace. The story has a moral dimension, not a tourist one.

The Jordan Valley is the lowest place on earth: the shore of the Dead Sea lies about 430 m below sea level. The climate here is hot and dry, and the water of the sea contains about ten times more salt than the ocean. Natural bitumen and sulfur occur in the area, which explains the biblical images of fire and tar. From Hebron to the shore of the lakes is about 40 km down the slopes, which explains how Abraham could watch the valley from a height. The exact location of the cities is uncertain; tradition places them at the south or east of the sea.

### FACTS

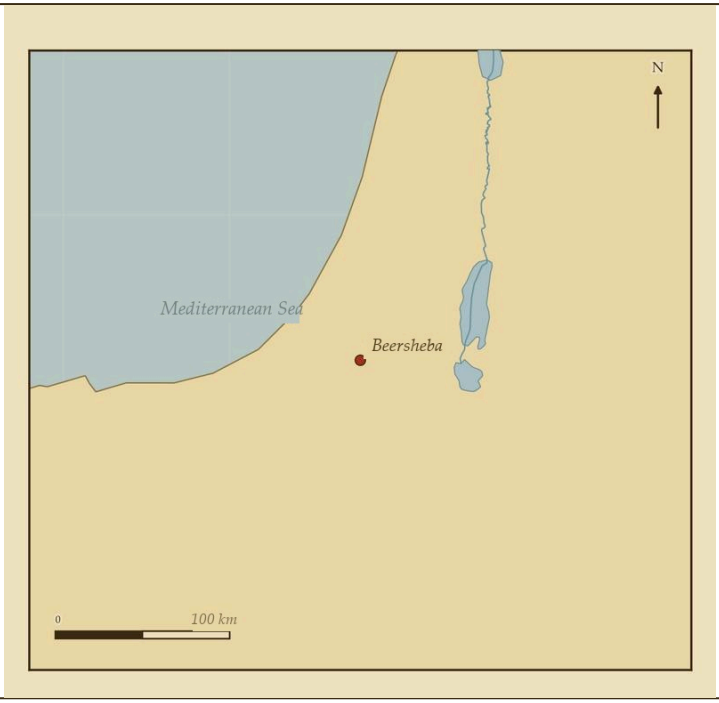
Level of the Dead Sea: about 430 m below sea level; length of the sea about 50 km.


N
Mediterranean Sea
Sodom & Gomorrah on the Dead Sea
0
100 km

# 06 Beersheba

GEN 21:22–34; 22; 26:23–33

*The well of the oath on the edge of the desert, an important stop for Abraham and Isaac.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a wide, bright plain under a cloudless sky. In the middle is a stone well with a wooden windlass and troughs for the animals. A lone tamarisk grows nearby, and sheep graze all around. Low sand-colored hills trace the horizon, and beyond them lies dry steppe. Shepherds draw water in leather buckets and talk at the edge of the stone well curb.

The name Beersheba is associated with a well and an oath. Abimelech, the ruler from the region of Gerar, and his commander make a treaty with Abraham in which they recognize his right to the well he dug with his own hands. The patriarch plants a tamarisk tree and calls on the name of the Lord. From here he sets out for the mountain pointed out for the sacrifice of Isaac. Many years later Isaac reopens the wells that had been filled in and receives a promise of support. Here the well means life, property rights, and peace with neighbors.

Beersheba lies where the Negev meets the cultivated belt, at a spot where annual rainfall is only about 200 mm. Access to a well therefore decided whether flocks survived. This area was the southern edge of the permanently settled land, hence the later phrase "from Dan to Beersheba." The road to Hebron is about 45 km long and runs across dry hills. Shepherds traveled it seasonally, seeking grass after the winter rains. The site of Tel Sheva lies a few kilometers from the modern city.

FACTS

Beersheba to Hebron: about 45 km; rainfall about 200 mm per year.

# 07 Machpelah in Hebron

GEN 23; 25:7–10; 49:29–32

*The only piece of land Abraham ever buys, to bury Sarah.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a field on a hillside, with a row of olive trees and a low stone wall. In a rock face opens the narrow entrance of a cave, covered by a flat boulder. Below runs a road leading to a town with flat stone roofs. In the setting sun everything takes on a golden hue. The atmosphere is quiet, full of solemnity and mourning.

Sarah dies in Kiriath Arba, that is, in Hebron. Abraham, as a foreigner, has no tomb of his own. He stands before the assembly of the city's inhabitants and asks to buy one. Ephron offers the field together with the cave, but the patriarch insists on settling the price, so that the matter is honestly sealed. He pays four hundred shekels of silver, and the transaction takes place publicly, at the city gate. This is how the family tomb comes about, in which Abraham, Isaac, Rebekah, Leah, and Jacob would later be laid.

Hebron lies about 30 km south of Jerusalem, at an elevation of about 900 m, in one of the oldest centers of settlement in Judea. The area is hilly, rocky, and full of natural limestone caves, which often served as tombs. Tradition locates Machpelah beneath a structure from the time of Herod, which to this day encloses a site revered by Jews, Christians, and Muslims. The Herodian wall is about 60 m long and clearly visible. The exact layout of the caves remains closed to full archaeological study.

FACTS

Price of the field about 400 shekels of silver; Hebron about 900 m above sea level.

# 08 Bethel – Jacob's Dream

GEN 28:10–22; 35:1–15

*A fugitive sleeps on a stone and sees heaven open over the earth.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows an evening sky over a stony hill. A lone figure sleeps on the ground, head on a flat stone, seen from a great distance. Above, a bright streak of light parts the clouds, forming a fan of rays descending toward the earth. Boulders lie all around, and a few thorny shrubs grow. Far below, a gentle valley looms. The air holds the warm night after a hot day.

Jacob sets out from Beersheba for Haran, to escape his brother's vengeance and to find a wife among relatives. When dusk falls, he stops for the night, lays his head on a stone, and dreams of a ladder. Angels ascend and descend, and God renews the promise given to Abraham and Isaac. On waking, Jacob sets up the stone as a memorial, anoints it with oil, and names the place Bethel. Years later he returns here at God's command to fulfill his vow.

Bethel lies on the ridge of the hills of central Palestine, about 17 km north of Jerusalem, at an elevation of about 880 m above sea level. The stony terrain, sparse trees, and lack of convenient shelter meant that a lone traveler slept under the open sky. The ridge road linked Hebron with Shechem and was the main route of Palestine. Jacob covered about 100 km from Beersheba to Bethel, which corresponds to several days of travel. The identification with the village of Beitin is widely accepted.

FACTS

Bethel: about 880 m above sea level, about 17 km north of Jerusalem.


N
Bethel: Jacob's Dream
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

# 09 Jabbok and Penuel

GEN 32:23–33

*A night struggle at the ford of the Jabbok changes Jacob's name to Israel.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

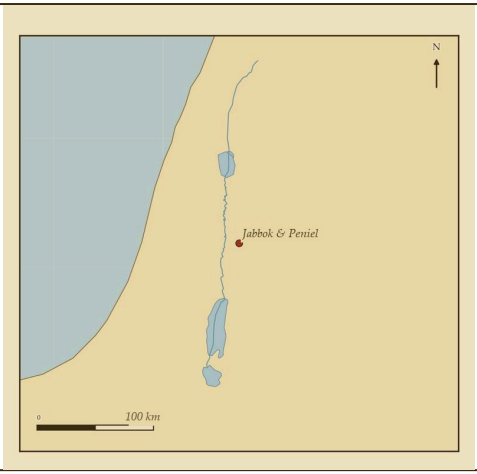
The artistic reconstruction shows a deep ravine at dusk. Shallow, swift water flows between stony banks, and on the far side a herd of animals and a few tents can be seen. In the foreground, in the gloom, two dark figures are locked in a struggle, visible from afar. The sky in the east brightens, heralding dawn. Oleander bushes cover the slopes, and the chill of night hangs in the air.

Returning after years from Haran, Jacob learns that Esau is coming to meet him with four hundred men. In the night he sends his wives, children, and possessions across the ford of the Jabbok, and stays alone on the other side. There he wrestles until dawn with a mysterious figure, who touches his hip and changes the patriarch's name to Israel. In the morning Jacob names the place Penuel, because he has seen God face to face, and he limps for the rest of his life. The next day he meets his brother in reconciliation.

The Jabbok, today the Zarqa River, is a tributary of the Jordan flowing from the hills of Gilead in the east. The river cuts into a deep, rocky ravine, and in the dry season it can be crossed in several places. Penuel stood near the ford, about 10 km east of the Jordan. From Haran to Penuel it is about 600 km in a straight line, so the journey with flocks took many weeks. The exact location is uncertain; Tulul edh-Dhahab on the lower course of the river is often suggested.

FACTS

The Jabbok is about 100 km long; Penuel lies about 10 km east of the Jordan.


N
Jabbok & Peniel
0
100 km

# 10 Dothan

GEN 37:12–36

*Near cisterns and a caravan route, the brothers sell Joseph.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a green valley beneath gentle hills. Flocks of sheep graze on the slopes, and in the distance a group of shepherds stands under a tree. From the other side of the valley a caravan of camels approaches, loaded with sacks and jars. In the foreground is the stone opening of a cistern, partly hidden by bushes. The light is sharp, afternoon light, and the shadows are long.

Jacob sends Joseph from Hebron to check on how his brothers are doing. Joseph goes by way of Shechem and learns that the flocks have moved on to Dothan. The brothers see him from afar, dressed in his distinctive robe, and decide to be rid of him. They throw him into an empty cistern. When a caravan of Ishmaelite merchants passes by, they pull Joseph out and sell him for twenty pieces of silver. They bring their father the bloodstained robe, and he sinks into mourning.

Dothan lies in a valley north of Shechem, about 25 km in a straight line. Through it passed the road linking the Jezreel Valley with the coast and on to Egypt, so caravans with balm and resin traveled this way regularly. The valley has fertile pastures ringed by hills, and cisterns were hewn in the rock to store water. From Hebron to Dothan is about 100 km, and to Egypt over 400 km. Tell Dothan has been explored archaeologically and shows Bronze Age settlement.

FACTS

Dothan–Hebron: about 100 km; Joseph's sale price about 20 pieces of silver.



# 11 Egypt and Memphis

GEN 39–41

*A slave from Canaan becomes the steward of the granaries of the land on the Nile.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

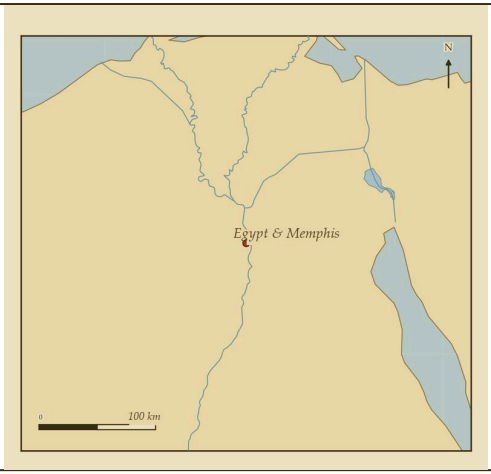
The artistic reconstruction shows the broad Nile, with sailing barges gliding along it, and green fields on both banks. Beyond them stretch the desert and low pyramids in the hazy distance. Along the quay stand long granaries of mud brick, and workers carry baskets of grain. On a palace terrace a small figure stands with its back turned, watching the work. The air is warm and bright, smelling of water and straw.

In Egypt, Joseph works in the house of Potiphar, a courtier of Pharaoh. He is falsely accused and lands in prison, where he interprets the dreams of two officials. When Pharaoh has troubling dreams about cows and ears of grain, Joseph is remembered. The young Hebrew explains that after seven plentiful years seven years of famine will come. Pharaoh entrusts him with overseeing the storing of grain, gives him an Egyptian name, and raises him to high office. The text stresses that Joseph's rise comes from wisdom and God's good care.

Egypt depended on the yearly flooding of the Nile, which deposited fertile silt on the fields. When the flood was too low or too high, famine and disaster threatened. Memphis, at the apex of the delta, was an important center of administration and trade. From it to the Mediterranean coast is about 200 km. Granaries stored grain in clay-and-brick silos, and officials recorded the supplies. The biblical text does not give the name of the pharaoh, so the exact dating of the events remains a subject of research.

FACTS

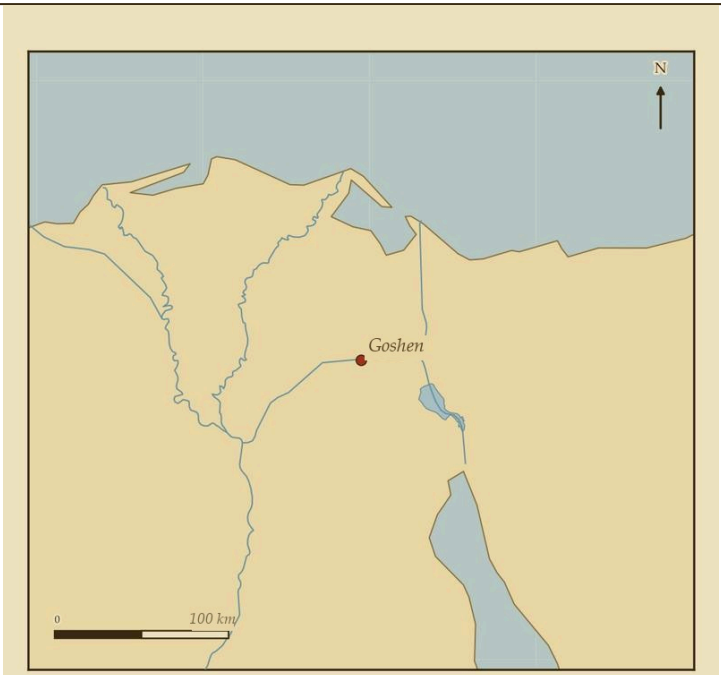
Memphis–Mediterranean Sea: about 200 km; the Nile flood lasted several months.


N
Egypt & Memphis
0
100 km

# 12 Goshen

GEN 45:9–11; 46:28–34; 47:1–12

*A region in the eastern Nile delta, where Jacob's family settles.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a flat, green plain crisscrossed by canals. Flocks of sheep and cattle graze beside rows of palms, and in the background enclosures of reed and clay can be seen. The shepherds wear simple, light robes. The air is humid and the sky wide. On the horizon the low dunes of the desert take shape, separated from the region by a sharp band of green.

Years later, Joseph reveals himself to his brothers and asks them to bring their father. Jacob sets out from Beersheba with his whole family, and on the way receives God's assurance of care. Joseph goes out to meet him and presents him to Pharaoh. The ruler assigns the settlers the land of Goshen as the best region for their flocks. This is how a community begins that will grow from seventy persons into a nation. Genesis ends with the death of Joseph and the promise that God will bring his descendants back to Canaan.

Goshen is usually located in the eastern part of the Nile delta, in the Wadi Tumilat, about 100 km from Memphis toward the Sinai Peninsula. It was a strip of well-watered meadows, ideal for sheep and cattle, and at the same time close to the border, so it was easy to move flocks from Canaan. The road from Beersheba across Sinai is about 250 km, or a dozen or so days of travel. The exact boundaries of the region are uncertain, and the identification rests on tradition and analysis of routes.

FACTS

Goshen lies about 100 km from Memphis; the road from Beersheba is about 250 km.

# Questions for Reflection

1. Why could Abraham trust the promise without knowing the destination of his journey, and what in your life requires a similar trust in an unknown road?

2. How do the wells, trees, and caves in the stories of the patriarchs point to the value of hospitality, peace with neighbors, and remembering our ancestors?

3. What changes in the story of Joseph when we recognize that the road from Dothan to Egypt was a trade route, not a mysterious expedition into the unknown?

# 03

PART 3 OF 9

# Egypt, the Exodus and the Wilderness

EXOD, NUM, DEUT

*From the grain fields of the Nile Delta, across the rocky paths of Sinai, to the threshold of the Promised Land.*



# The Road That Shaped a People

Imagine a world where water is life and the desert is the boundary. The Egypt of the Book of Exodus is the land of the Nile: each year the river floods and leaves fertile silt, and the delta becomes a mosaic of fields, canals and cities full of storehouses. Here, among the brickyards and granaries, lived the descendants of Jacob, ever more numerous and ever more burdened with forced labor. Exod 1–2 shows a state that needs hands to build, yet fears the very people who supply them. Geography and politics are intertwined from the first chapter.

Beyond the eastern border of the delta, a completely different world begins. The Sinai Peninsula is a triangle of desert, narrow wadis and granite massifs, where the daily struggle is for water and shade. The Exodus from Egypt is therefore not a simple journey but a passage between two orders: from an organized state to a place where everything must be received as a gift. The books of Exodus, Numbers and Deuteronomy describe this march in stages, naming dozens of stopping places. Some of them we know fairly well today; others remain puzzles for scholars.

In this atlas we follow the route step by step. For each place we give the coordinates of the traditional or most widely accepted identification, and where scholars disagree, we say so openly. This applies especially to the Sea of Reeds, Mount Sinai and many of the stops in the wilderness. The illustrations are artistic reconstructions based on archaeological and geographical knowledge, not photographs of the past. Distances and numbers are marked “approx.” because ancient sources do not give them with modern precision. In this way the map and the text will help you see how the shape of the land influences the course of the events described.

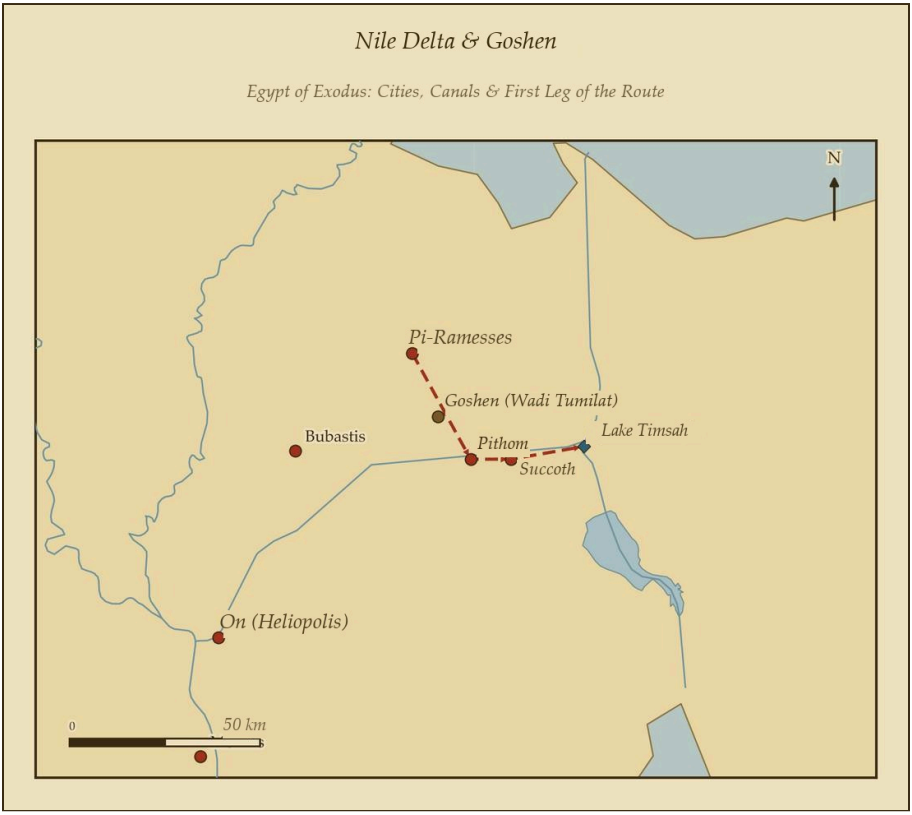
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HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

The maps show routes and the locations of places; the illustrations are artistic reconstructions based on archaeological knowledge, not photographs. Distances and dimensions are approximate.

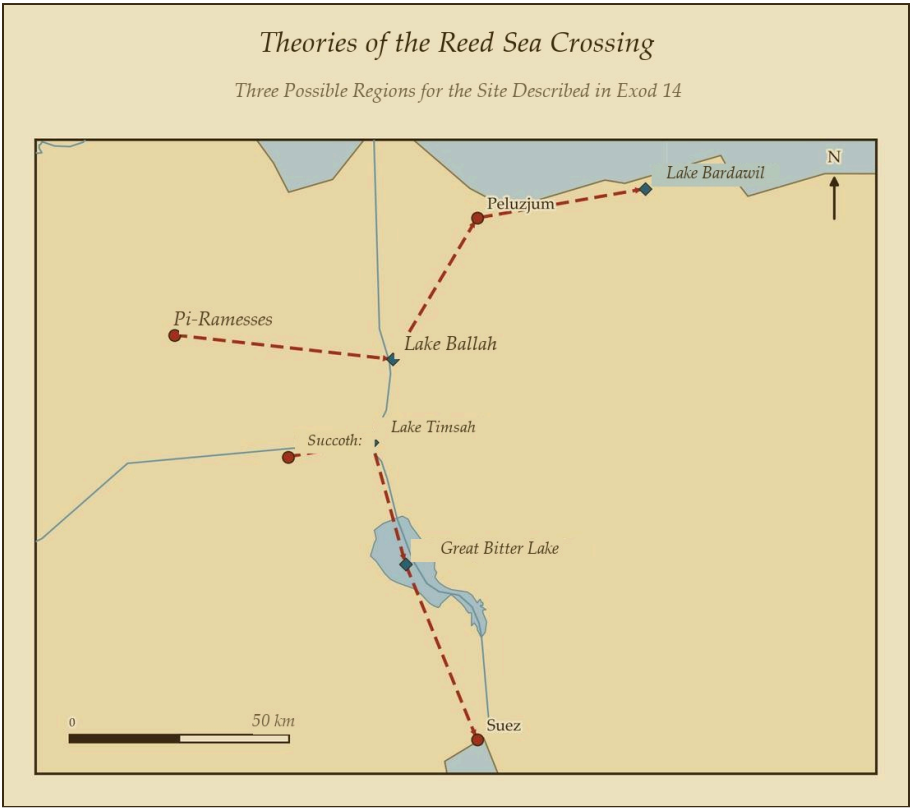
MAP 3.1




*The dots mark cities and places mentioned in the Book of Exodus, and the line shows the probable beginning of the route. Many locations are debated.*

The map shows the eastern part of the Nile Delta, the region where, according to Exod 1–12, the Israelites lived. Note the Wadi Tumilat, a narrow corridor leading from the Nile toward the Bitter Lakes. It is a natural route east, along which store cities and camps lay. The distances on the map are small, approx. 50 km between Pi-Rameses and Succoth, but for a group with children and flocks they meant several days of walking.

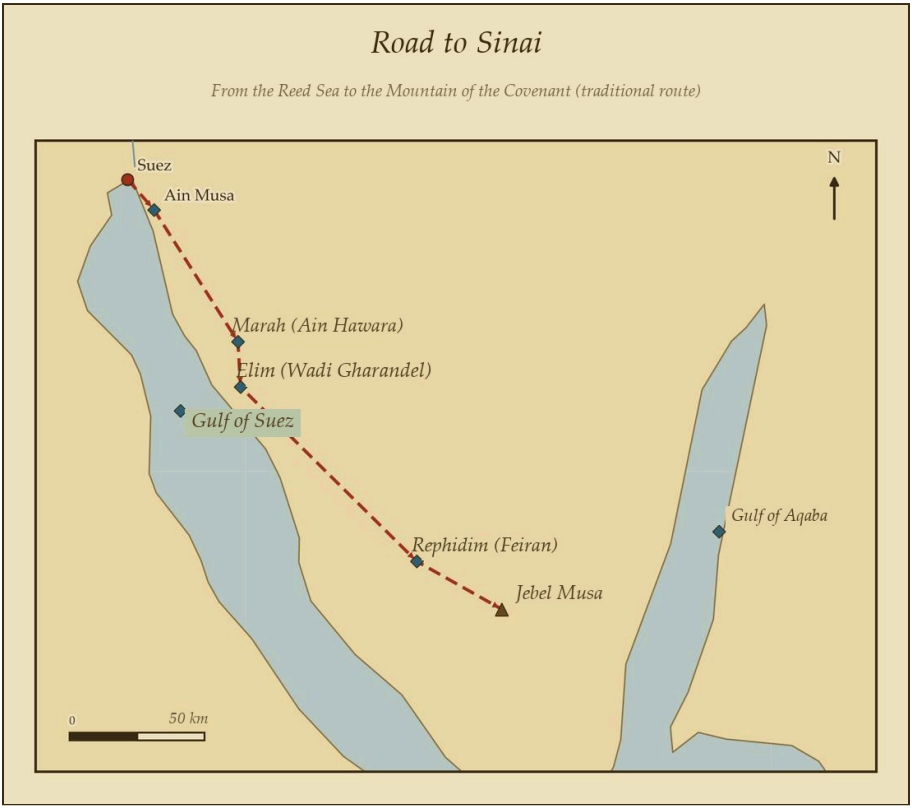
MAP 3.2




*The two lines show alternative route proposals by scholars, not an established course of events. The waters are marked approximately.*

This map sorts out the main hypotheses about the Sea of Reeds. The northern route leads toward the lakes near the Mediterranean coast, the central one through the area of Lake Timsah and the Bitter Lakes, and the southern one toward the Gulf of Suez. Since ancient times the water level and the shape of the coastline have changed, so today's map does not show that landscape exactly. The most important thing is to understand that the dispute concerns the location, not the message of the story.

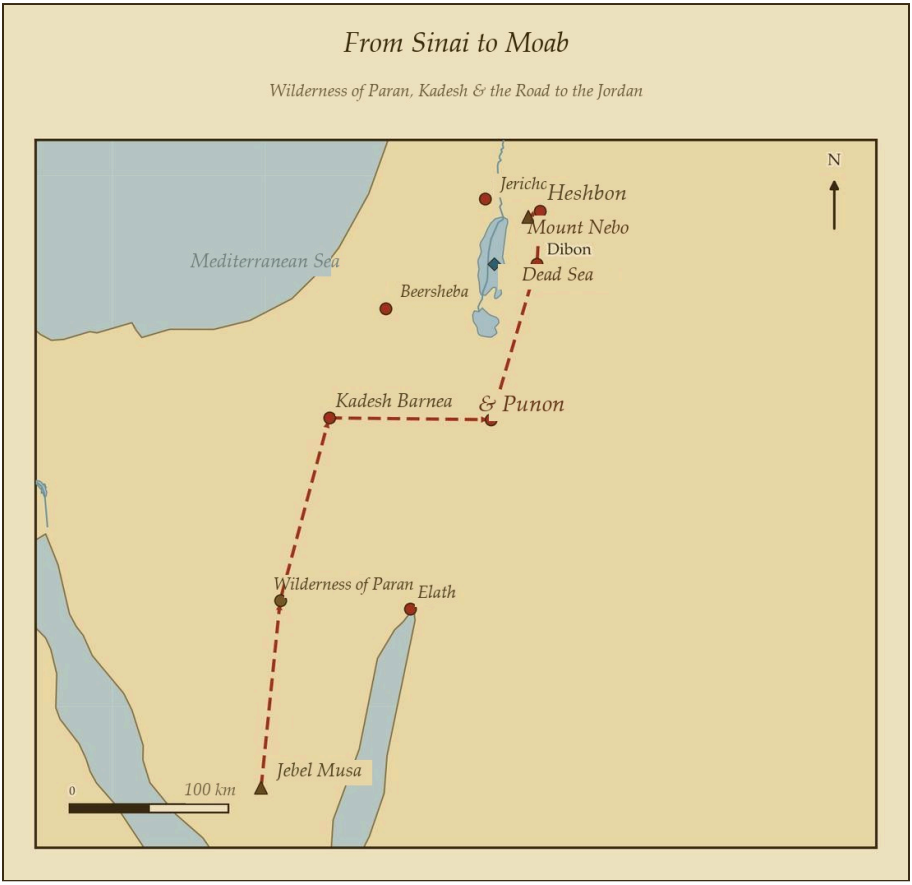
MAP 3.3




*The line shows the traditional route through southern Sinai, from Suez to Jebel Musa. Alternative locations of Sinai would mean a different course.*

The map shows how the road leads from oasis to oasis: from the bitter water at Marah, through the palms at Elim, to Feiran at the foot of the mountains. The terrain gradually rises, and the landscape changes from flat to mountainous. Jebel Musa is approx. 2,285 m above sea level. Remember that this is only one hypothesis: some scholars look for Sinai in the north of the peninsula or in Arabia.

MAP 3.4




*The first line leads from Sinai through Paran to Kadesh, the second from Kadesh along Edom and Moab to Mount Nebo. The routes are approximate.*

The map shows the final stages of the journey. From Kadesh the people did not go straight into the land, but turned east, going around Edom and Moab (Num 20–21). The text names many stops that we cannot identify with certainty, so the route is simplified. Note how close Nebo and Jericho are: about 25 km apart in a straight line, with the Jordan Valley between them.

# 01 Pi-Rameses, the City of Rameses

EXOD 1; 12

*The great capital of the delta, where the Israelites worked building storehouses and cities.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Imagine a wide, flat plain dotted with fields and canals. On the horizon rise temple gates faced with pale stone, and below them long rows of clay storehouses. Barges of acacia wood are moored at the quay. The air is hot and smells of silt and bakery smoke. All of this is an artistic reconstruction, based on finds from Qantir and Tell el-Daba, not an exact plan of the city.

Exod 1:11 says that the Israelites built supply cities for Pharaoh, Pithom and Rameses. The work with brick, clay and fields was hard, and the ruler feared that the growing people would become a threat on the eastern border. Exod 12 describes the night when, after dramatic events, Pharaoh let the people go. The text stresses haste: unleavened bread, traveling clothes, families gathered together. The Exodus therefore begins not in the silence of the desert, but in the midst of a crowded administrative capital.

Pi-Rameses lay on the eastern edge of the delta, near a former branch of the Nile, which gave the city a port and access to trade routes to Sinai and Canaan. The area of present-day Qantir is most often accepted as the site, though some scholars point to nearby Tell el-Daba. It is thus a dispute over location, not over the existence of the city in the time of Rameses II. The nearness of the border explains why the army, workshops and storehouses were built right here. From here the routes to the desert were counted in days, not weeks. Think of the scale of such a metropolis: numerous temples, craftsmen's quarters, stables for horses and canals along which barges brought stone and grain. In such a place the violence of the daily labor system was visible at every step, but just as visible was the power that the biblical story stands against. That is why Exod 12 ends with the image of families setting out at dawn.

FACTS

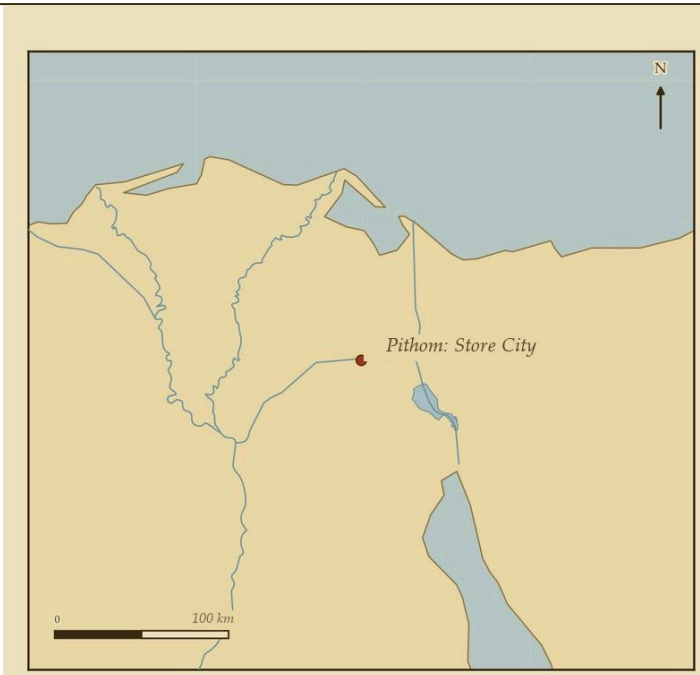
The distance from Pi-Rameses to Lake Timsah is approx. 50 km in a straight line (the city's location is debated: Qantir or Tell el-Daba).


N
Pi-Ramesses: City of Ramesses
0
100 km

# 02 Pithom, the Store City

EXOD 1:11

*The second of the store cities, built in the narrow valley of the Wadi Tumilat.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Imagine a row of long, low storehouses of raw brick, arranged around a rectangular courtyard. Beside them rises a small temple with columns, and by the canal people are working, kneading clay with straw. Donkeys with sacks of grain stand beneath the walls. This is an artistic reconstruction, based on finds from the store cities of the delta, not a portrait of a particular excavation.

### 3.2 · PITHOM, THE STORE CITY · EXOD 1:11

Exod 1:11 names Pithom as one of two cities that the Israelites built as supply centers. The name Pithom comes from an Egyptian name meaning the house of the god Atum, which suggests a cultic center connected with storehouses. The text shows how forced labor was linked to the state economy: brick, clay and straw become the foundation of structures meant to secure power. The book gives no details of the architecture, but the very mention of supplies shows that the delta was also a logistical base for military expeditions.

It is most commonly assumed that Pithom lay in the Wadi Tumilat, a narrow valley running from the Nile east toward the Bitter Lakes. Tell el-Retaba is regarded as a candidate, though some scholars choose Tell el-Maskhuta, so the location is debated. The valley was a natural corridor: it had water, pastures and roads along which caravans and armies moved. That is why cities with supplies were placed there, and later one of the possible escape routes toward the desert ran this way. Geography thus explains why the story concentrates on this strip of land. For the reader, the difference in scale between the two places matters: Pi-Rameses was a great capital, Pithom rather a logistical center. Together they form a picture of a land in which work on resources was organized on a vast scale. Looking at the map, you see both cities about 40 km apart, on a single route leading to the border.

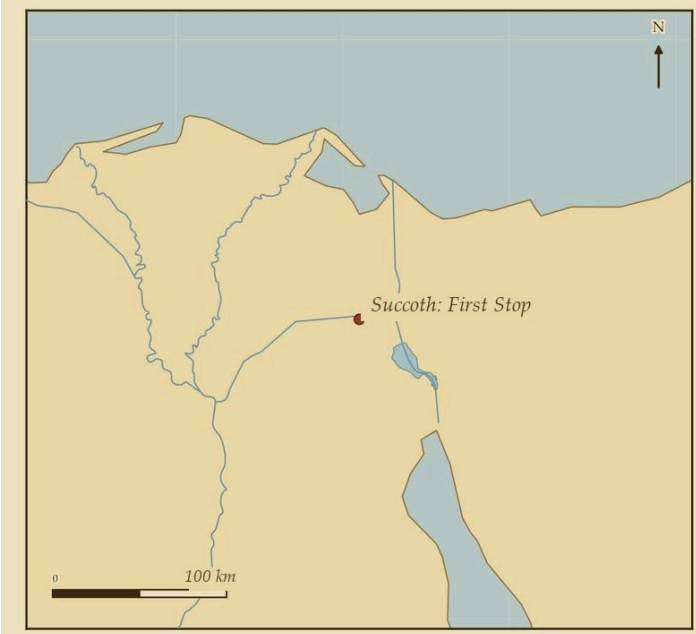
FACTS

The Wadi Tumilat is approx. 50 km long; the location of Pithom (Tell el-Retaba or Tell el-Maskhuta) is debated.

# 03 Succoth, the First Stop

EXOD 12:37; 13:20

*The first camp of the refugees, at the edge of the desert.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Imagine a broad strip of sand and low shrubs at the edge of the valley. Along a narrow canal, makeshift huts of branches and cloth have been set up, and sheep graze nearby. Smoke from the campfires rises straight up, because there is no wind. In the distance the first rocky hills can be seen. This is an artistic reconstruction, not an exact picture of a particular place.

Exod 12:37 says that the Israelites set out from Rameses to Succoth, with many men, women, children and large flocks. The text also speaks of a mixed crowd that joined them. Exod 13:20 adds that the next stop was Etham, on the edge of the wilderness. Succoth means “booths,” and it captures the character of the place well: makeshift shelters where people stop for the first night. The story slows down here and shows weariness, uncertainty and a community being born on the road.

Succoth is usually identified with the Egyptian Tjeku, that is, the area of Tell el-Maskhuta in the Wadi Tumilat, but the location is debated. The valley leads exactly toward the Bitter Lakes and Lake Timsah, so it is a natural first stage of the move east. The distance from Rameses is approx. 50 km in a straight line, which at the pace of a large group with children and cattle means several days of walking. The border of Egypt was not a line on a map but a belt of fortresses and wells, which one crossed with the permission of the guards. It is worth noting that the Book of Exodus does not choose the shortest road through the land of the Philistines (Exod 13:17), but directs the people toward the wilderness. The reason is practical: that road was a military route full of Egyptian outposts. The choice of route thus shows how strongly geography and politics shape the course of the events described.

FACTS

From Pi-Rameses to Succoth (Tell el-Maskhuta) is approx. 50 km in a straight line; the location is debated.

# 04 The Sea of Reeds

EXOD 14–15

*The place of the crossing, whose exact location remains a subject of research.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

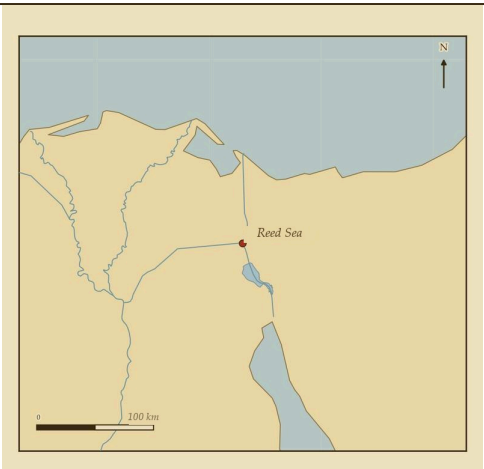
Imagine shallow water, cold at dawn, among dense thickets of reeds, vast as a lake, with no clear shore on the other side. The sky is gray and pink, and on the eastern side rises the low edge of the desert. On the shore, groups of people with animals can be seen from afar. This is an artistic reconstruction of one possible hypothesis, not an exact re-creation of the course of events.

Exod 14 tells of the camp by the water, of the pursuit by Pharaoh's army and of the crossing, which the Israelites regarded as the work of God. The Hebrew name yam suph means "sea of reeds" or "sea of rushes," and the Greek tradition translated it as the Red Sea. Exod 15 is a hymn of thanksgiving after this event. The text gives no coordinates, so the reader must rely on the clues in the names: Pi-hahiroth, Migdol and Baal-zephon (Exod 14:2). Their location is uncertain.

Scholars have proposed several hypotheses. The northern route leads to the lakes near the Mediterranean, the central route to Lake Timsah and the Bitter Lakes, and the southern route to the Gulf of Suez. Each has its supporters and arguments, so in this atlas we give Lake Timsah as an approximate point, noting that the location is debated. In the Wadi Tumilat the terrain changes from fertile to marshy, with reeds and shallow pools that could have formed a natural obstacle for an army in chariots. For the reader the most important thing is what the text itself says: the road toward the wilderness led through a place where water blocked both escape and pursuit. Considering geographical hypotheses does not weaken the message, but lets us see a realistic backdrop. The width of the shallow pools, on the order of a few kilometers, and the seasonal changes in water level fit well with the picture of a place where wind, land and water are at work.

FACTS

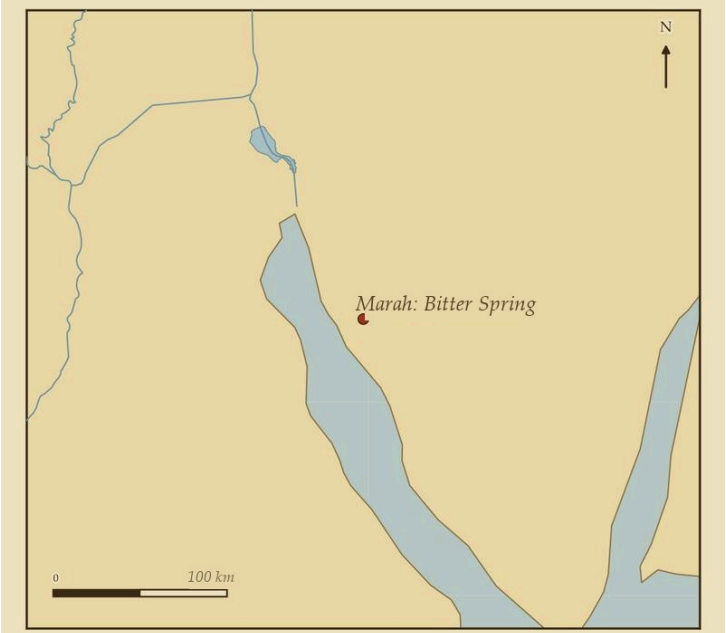
Three main route hypotheses (northern, central, southern) are considered for the crossing of the water; the distance from Succoth to Lake Timsah is approx. 20 km, and the location of the place is debated.


N
Reed Sea
0
100 km

# 05 Marah, the Bitter Spring

EXOD 15:22–26

*The first water after three days of marching, but bitter to the taste.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Imagine a small, gravelly valley with a few tamarisk bushes. In a shallow hollow stands cloudy water with a white crust of salt. Stones heated by the sun lie all around, and in the background rises a pale limestone plateau. There is no shade here, so people shelter under sheets of cloth. This is an artistic reconstruction, not a photograph of a particular spring.

Exod 15:22–26 tells that after crossing the water the Israelites walked three days through the wilderness of Shur and found no water. When they reached Marah, the water proved undrinkable, so the people began to grumble. The story stresses how quickly the joy of deliverance gives way to weariness and fear for basic needs. Then the spring is healed, and the people receive instruction about listening to the voice of God. Marah becomes a symbol of the first trial in the wilderness.

Marah is traditionally identified with Ain Hawara, a spring of brackish water located approx. 80 km southeast of Suez. The location is debated, because some scholars prefer Ain Musa closer to Suez. The picture of a brackish spring fits the text well: on the eastern shore of the Gulf of Suez many waters are made saline by the limestone bedrock and the hot climate. Three days of marching at the average pace of a group with children and animals is about 40–60 km, which fits within this range. For reading the journey, it matters that water decides the route. In Sinai the paths lead from oasis to oasis, and between them stretch sections requiring days of marching without springs. Marah is the first such test, and Elim, the next place, shows the other side of the desert: wells and palms. The whole story thus has a rhythm of scarcity and abundance.

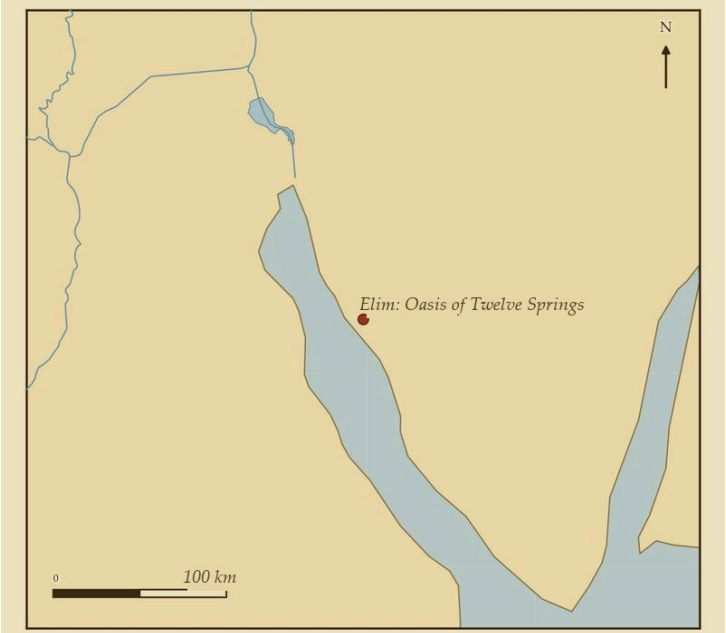
FACTS

Ain Hawara lies approx. 80 km southeast of Suez; the location of Marah is traditional and debated.

# 06 Elim, the Oasis of Twelve Springs

EXOD 15:27; NUM 33:9

*A stop at twelve springs and seventy palm trees.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Imagine a narrow valley in which a green belt of palms and tamarisks grows from the stony floor. A stream flows beneath the tree crowns, and modest goat-hair tents stand beside it. Farther on, on the slopes of the wadi, sharp dark rocks stand out. The air here is noticeably cooler than in the open desert. This is an artistic reconstruction, not an exact re-creation of the oasis.

Exod 15:27 and Num 33:9 state that at Elim there were twelve springs and seventy palm trees, and that the people camped there by the water. Numbers in the Bible often have symbolic meaning, but here they describe the real richness of an oasis. After the bitter water at Marah, the text brings relief and the picture of a stable place of rest. The story does not develop the details, but the very brevity of the account suggests a moment of respite before further trials.

Elim is usually identified with Wadi Gharandel, a valley approx. 15–20 km south of Ain Hawara, though the location is debated. Wadi Gharandel has permanent water, tamarisks and date palms, so it fits the description well. In the Sinai region such oases are rare, and it is they that set the practical caravan routes. That is why scholars often look for stopping places near permanent springs, on the assumption that a group with cattle could not go long without water. The date palm was in the ancient world not only a source of shade but also of food: fruit, fibers for ropes and leaves for roofs. The picture of seventy palms thus describes a place where one can mend clothing, replenish supplies and rest. On the map you can see that Elim lies farther from Suez, toward the south of the peninsula, where the landscape begins to rise toward the granite massifs.

FACTS

Wadi Gharandel lies approx. 15–20 km south of Ain Hawara; the location of Elim is debated.

# 07 Rephidim, the Battle and Water from the Rock

EXOD 17

*No water, a rock and the first battle in the wilderness.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

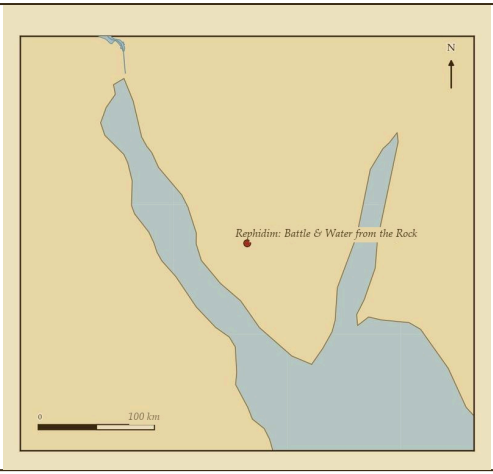
Imagine a wide, sunlit valley with a strip of green along a dry riverbed. Above it rise reddish-brown slopes with jagged ridges. In the distance, on a hill, two small figures support a third with raised hands, while below groups of people gather. This is an artistic reconstruction, not a literal picture of the text.

Exod 17 describes the camp at Rephidim, where there was no water and the people demanded help. Moses strikes the rock with his staff at God's direction, and water flows from the stone. The text calls the place Massah and Meribah, meaning "testing" and "quarrel." Right after this comes the attack of the Amalekites, a desert people. The story shows that a crisis on the road has many faces: thirst, conflict within the group and threat from outside.

Christian tradition has for centuries located Rephidim in the oasis of Feiran, in the Wadi Feiran, the largest oasis of southern Sinai. The location is debated, because Feiran lies approx. 25 km from Jebel Musa, which creates tension with the short interval of time described in the text. Feiran does, however, have palms, water and a strategic position on the route leading to the mountains. For a group wandering through the desert, taking such an oasis was a matter of survival, so an encounter with a local people is very likely. The battle with the Amalekites is fought in open terrain, in a narrow valley, where superior numbers do not always decide. Exod 17:11–12 describes Moses on the hill with raised hands, supported by Aaron and Hur. The image of the hill as a lookout point is tied to geography: high slopes above the wadi made it possible to see the whole battlefield. In this way nature and history once again intertwine in one place.

FACTS

The oasis of Feiran lies approx. 25 km from Jebel Musa in a straight line; the location of Rephidim is traditional and debated.


N
Rephidim: Battle & Water from the Rock
0
100 km

# 08 Sinai / Horeb (Jebel Musa)

EXOD 19–20; 24; 31–34

*The mountain of the covenant, where the people received the Law.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

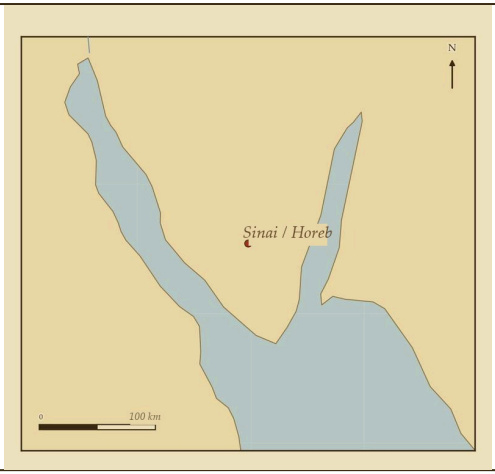
Imagine a huge, bare wall of red granite rising above a vast gravel valley. Dark clouds swirl over the summit, and below the campfires of the camp burn, scattered like points of light. There are no trees on the slopes, only rock and shadow. This is an artistic reconstruction, not an exact re-creation of the events.

Exod 19 says that three months after leaving Egypt the people stood at the foot of Mount Sinai. There follow preparation, thunder, fire and trumpets, and then the gift of the Decalogue (Exod 20). In the following chapters come the legal regulations, the making of the covenant (Exod 24), the episode of the golden calf and the instructions concerning the Tabernacle. The Book of Numbers (Num 1–10) adds the census of the people and the organization of the camp. The stay at the mountain lasts approx. a year and is the central point of the whole narrative.

Traditionally, Mount Sinai, also called Horeb, is identified with Jebel Musa (Mount Moses) in southern Sinai, at a height of approx. 2,285 m above sea level. This identification dates from Christian times and is tied to St. Catherine's Monastery at its foot. The location is debated: other peaks have also been proposed, including Jebel Serbal, and even places in Arabia or the Negev. Before the mountain stretches the flat plain of Er-Raha, where a large crowd could have camped. The granite mountain rises steeply above the valley and can be seen from afar, which explains the description of the boundaries set around it (Exod 19:12). The weather at this altitude can turn suddenly: storms with lightning, strong winds, cold nights even in summer. Such a landscape harmonizes well with the picture of a theophany in thunder and fire. When reading the text, however, remember that it is not geography but the encounter with God that is its heart.

FACTS

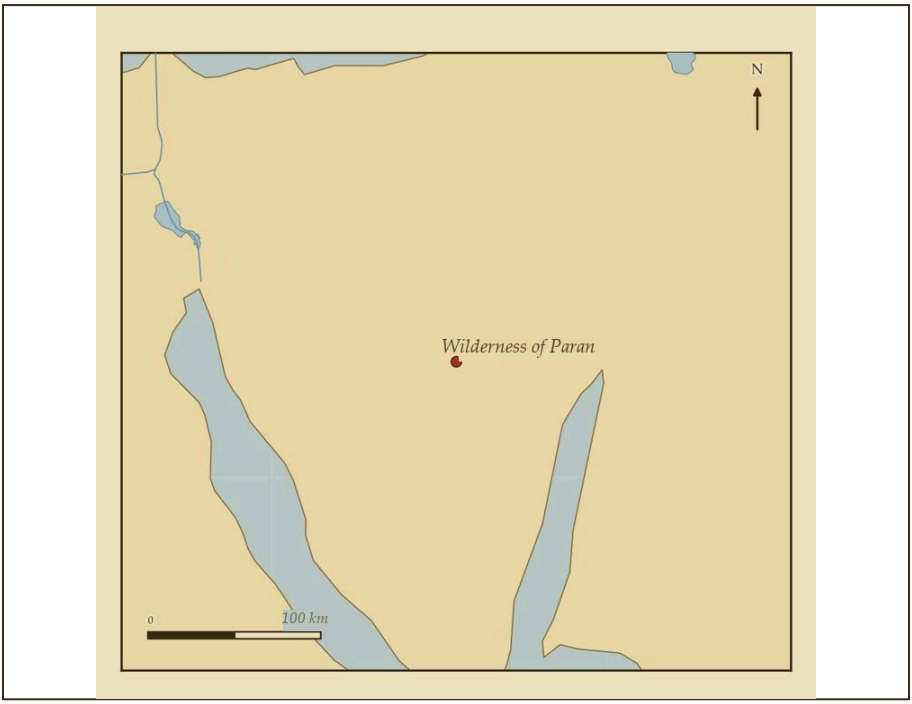
Jebel Musa is approx. 2,285 m above sea level; its identification with biblical Sinai is traditional and debated.


N
Sinai / Horeb
0
100 km

# 09 The Wilderness of Paran

NUM 10:12; 12:16; 13:3

*A vast wilderness through which the people walked toward Kadesh.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Imagine an endless, flat plateau covered with gravel and sparse clumps of shrubs. Here and there low, pale hills rise, and dry riverbeds stretch through the valleys. The air shimmers with heat, and on the horizon a thin line of a caravan can be seen. This is an artistic reconstruction, not a portrait of a particular place.

Num 10:12 says that after leaving Sinai the cloud came to rest in the wilderness of Paran. From here, according to Num 13:3, Moses sent twelve spies to explore the land of Canaan. The story shows a stage of successive stops, such as Taberah and Kibroth-hattaavah, where the people complained about food and their leaders (Num 11). Passing through this area took a long time and depended continually on water and fodder for the flocks.

The wilderness of Paran is a vast, harsh area in central Sinai and in the northern part of the peninsula, with rocky hills, plateaus and dry wadi beds. Its exact boundaries are not established, and the location of individual stops is debated. For the map we adopt a reference point in the central part, approx. 100–150 km from Jebel Musa. Routes connecting Sinai with the Negev ran through here, so the area was not completely cut off from the world. For the reader, it is important that Paran is not a single point but a region. The name denotes large spaces where people and flocks wandered from spring to spring. In the Bible this place also appears in the story of Hagar and Ishmael (Gen 21:21), which shows that it was a known zone for pastoral peoples. From the perspective of the narrative, Paran is the gate between the mountain of the covenant and the land of promise.

FACTS

The point on the map is approximate: the wilderness of Paran covers an area approx. 100–150 km across; its boundaries are debated.

# 10 Kadesh-barnea

NUM 13–14; 20:1–13

*An oasis at the threshold of Canaan, where the people hesitated to enter.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

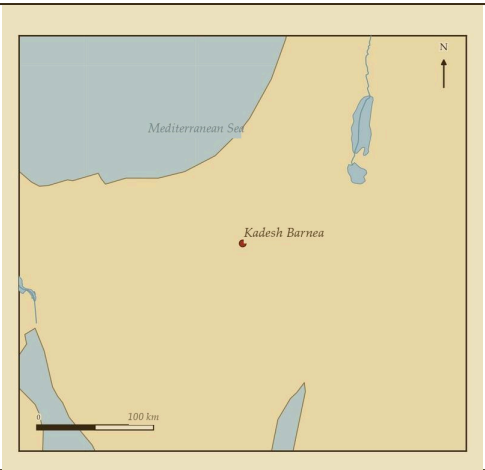
Imagine a green, spacious basin amid a dry, rocky desert. A spring forms several streams, along which shrubs and low trees grow. Numerous tents stand around the oasis, and on the hills traces of ancient paths can be seen. This is an artistic reconstruction, not an exact re-creation of the camp.

Num 13–14 tells of twelve spies who explored the land for forty days. They returned with fruit and descriptions of a fertile land, but most presented its inhabitants as too strong. The people began to complain and refused to enter, which the book interprets as a lack of trust. As a consequence, the generation that left Egypt was to remain in the wilderness, and the way into the land was postponed. Num 20:1–13 mentions the death of Miriam at Kadesh and a new conflict over water.

Kadesh-barnea is most often identified with the oasis of Ain el-Kudeirat in northern Sinai, approx. 80 km south of Beersheba. The location is debated, because Ain Qadis is also sometimes suggested. Ain el-Kudeirat is one of the largest springs in the region, surrounded by a fertile valley where cultivation is possible. The place lies at a crossroads of routes, so it provided the group with water and a good position, while also allowing a view of the roads leading to the Negev. From the oasis to Beersheba it is approx. 80 km in a straight line, which for families and flocks on the march would take several days. The oasis thus gives a picture of a place from which the goal can be seen, but a decision still has to be made. The book shows that the obstacle is not the distance itself but courage. That is why Kadesh-barnea remains in memory as the turning point of the whole journey.

FACTS

Ain el-Kudeirat lies approx. 80 km south of Beersheba; the location of Kadesh-barnea is debated.


N
Mediterranean Sea
Kadesh Barnea
0
100 km

# 11 The Plains of Moab

NUM 22–36; DEUT 1–4

*The last camp before the Jordan, opposite Jericho.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Imagine a vast, hot lowland with shrubs, tamarisks and strips of green along the river. In the west the pale line of the Jordan and the palms of Jericho can be seen, and in the east the hills of Moab rise. Tents are pitched in rows, and white smoke from campfires rises above them. This is an artistic reconstruction, not an exact plan of the camp.

Num 22–36 describes the camp of the Israelites on the plains of Moab, on the east side of the Jordan, opposite Jericho. Here the episodes with Balaam take place, a new census of the people (Num 26) and the regulations concerning the division of the land. The Book of Deuteronomy, in turn, is a series of speeches by Moses, delivered in this very place. The story draws near its end, and the reader sees that the goal is not only to reach the land but also to prepare the people for life in it.

The plains of Moab are a wide strip of low terrain east of the Jordan, just by the Dead Sea, at an elevation below sea level. The exact location of the camp is debated, because the Bible gives names such as Shittim or Beth-peor, which we cannot identify with certainty. From the plains one can see Jericho and the palm valley of the Jordan in the west. The strip of land is several kilometers wide, which was enough for a temporary camp of a large community. The climate of the Jordan Valley is hot and dry in summer, and in spring the river floods, which, according to Josh 3:15, made crossing difficult. The location just before the border of the land makes Moab a symbolic place: the people are on the threshold, but not yet inside. Deut 1–4 recalls the whole journey and leads to the final instructions meant to shape the life of the community.

FACTS

The strip of the plains of Moab is several kilometers wide and lies below sea level; the point on the map is approximate, and the location of the camp is debated.

# 12 Mount Nebo

DEUT 32:48–52; 34

*A view of the Promised Land and the end of Moses' journey.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

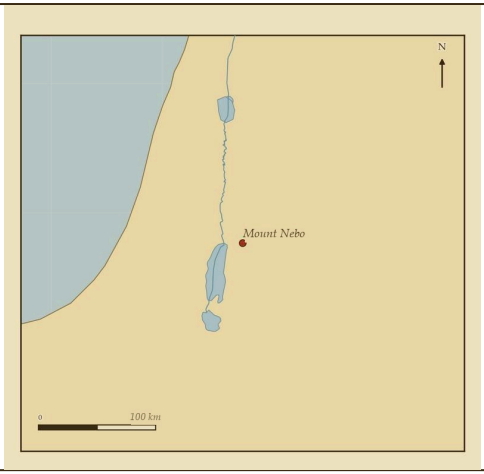
Imagine a broad, stony summit with low shrubs, from which one can see below the shining line of the Jordan and a vast yellow-brown lowland. Beyond it the gentle outlines of the mountains of Judea appear, and in the distance a band of blue water can be seen. On the summit a solitary figure stands far off, seen from behind. This is an artistic reconstruction, not an exact re-creation of the scene.

Deut 32:48–52 and Deut 34 present the last stage of Moses' life. At God's command he goes up Mount Nebo, the peak of Pisgah opposite Jericho, and from there surveys the broad land: Gilead, the Negev, the Jordan Valley, all the way to the distant hills. The text says that he did not enter the land, and that his grave remained unknown. The story ends with the memory of the people's mourning and the handing over of leadership to Joshua. This is the closing of the Pentateuch, full of gravity and gratitude.

Mount Nebo is traditionally identified with Ras Siyagha, a peak approx. 800 m above sea level, located in Jordan, approx. 10 km west of Madaba. The location is traditional rather than certain. From this point, in good weather, one can see the Jordan Valley, the northern part of the Dead Sea and the area around Jericho. The relative height above the valley exceeds 1,100 m, which gives a wide panorama while also clearly separating the observer from the land lying below. The significance of the geography is exceptional here: the place was chosen not by chance, but because it offers a view of the entire land of promise. From the reader's perspective, Nebo shows that the journey does not end in triumph, but in trust that the promise will be fulfilled in the next generation. Deut 34 also recalls that Moses was approx. 120 years old, and his strength did not leave him until the end.

FACTS

Ras Siyagha is approx. 800 m above sea level and rises over 1,100 m above the Jordan; its identification with Mount Nebo is traditional.


N
Mount Nebo
0
100 km

# Questions for Reflection

1. Why, according to Exod 13:17, did the road lead through the wilderness and not along the shortest route by the coast, and what does this say about the role of geography in the story?

2. How does your reading of Exod 14 change when you know that the place of the crossing is debated and that scholars hold several hypotheses?

3. Which of the places on the journey, Marah, Elim, Rephidim, Kadesh or Nebo, best shows, in your opinion, the tension between scarcity and trust, and why?

# 04

PART 4 OF 9

# The Promised Land

JOSH 1–24; JUDG 1–21; RUTH 1–4

*From the crossing of the Jordan to the fields of Bethlehem: how a nation came to live in Canaan.*



# From the Jordan to Bethlehem

After Moses' death, the nation stands on the eastern bank of the Jordan, looking out over the promised land. The Book of Joshua tells of the entry into Canaan, the Book of Judges of several centuries of uncertain freedom, and the short Book of Ruth of a single family from Bethlehem. Together they form a story about a land that is a gift, but also a test. Picture a narrow strip of land between the sea and the desert, cut by valleys and hills. This terrain explains why some clashes were decided on the summits, others in the valleys, and why daily life unfolded in small, scattered settlements.

The geography of Canaan is surprisingly varied. In the west stretches a coastal plain, crossed by important trade routes. Farther inland rise the hills of Judah and Ephraim, hard to conquer but easy to defend. In the east opens the deep Jordan rift, and in the north the broad Jezreel Valley links the coast with the river. In such a landscape each generation received a different kind of land: pastures, grain fields, vineyards, or steep slopes. This mosaic favored independence but hindered unity, as the Book of Judges makes plain.

In this part of the atlas you will follow the stages of that journey: from the miraculous crossing of the Jordan, through Jericho, Ai, and Gibeon, to the assembly at Shiloh, where the land was divided among the twelve tribes. Later you will meet Deborah at Tabor, Gideon at the spring of Harod, and Samson in Gaza, and finally the humble fields of Bethlehem, where a story begins that leads to David. The reconstructions of places are artistic interpretations based on archaeological knowledge, and distances are given as approximations.

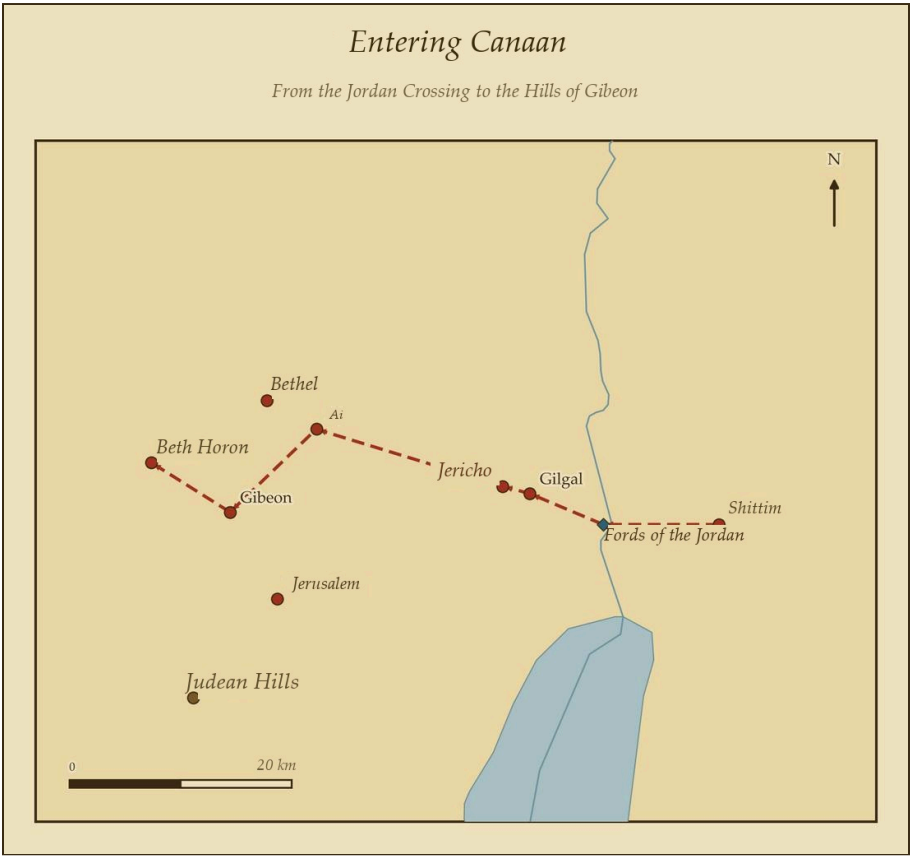
INDEX OF PLACES AND SCENES


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HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

The maps show routes and the locations of places; the illustrations are artistic reconstructions based on archaeological knowledge, not photographs. Distances and dimensions are approximate.

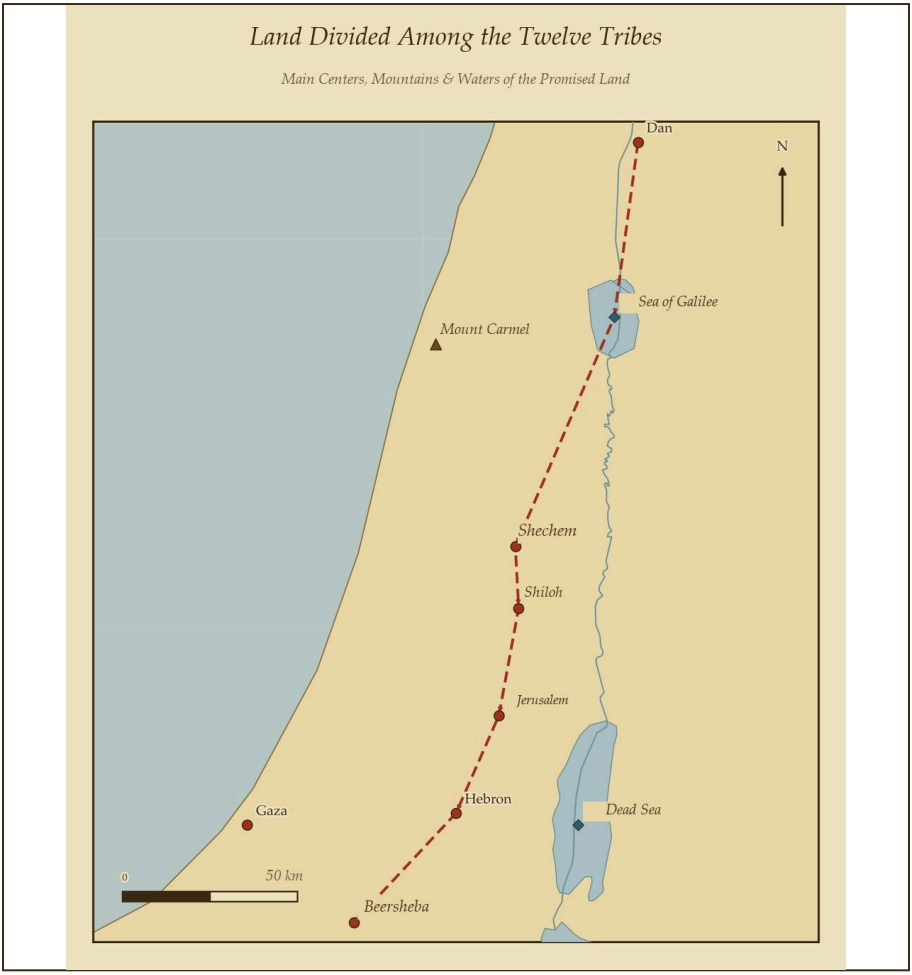
MAP 4.1




*The red line shows the approximate course of the road from the Jordan up to the plateau. The locations are traditional, and the routes are approximate.*

The map shows that the first phase of settlement was a march from the valley into the hills: from the deep Jordan rift to an elevation of nearly 800 m. Jericho controlled the entrance, Ai and Bethel lay on the edge of the plateau, and Gibeon close to present-day Jerusalem. Look closely at the difference in elevation, because it explains why the road was so exhausting and why ambushes in the ravines worked so well.

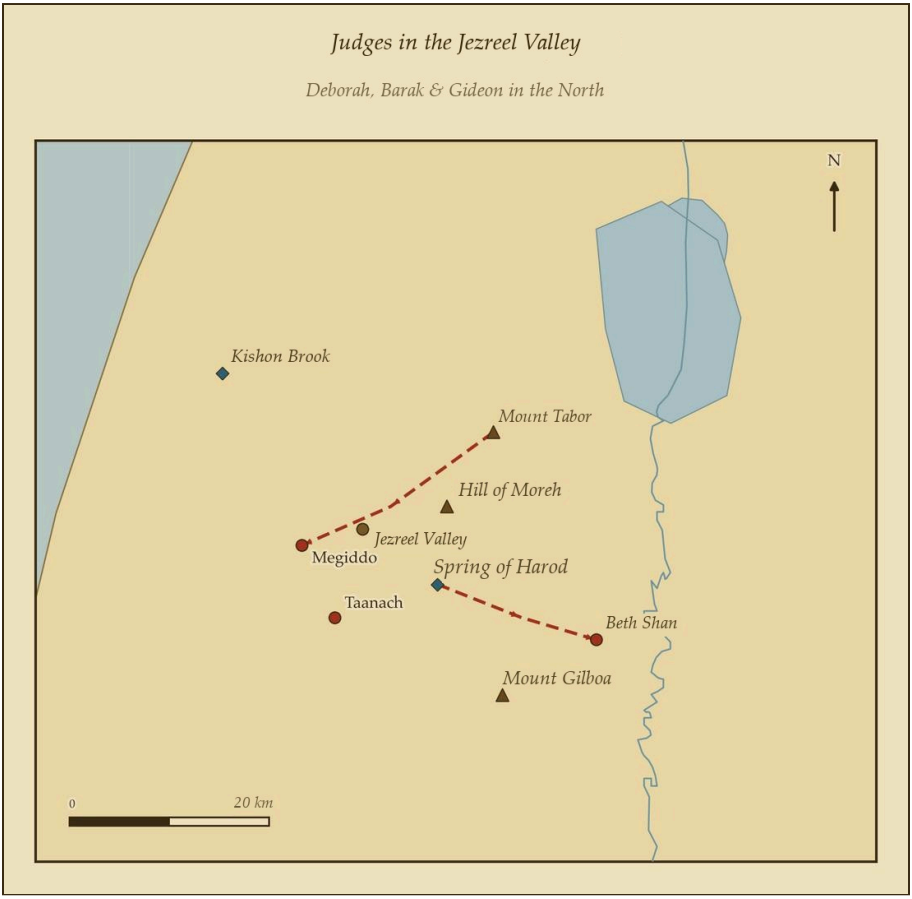
MAP 4.2




*The map shows the backbone of the land from Dan in the north to Beersheba in the south, as the Bible describes it. The line marks the main route along the hills.*

The map shows that the Promised Land stretches about 240 km from north to south, yet it is very narrow. The twelve tribes thus received strips of land of differing character: fertile valleys in the north, the hills of Ephraim in the middle, drier hills of Judah in the south. Shiloh, located almost in the center, was well suited as a place of assembly and for the Tabernacle.

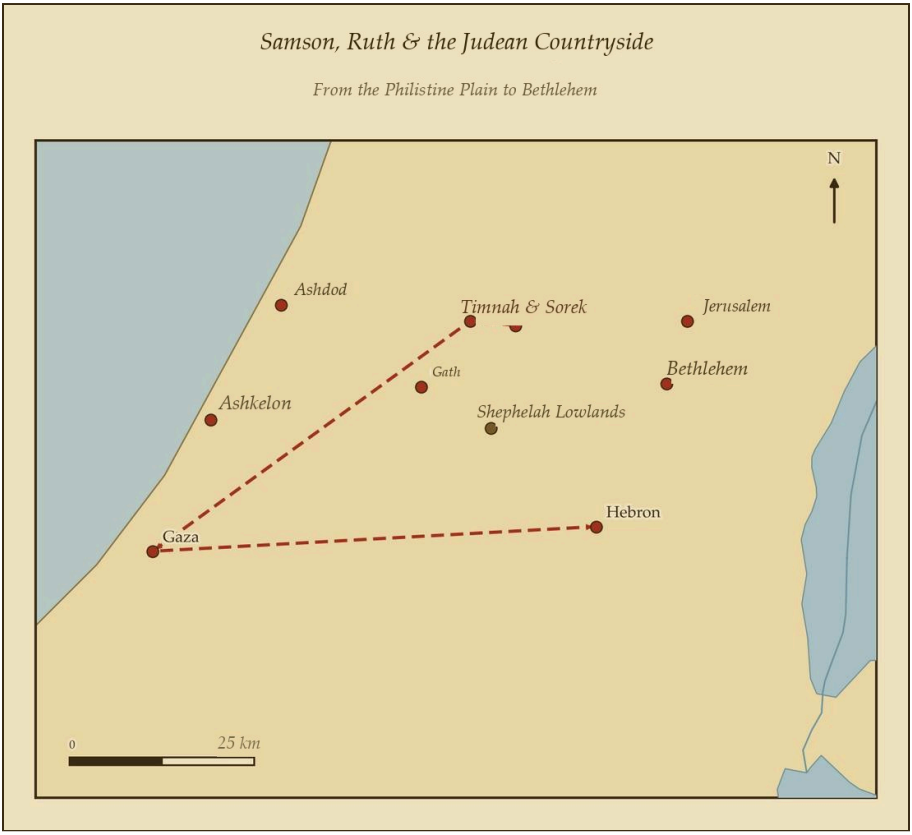
MAP 4.3




*The map covers the broad Jezreel Valley, also called the Plain of Esdraelon, with the key sites of two battles. The lines show the approximate direction of the action.*

The Jezreel Valley is the largest fertile area of the north and a natural corridor from the coast to the Jordan. That is why battles were fought here: that of Deborah and Barak in the rain, that of Gideon at night. Notice how Tabor, Gilboa, and the hill of Moreh mark the edges of the valley, giving defenders high ground and leaving attackers a trap of mud or darkness.

MAP 4.4




*The map sets the five Philistine cities beside the hill country of Judah. The line shows Samson's approximate route, and Bethlehem marks the setting of Ruth's story.*

The stories of Samson unfold on the border of two worlds: the coastal plain of the Philistines and the hills of Judah. The distances are small, yet the contrasts are enormous, since only a dozen or so kilometers separate the plain from the steep hills. Bethlehem, only about 8 km from Jerusalem, lies at the opposite end of this map and reminds us that daily life in Judah went on in the shadow of great history.

# 01 Crossing the Jordan and Gilgal

JOSH 3–5

*The nation crosses the river on dry ground and pitches its first camp in Canaan.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Imagine a broad, fertile valley where a river winds between green thickets. In spring the water is muddy and swift, and crowds of people with their animals stand on both banks. In front are the priests, carrying the Ark high, with families behind them. On the horizon the pale hills of Judah rise, and far to the west, in the morning haze, the outline of Jericho can be seen. This is an artistic reconstruction, based on the description of the valley's landscape.

## 4.1 · CROSSING THE JORDAN AND GILGAL · JOSH 3–5

The Book of Joshua describes how the Israelites camped at Shittim and then moved toward the river opposite Jericho, at the season of the spring floods. The priests carrying the Ark of the Covenant stepped into the water first, and the current stopped, so that all the people crossed on dry ground. Twelve stones were taken from the riverbed, one for each tribe, and set up at Gilgal. The place became the first camp in Canaan, a site of circumcision and of celebrating the Passover. Tradition places Gilgal east of Jericho, though its exact location remains disputed.

The Jordan is not a wide river, but during the spring thaw its valley turns into a tangle of reeds, mud, and swift current. The river flows through a deep rift valley, below sea level, and its banks are overgrown with dense vegetation. Moving an entire people with their belongings across it was therefore a serious challenge. On the western side lay a belt of desert hills leading toward Jericho and onward, up to the plateau. The crossing thus had a strategic dimension as well: whoever controlled the ford controlled the entrance to the whole land.

### FACTS

The Jordan Valley lies about 390 m below sea level, and here the river is only a few dozen meters wide.


N
Crossing the Jordan & Gilgal
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

# 02 Jericho

JOSH 2; 6

*The first city of Canaan, which fell after seven days of marching around its walls.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

See a small but heavily fortified city on a low hill, surrounded by palm groves and fields irrigated by a spring. Walls of sun-dried brick rise several meters, and behind them the flat roofs of houses can be seen. All around spreads the bright, parched desert, and in the distance rocky slopes rise. The artistic reconstruction combines knowledge of the tell with the description of the oasis.

Joshua sent two spies to Jericho, who were hidden by Rahab, a woman of the city. Later the whole people circled the walls for six days, and on the seventh day seven times, with priests blowing horns. At the sound of a great shout the walls fell, and the city fell into Israelite hands. Rahab and her family were saved and joined the people. The story stresses that victory is a gift, not the fruit of strength. Jericho is identified with the tell of Tell es-Sultan, and the dating of its layers is a matter of debate among scholars.

Jericho lay beside an abundant spring, in an oasis amid the desert, and is one of the oldest known cities in the world. For this reason it was called the City of Palms. From here roads led west, through steep, dry ravines toward Jerusalem and Bethel, and east, through a ford on the Jordan. Whoever took Jericho opened the way into the mountain plateaus of Canaan. For newcomers from the desert it was thus the natural first task, and at the same time the symbolic beginning of settling the land.

FACTS

Jericho lies about 250 m below sea level and is among the lowest-lying cities in the world.


N
Jericho
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

# 03 Ai

JOSH 7–8

*Defeat because of Achan's sin, and victory by ambush.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Imagine a rocky ridge covered with shrubs, with a small walled town on its summit. Narrow gullies wind all around, where a detachment could easily hide. The road uphill twists among the stones, and a dry, bright sky hangs over it all. This is an artistic reconstruction, based on the lay of the land.

After the fall of Jericho, Joshua sent a small force against Ai, but the Israelites had to flee. The cause was the mysterious guilt of Achan, who had kept for himself items placed under a ban. When the matter came to light and the offender was punished, Joshua prepared a second attack. Part of the army was hidden in an ambush west of the city, while the rest feigned flight. The inhabitants rushed out of the gates in pursuit, and the ambush seized the city and set it on fire. Et-Tell is traditionally considered the location of Ai, though archaeologists dispute this identification.

Ai lay high on the edge of a hilly plateau, near Bethel, and the road from Jericho led there by a steep, difficult climb through dry ravines. The difference in elevation between the Jordan Valley and this place is several hundred meters, which explains why the first approach was so exhausting. The area is full of narrow valleys and rocky outcrops, ideal for hiding an ambush. For commanders it meant having to use the terrain, not just superior numbers, and the tactic of the second battle rests on exactly this.

FACTS

The distance from Jericho to Ai is about 20 km, with a climb of about 900 m.

# 04 Shechem, Ebal, and Gerizim

JOSH 8:30–35; 24

*Two mountains above a valley, where the people heard the blessings and the warnings.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Imagine a greenish, fertile valley, with gentle but high mountains rising on both sides. Sheep graze on the slopes, and a road with merchant caravans runs between them. On one side the hills are covered with stone terraces, on the other with rock. The artistic reconstruction combines the biblical description with the appearance of the valley today.

The Book of Joshua describes a ceremony in the heart of the land. After the capture of Ai, the people gathered between two mountains: some stood at the foot of Gerizim, some at the foot of Ebal. Joshua built an altar and read out the words of the Law, including the blessings and the warnings. Many years later, near the end of his life, he again summoned all the tribes to Shechem and asked them to choose whom they would serve. The people answered that it would be the Lord, and Joshua recorded this as a renewal of the covenant.

Shechem lies in a natural pass between two massive mountains and controlled an important crossroads in the center of the land. The valley between Ebal and Gerizim is narrow, and sound carries superbly here, which made it easy for a large number of people to assemble together. The place was also close to the old patriarchs, for Abraham and Jacob had stopped here centuries before. Shechem thus became a natural place to recall that the promise reaches deeper than the mere conquest of the land.

FACTS

Mount Ebal rises about 940 m above sea level and Gerizim about 880 m; the valley between them is only about 500 m wide.

# 05 Gibeon

JOSH 9–10

*A cunning alliance, the battle of Gibeon, and the day that grew longer.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

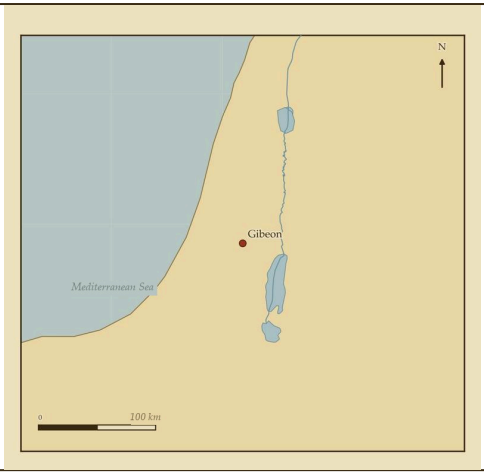
See a hill crowned by a city with stone walls, surrounded by terraces of vineyards and olive trees. Life bustles all around: carts, flocks, merchants. Down in the valley, clouds of dust rise as an army approaches. The sky is bright, and the light lingers long on the slopes. This is an artistic reconstruction, based on the description and surveys of the terrain.

The Gibeonites, seeing the fate of Jericho and Ai, came to the camp at Gilgal in worn-out clothes, pretending to be travelers from a distant land. The Israelites made a treaty with them, and when the trick came to light, they did not break their oath. Soon five kings attacked Gibeon. Joshua set out from Gilgal on a night march, surprised the enemy, and defeated them. Tradition describes the day as lengthened until the pursuit was over, and a hailstorm completed the enemy's defeat. The author stresses that it was not strength but God's intervention that decided the outcome.

Gibeon lay on the western edge of the plateau, not far from Jerusalem, on an important road leading from the hills toward the lowland. From Gilgal it took a whole night's march uphill, about 30 km along a steep, stony track. The pursuit then ran downhill through Beth-horon, a narrow pass where fleeing enemies could hardly scatter. This region formed a transitional belt between the hills and the lowland Shephelah, so whoever controlled it held the key to both worlds.

FACTS

Gibeon lies about 9 km northwest of Jerusalem, at about 800 m above sea level.


N
Gibeon
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

# 06 Shiloh

JOSH 18–19; 1 SAM 1–4

*The site of the Tabernacle and of the casting of lots for the twelve tribes' portions.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Imagine a small hill above a greenish valley, on which stands a large tent covered with skins, surrounded by a courtyard. Around it are set up the smaller tents of pilgrims and stone enclosures. In spring and autumn crowds gather here. This is an artistic reconstruction, since the exact appearance of the Tabernacle at Shiloh is known to us only from descriptions.

Once the army had settled in the land, the Tent of Meeting was set up at Shiloh, and the whole people assembled there. Joshua noticed that seven tribes still had no portions assigned. So he sent three men from each of them to survey the land, and then, before the Lord, lots were cast and each tribe received its own territory. Judah and Joseph (Ephraim and Manasseh) had received their portions earlier, and the Levites were given cities among the other tribes. Later, Eli served at Shiloh, and Samuel as a boy.

Shiloh lies in the heart of the land, in the hills of Ephraim, in a valley hidden among low hills, not far from the main north–south route. From Shiloh to Shechem is about 18 km, and to Jerusalem about 31 km. This central position made it easier for pilgrims from different directions to reach the yearly feasts. The division of the land reflected geography: the north had fertile valleys, the hills of Ephraim pastures and vineyards, the south drier hills. The twelve tribes thus received very different living conditions.

FACTS

Shiloh lies about 600 m above sea level and about 31 km north of Jerusalem.

# 07 Taanach and Megiddo

JUDG 4–5

*The battle by the Kishon brook and the victory of Deborah and Barak over Sisera's war chariots.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

See a broad, green plain under a heavy, dark sky. At its edge rise two fortified hills with cities, and in the valley wooden chariots with horses have bogged down. Streams of mud flow toward the brook, and in the distance Mount Tabor can be seen. This is an artistic reconstruction, based on the description of the valley's landscape.

The prophetess and judge Deborah, from the hill country of Ephraim, summoned Barak to gather men from Naphtali and Zebulun. Sisera, commander of King Jabin, had nine hundred iron chariots and assembled them at the Kishon. When Barak set out from Tabor, the Lord threw the enemy into confusion, and the valley turned to mud. The Song of Deborah mentions an overflowing brook that swept the chariots away. Sisera fled on foot and died in Jael's tent. In the text, Taanach and Megiddo are described as the site of the battle.

Taanach and Megiddo guarded the passes from the Jezreel Valley toward the coast. Through Megiddo ran one of the most important roads of the ancient world, linking Egypt with Mesopotamia, which meant that this place repeatedly became a battlefield. The Jezreel Valley is a broad plain with rich, heavy soil that turns to mud after a downpour. War chariots, fearsome on hard ground, bogged down here helplessly. Geography thus became an ally of the weaker side.

FACTS

Taanach and Megiddo are about 8 km apart, and the Jezreel Valley is about 20 km wide.


N
Taanach & Megiddo
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

# 08 Mount Tabor

JUDG 4:6–14

*A lone, dome-shaped mountain from which Barak set out for battle.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Imagine a symmetrical mountain, covered with oaks and shrubs, rising majestically above a flat valley. On its slopes paths and a small gathering of people can be seen. Far below, clouds of dust or rain drift by. The artistic reconstruction is based on the mountain's appearance today.

Deborah told Barak to gather ten thousand men on Mount Tabor. When Sisera learned of it, he drew his chariots to the Kishon. Then Deborah told Barak that the day had come when the Lord would deliver the enemy into his hand. Barak came down the slope with his force and struck the enemy. Tabor marked the boundary between the territories of Zebulun, Naphtali, and Issachar, so it served as a natural gathering place for the tribes.

Tabor rises alone from the plain like an enormous, rounded dome. From its summit one can see the whole Jezreel Valley, the hills of Galilee, and the foothills of Carmel. This position offered an excellent vantage point, and the slope protected the army from a chariot charge, since chariots could not drive up it. Descending the mountain gave the Israelites the advantage of momentum, and the mud below deepened the enemy's confusion.

FACTS

Tabor rises about 588 m above sea level and about 400 m above the surrounding plain.

# 09 Spring of Harod

JUDG 6–7

*Gideon sets out with three hundred warriors against the Midianites.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

See a quiet night over the valley. At the foot of a rocky slope a spring wells up, and in the distance, in the valley, hundreds of campfires of the Midianite camp flicker, with camels spread out like dark patches. On the hills sudden torchlights appear. An artistic reconstruction, based on the description of the night and the terrain.

The Midianites and their allies invaded the land every year at harvest time, leaving the Israelites in poverty. Gideon of Ophrah was called to be a judge. He gathered an army, but the Lord told him to reduce it. First the fearful were sent home, then the men were tested by how they drank water from the spring, until three hundred remained. At night Gideon divided them into three companies and gave them trumpets, empty jars, and torches. At the agreed signal they smashed the jars and blew the trumpets, and the enemy began to flee in panic.

The spring of Harod lies at the foot of Mount Gilboa, on the edge of the Jezreel Valley, and the Midianite camp stood north of it, in the valley below the hill of Moreh. From this place the way to the Jordan, about 15 km to the east, lay open to the fleeing. Gideon used the darkness of night, the breadth of the valley, and the echo to give the impression of an enormous army. The narrow passes and hill edges drove the fugitives toward the fords of the river.

FACTS

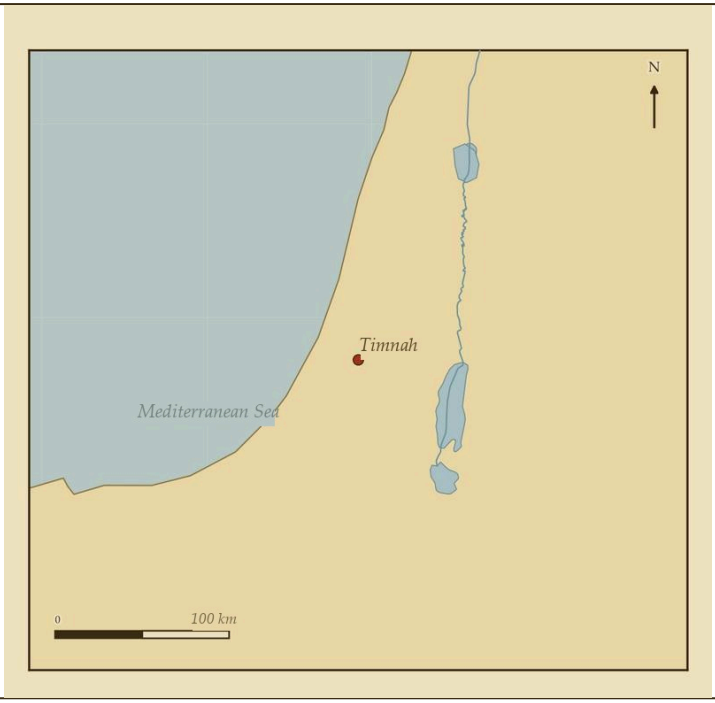
The distance from the spring of Harod to the Jordan is about 15 km, and according to the text the Midianite camp numbered hundreds of thousands of people and camels.


N
Spring of Harod
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

# 10 Timnah

JUDG 14

*A Philistine city where Samson fell in love with a woman and posed a riddle.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Imagine a wide valley with gentle slopes, with grain fields, vineyards, and a small town on a hill. Farmsteads stand all around, and shepherds and carts can be seen on the roads. In the distance, to the east, the rocky hills of Judah rise. This is an artistic reconstruction, based on the description of the borderland.

Samson came from the tribe of Dan, from the town of Zorah. When he grew up, he saw a young Philistine woman in Timnah and asked his parents to get her for him as a wife. On the way to Timnah he killed a lion with his bare hands, and later found honey in its carcass. At the wedding feast he made a riddle of it for thirty guests, wagering garments. When the answer came out through his wife, Samson flew into a rage and began a series of deeds that unleashed open war with the Philistines.

Timnah lay in the Sorek Valley, about 5 km from Zorah, on the border between the hills of Judah and the coastal plain. It was a borderland, where Israelites and Philistines met, traded goods, and intermarried. The Sorek Valley formed a natural corridor from the coast into the hills. That is why all the tensions between the two peoples played out in places like this, and the story of Samson shows this world of borders well.

FACTS

Timnah (Tel Batash) lies about 5 km from Zorah and about 25 km from the sea.

# 11 Gaza

JUDG 16

*A Philistine city from which Samson carried the gates up to a hilltop.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

See a fortified city on a sandy hill, surrounded by palm groves and gardens. The walls of brick and stone are broad, with a massive gate with wooden doors set in them. Beyond the city stretch the plain and the distant sea, and in the far distance gentle hills rise. This is an artistic reconstruction, based on knowledge of Philistine cities.

4.11 · GAZA · JUDG 16

Samson came to Gaza, where the Philistines shut the city gates, planning to catch him at dawn. In the middle of the night he rose, tore out the gates together with their posts, and carried them to the top of a hill facing Hebron. Later Delilah, a woman from the Sorek Valley, betrayed his secret, and the Philistines seized him, blinded him, and brought him to Gaza. Imprisoned, he worked at the mill, until in the temple of Dagon, during a festival, he asked the Lord for one last measure of strength and brought down the pillars, dying together with his enemies.

Gaza lay at the southern end of the coastal plain, about 5 km from the sea, on the great route linking Egypt with Syria and Mesopotamia. It was one of the largest Philistine cities, wealthy through trade. The distance from Gaza to Hebron is about 60 km, with the last twenty-odd steeply uphill. Samson's feat was thus not only a miracle of strength but also a symbol of the city's humiliation, whose gates were carried right up to the hills of Judah.

FACTS

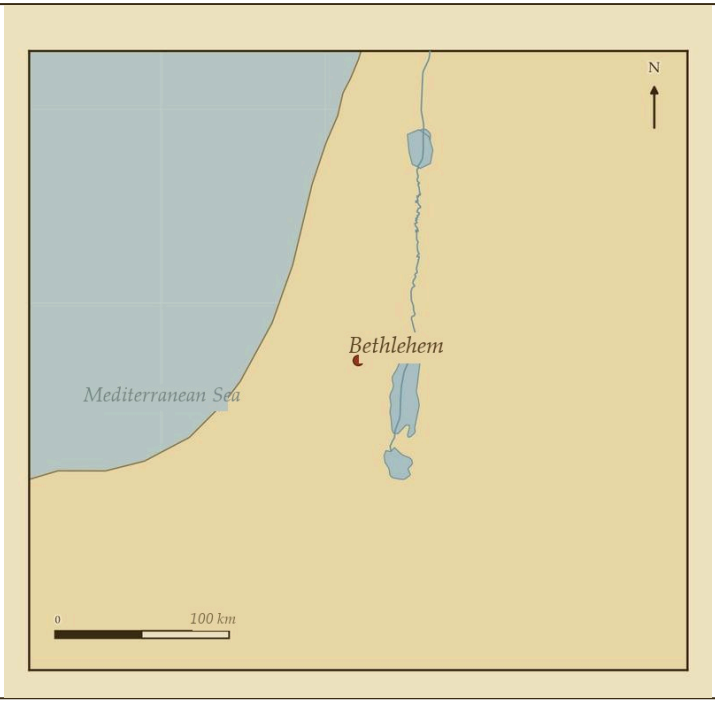
Gaza lies about 5 km from the Mediterranean Sea and about 60 km from Hebron.


N
Mediterranean Sea
Gaza
0
100 km

# 12 Bethlehem

RUTH 1–4

*The barley fields where Ruth met Boaz, and the beginning of David's family line.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Imagine golden barley fields on terraces, harvested by hand by reapers. Women gather the ears of grain, carrying them in bundles, and in the background the small stone houses of the hilltop town can be seen. Olive and fig trees grow all around, and farther off pale slopes rise. An artistic reconstruction, based on the landscape of the area today.

Because of famine, Elimelech and his family left Bethlehem and settled in Moab. After the death of her husband and sons, Naomi decided to return, and her daughter-in-law Ruth went with her. In Bethlehem the barley harvest was beginning. Ruth went out to the fields to glean, and happened upon the field of Boaz, a relative of Naomi. Boaz saw to her safety, and after fulfilling the requirements of the law, he married her. From their family was born Obed, father of Jesse and thus grandfather of King David.

Bethlehem lies on a ridge of the hills of Judah, about 8 km south of Jerusalem, at an elevation of about 770 m above sea level. The area is fertile, but the transition from fields to desert is short here, which explains both the periodic famines and the pastoral tradition. The hillsides form terraces of barley and wheat, and lower down, toward the Dead Sea, the Judean Desert begins. The road from Hebron to Jerusalem ran through Bethlehem.

FACTS

Bethlehem lies about 770 m above sea level and about 8 km from Jerusalem.

# Reflection Questions

1. How does the lay of the land, from the Jordan Valley to the Jezreel Valley, help us understand the course of the battles described, and why is victory attributed not only to the strength of men?

2. Why did Shiloh and Shechem play such an important role in the religious life of the nation, and what do they have to do with the memory of the covenant and the division of the land?

3. What does the story of Ruth and the fields of Bethlehem say about faithfulness, hospitality, and the way God's plan can unfold in ordinary, everyday matters?

# 05

PART 5 OF 9

# The Kingdom of Israel

1SAM9–2KGS1;1CHR10–2CHR10

*From the first king in the hills of Benjamin to the prophet on Mount Carmel.*



# From Shepherds' Hills to Royal Cities

Imagine a land where judges ruled not long ago and every tribe guarded its own valley. Around 1000 BC this changes: a king appears. Saul rules from Gibeah, a small town on a mountain ridge, David captures Jerusalem, and Solomon turns it into a capital with a palace and a temple. The books of Samuel, Kings, and Chronicles tell of this turning point, in which politics, faith, and geography are tightly intertwined. When reading these books, it pays to keep glancing at the map, because many of the tensions come from distance and terrain.

The map of this part is surprisingly compact. It is about 30 km from Jerusalem to Hebron, a little over 15 km to Bethel, and about 150 km in a straight line to the Sea of Galilee. The central hills offered shelter and water, the Jezreel Valley opened the way to the coast and Damascus, and the coastal route linked Egypt with Mesopotamia. Whoever controlled Megiddo, Hazor, and Gezer watched the merchants carrying goods from one empire to another. That is why, for every chapter of this part, it matters not only what happened, but also where and under what conditions.

The story does not end with the golden age. After Solomon's death, around 931 BC, the kingdom splits into two states: Judah with Jerusalem in the south and Israel with its capital in Samaria in the north. Against this background prophets appear, among them Elijah, who stands on Mount Carmel before King Ahab. The twelve places in this part lead you from Gibeah to the Valley of

Jezreel; some of them are artistic reconstructions based on excavations. Notice how the mood of the story changes from place to place: from cramped mountain villages to wide valleys and the coast.

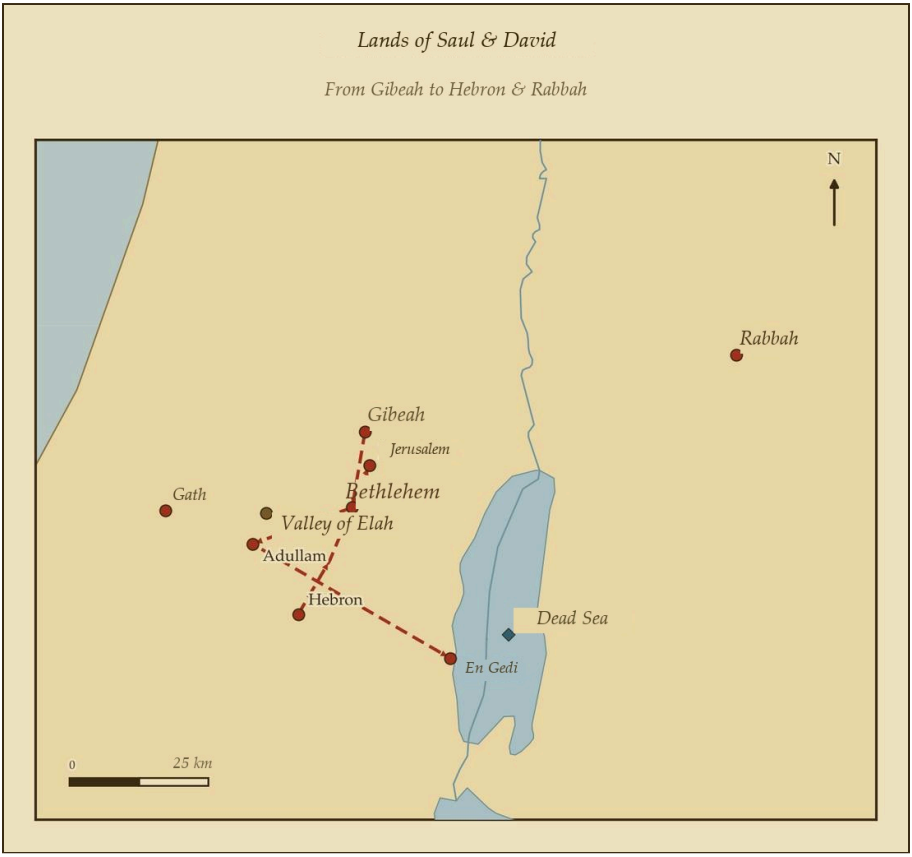
## INDEX OF PLACES AND SCENES


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HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

The maps show routes and the locations of places; the illustrations are artistic reconstructions based on archaeological knowledge, not photographs. Distances and dimensions are approximate.

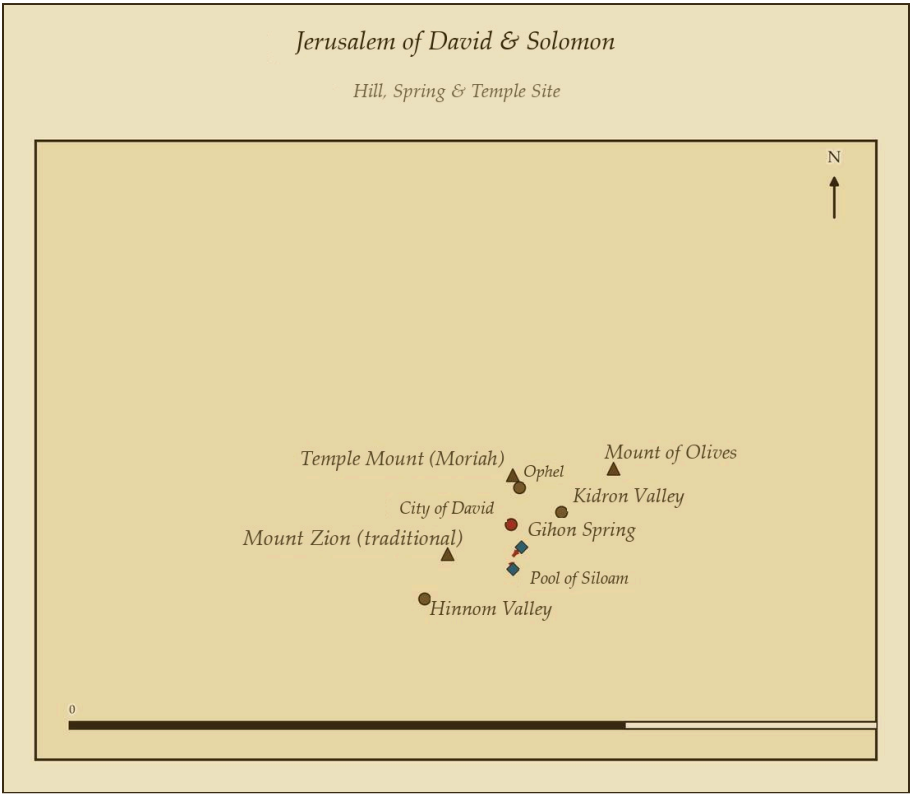
MAP 5.1




*The first line shows David's flight from Saul, and the second his move from Hebron to Jerusalem. The hills of Judah and Benjamin lie in the middle, the Philistines to the west, the Ammonites to the east.*

The map shows how small the territory of the first kings was: it is only about 35 km from Gibeah to Hebron. Saul held the north of the hills, David started from the south, and Jerusalem lay between them. The Philistines pressed in from the west through the valleys, and the Ammonites from the highlands of Transjordan. This makes it easier to understand why David sought refuge in the wilderness by the Dead Sea, and why a capital on the border between tribes gave him an advantage.

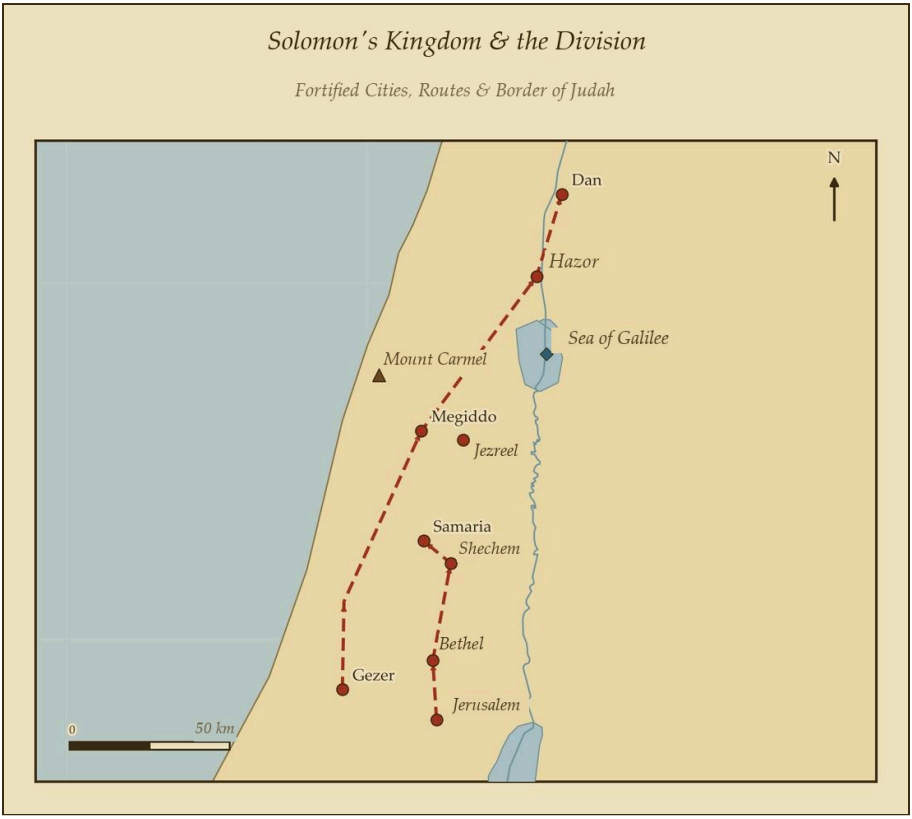
MAP 5.2




*The map shows a very small area. The narrow hill of the City of David lies above the Gihon Spring, and to the north rises the Temple Mount. The line shows the later water tunnel built under Hezekiah (2 Kgs 20:20).*

David's capital occupied a small ridge surrounded by the Kidron and Hinnom valleys. The Gihon Spring supplied water but lay outside the walls, so later generations built tunnels to conceal it. Solomon moved the center of power north, to the temple hill, and joined it to the old city. The map shows how compact Jerusalem was: walking from one end to the other took a few minutes.

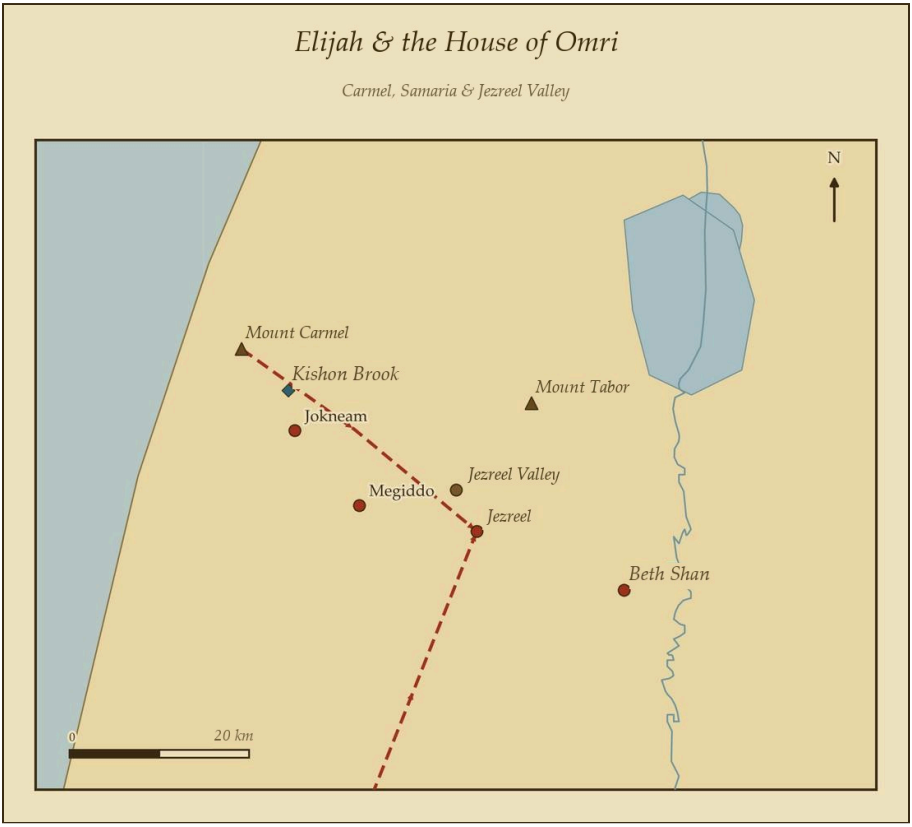
MAP 5.3




*The first line shows the ancient coastal route along which Solomon fortified cities. The second runs through the hills from Jerusalem by way of Bethel and Shechem to Samaria. The dividing border ran near Bethel.*

Solomon strung his fortresses along the Via Maris like beads on a string: Gezer, Megiddo, Hazor. After his death, around 931 BC, the land divided along the border of Benjamin. Judah kept Jerusalem and the hills of the south, while Israel received the fertile north, with its valleys and routes. Bethel and Dan became sanctuaries and Samaria the capital. The map shows why the north was richer and the south harder to conquer.

MAP 5.4



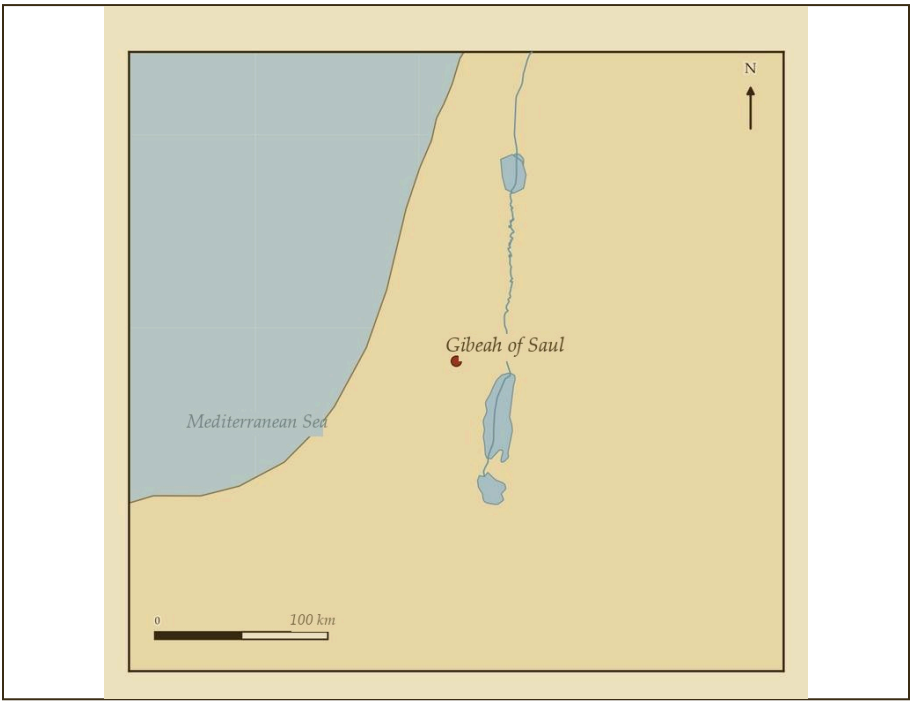

*The map shows the north of the kingdom of Israel. The first line shows the road from Carmel to Jezreel that, according to the text, Ahab traveled while the prophet ran ahead of his chariot. The second links the capital with the summer residence.*

The dynasty of Omri ruled from Samaria but loved Jezreel, where the climate was milder and the soil fertile. Carmel, by the sea, separated the valley from the coast, and it was there that the struggle took place over whom the people would trust with their faith. The distance from Carmel to Jezreel is about 30 km, which explains the account of the prophet running ahead of the chariot. The map shows that the events of Elijah's life unfolded in an area no bigger than a single modern municipality.

# 01 Gibeah of Saul

1 SAM 10; 1 SAM 13–15; 1 SAM 22

*The modest seat of Israel's first king on the hill of Benjamin.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Tradition points to Tell el-Ful, a flat-topped mound above present-day Jerusalem. The artistic reconstruction shows a small fortress with a thick wall of rough stones, a corner tower, and a few mud-brick houses. Around it stretch terraces of barley, olive trees, and flocks of sheep. The dust of the mountain road hangs over everything, and in the distance the ridges of Judah can be seen. Over it all one senses a stark simplicity: no columns, no marble, only sturdiness and the smoke of cooking fires.

The Book of Samuel tells how Saul, son of Kish of the tribe of Benjamin, was anointed by the prophet Samuel and proclaimed king. Yet he did not settle in a palace: he returned to Gibeah, where he governed among shepherds and farmers. His court was modest, and his power rested on constant readiness for war. When the Philistines threatened the land, he gathered volunteers from around Gibeah and Michmash. Over time his relations with Samuel and with the young David soured, which the biblical authors present as the drama of a rejected ruler. For the reader, what matters is that the Book of Samuel does not hide the tensions: the king could be unsure and fearful, and his decisions stirred conflict with the prophet.

Gibeah lay on a mountain ridge about 5 km north of what would become Jerusalem, beside the road running along the central hills from south to north. This hill of Benjamin was an observation point: from here one could see Jerusalem, the valleys descending toward the Jordan, and the movements of armies coming from the west. Narrow passes, such as nearby Michmash, allowed a small army to hold back a far larger enemy. This explains why the first king chose a defensible place rather than a trading center. A place like this explains well the style of the first government: a small capital, closeness to the fields, and constant vigilance against a threat that could come from any side.

FACTS

Hill elevation approx. 840 m above sea level; distance to Jerusalem approx. 5 km.

# 02 Valley of Elah

1SAM17

*The battlefield of David and Goliath between Socoh and Azekah.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a wide valley with a shallow, stony brook in the middle. On one slope stands the Philistine camp with tents and bronze shields, on the other a plainer Israelite encampment among olive groves. Between them, far off, two tiny figures face each other. The air is dry, the light sharp, and spreading terebinth trees grow over the valley. The rest of the picture is the stillness before the clash: the clink of metal, the snorting of animals, and the short shouts of commanders carry far.

According to the Book of Samuel, the Philistines gathered their forces at Socoh in Judah, and Saul drew up the Israelites on the other side of the Valley of Elah. For many days the giant Goliath came out of the enemy camp, challenging the Israelites to fight. David, who had brought food to his brothers, could no longer bear to watch this humiliation. He rejected Saul's armor and took a staff, a sling, and a few smooth stones from the brook. He defeated his opponent, and the Philistines fled toward Gath and Ekron, pursued by the Israelites. The story also has a symbolic dimension, but its setting is very concrete: two armies, one valley, and a local brook that supplied the stones.

The Valley of Elah, today Wadi es-Sant, is a natural boundary between the Shephelah and the hills of Judah. It runs from east to west and opens the way for the Philistines from the coastal plain toward Bethlehem and Hebron. The slopes are gentle, the valley floor wide and strewn with stones, which explains the motif of the sling. For the Israelites, control of this valley meant the defense of the hills. Archaeologists are studying a fortified city from David's time nearby, Khirbet Qeiyafa, though its connection to the duel itself remains a matter of debate. Geography thus hints at why this valley kept returning in history: whoever stood on the hill saw the enemy's movements, and whoever went down to the bottom exposed himself to fire.

FACTS

From Khirbet Qeiyafa to Jerusalem approx. 30 km; the valley is approx. 2–3 km wide.


N
Valley of Elah
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

# 03 Hebron

2 SAM 2–5; GEN 23

*David's first capital as king of Judah.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a town on a hillside, with closely packed stone houses, narrow lanes, and a square by the gate where the elders gathered. Around it are cascading terraces of grapevines, olive groves, and herds of goats. The backdrop is the pale limestone hills of Judah, and the air is cooler than in the desert to the east. In the evening smoke rises from the chimneys, and from below come the voices of shepherds calling their flocks into the pens.

5.3 · HEBRON · 2 SAM 2–5; GEN 23

After Saul's death, David asks God where he should go and sets out for Hebron. The elders of Judah anoint him here as king of their tribe, while the north remains with the house of Saul. Years of civil war follow, until the killing of the commander Abner and of King Ish-bosheth. Then the representatives of the tribes come to Hebron and recognize David as ruler of all the Israelites. The Book of Samuel says that he reigned in Hebron for about seven and a half years and later moved to Jerusalem. Hebron remains important afterward too: it is here that Absalom will declare his rebellion against his father, and the city will long keep its significance for the tribe of Judah.

Hebron lies about 30 km south of Jerusalem, at an elevation of about 930 m above sea level, the highest of all the major cities of Judah. The surrounding area is fertile: vineyards, olive groves, and pastures gave the town wealth, and the nearby Cave of Machpelah is associated with the tombs of the patriarchs. Roads led from Hebron to Beersheba and the Negev and to the coast. For David, who came from the tribe of Judah, it was a natural base, but too far from the northern tribes to rule the whole land. The choice of place shows the first phase of David's reign, when he relied on his own tribe and friends from the south, before he built a state covering the entire land.

FACTS

Distance to Jerusalem approx. 30 km; elevation approx. 930 m above sea level.

# 04 City of David in Jerusalem

2 SAM 5–6; 1 CHR 11

*The Jebusite stronghold that became the capital of all Israel.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

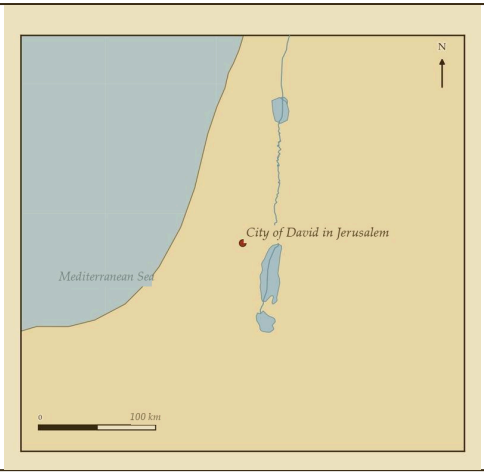
The artistic reconstruction shows a tightly built ridge, descending in terraces toward the Kidron Valley. Stone houses rise one above another, and above them stands a fortified citadel. On the east side a path leads to the Gihon Spring, where women fill their jars. In the background, to the north, lies a still-empty plateau on which the temple was built later. The whole gives the impression of a dense settlement stretched along the ridge, full of the smells of smoke, herbs, and sun-warmed stone.

After being crowned over all Israel, David turns against Jerusalem, which the Jebusites still held. The inhabitants felt safe behind their walls, but David's troops entered the city through the so-called water shaft; the Hebrew text uses a rare word here, whose meaning scholars debate. David occupies the stronghold, builds walls around it, and calls it the City of David. Then he brings the Ark of the Covenant here with great joy, dancing before it. Jerusalem becomes the political and religious capital. The transfer of the Ark joins power and worship in this story: the king not only captures a city but makes it the place toward which the whole people are heading.

The choice was deliberate. Jerusalem lies on the border of Judah and Benjamin, so it favored neither side. The narrow hill between the Kidron and Tyropoeon valleys was easy to defend, and the Gihon Spring at its foot gave a constant water supply. The city stood away from the main trade routes, which protected it from threats but required access roads. David gained a capital that was neutral between the tribes and militarily secure. Note the order: first the fortress and walls, then the sanctuary, and only years later the temple, which shows the gradual maturing of the capital.

FACTS

Area of the ancient city approx. 5 hectares; the Gihon Spring approx. 100 m from the top of the hill.


N
City of David in Jerusalem
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

# 05 Rabbah of the Ammonites

2 SAM 10–12

*The city besieged by Joab, where David's drama unfolded.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a fortified hill above a dry valley, with a row of houses clinging to the slope and a wide gate. At the foot, along a brook, stand the tents of the besiegers, and helmets gleam on the walls among the defenders. The surroundings are open, barren, covered with low shrubs and limestone boulders. The air is full of dust and the sound of horn signals, and in the distance Ammonite shepherds' flocks graze.

When the king of the Ammonites insulted David's envoys, war broke out. Joab, the commander of the army, besieged Rabbah, the Ammonite capital, while David remained in Jerusalem. There the events with Bathsheba and Uriah the Hittite took place, whom the king sent to the front line so that he would die. The prophet Nathan tells a parable and accuses the king. David admits his guilt. Meanwhile Joab captures part of the city, the so-called city of waters, and summons the king to take the rest himself. These scenes set two worlds side by side: the battlefield, where soldiers carry out orders, and the palace, where the ruler forgets responsibility for his own deeds.

Rabbah lay on the hills of present-day Amman, across the Jordan, about 65 km in a straight line from Jerusalem. The road led down to the Jordan Valley and then steeply up the slopes of Transjordan, which meant two to three days' march for an army. By the springs of the Jabbok River the city had a steady water supply, so a siege was long. This distance explains why the king could stay in the capital while the war was fought far from his sight. The biblical authors do not hide the shadow over the most famous king, and the geographic description helps us grasp how great a distance separated decisions from their consequences.

FACTS

Distance to Jerusalem approx. 65 km in a straight line; elevation approx. 800–850 m above sea level.

# 06 Solomon's Temple

1 KGS 5–8; 2 CHR 2–7

*The first temple on Mount Moriah, built in about seven years.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a rectangular building of pale stone, with two freestanding pillars at the entrance and low chambers on the sides. Before it lies a courtyard with a great altar and a bronze basin on the backs of bull figures. The interior remains unseen, shielded by cedar doors. Workers in the background are laying the last blocks of the wall. The golden elements inside reflect the light of lamps, and the scent of cedar and incense fills the whole courtyard.

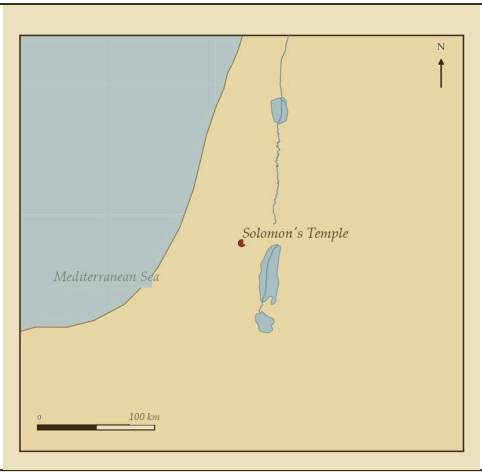
## 5.6 · SOLOMON'S TEMPLE · 1KGS 5–8; 2CHR 2–7

The Book of Kings tells how Solomon made an agreement with Hiram, king of Tyre, who supplied cedar and cypress timber and craftsmen. The work lasted about seven years. The temple consisted of a porch, a main hall, and the most holy place, where the Ark of the Covenant stood. The interior was covered with wood and gold and adorned with carved cherubim, palm trees, and flowers. At the dedication Solomon prayed over the people, asking that God hear those who turn toward this place. The account in Chronicles stresses David's preparations: he gathered materials and plans, though he himself was not permitted to build the temple.

The building stood north of the old city, on the hill that tradition links with Mount Moriah. Solomon had to widen the plateau by raising retaining walls around it. The stone was quarried nearby, and the timber was floated from Lebanon by sea to Joppa and then hauled to the hills of Judah, a climb of about 60 km. The location itself set the temple apart: it stood higher than the palaces and the city and was visible from every side. Archaeology has not found the building itself, because later temples stood on its site, so every picture is a reconstruction based on the text and on comparison with similar buildings of the region.

### FACTS

Dimensions of the main hall according to the text: 60 × 20 × 30 cubits, or about 27 × 9 × 13.5 m.


N
Solomon's Temple
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

# 07 Megiddo

1 KGS 9:15; 1 KGS 4:12; 2 KGS 23:29

*A fortified crossroads at the entrance to the Jezreel Valley.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a tall, oval mound above a green plain, surrounded by stone walls and a gate with several guard chambers. Inside are barracks and large structures that scholars interpret as stables or storehouses. On the road at the foot, a caravan of donkeys and camels passes, and in the distance the ridge of Carmel gleams. Roads run at the foot of the wall like broad ribbons, and among the fields lie small villages dependent on the city.

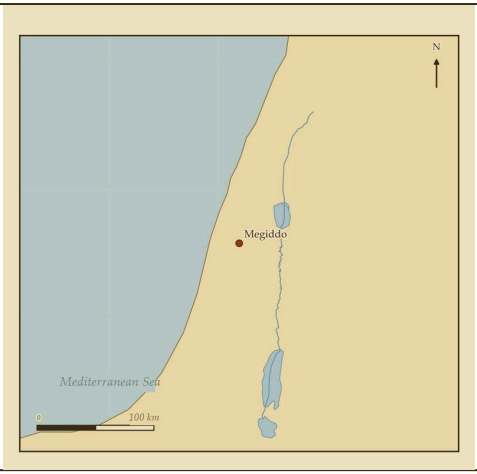
5.7 · MEGIDDO · 1 KGS 9:15; 1 KGS 4:12; 2 KGS 23:29

The Book of Kings lists Megiddo among the cities that Solomon built up, together with Hazor and Gezer. This was meant to secure control of the most important trade artery. Alongside barracks and storehouses, gates were erected, and scholarly tradition describes a multi-chambered gate from Solomon's time, though its dating is debated. Later, near the city, King Josiah was killed in a clash with Pharaoh Necho (2 Kgs 23). That is why Megiddo went down in history as a place of battles. From a biblical perspective, fortifications served not only war: they allowed tolls to be collected from caravans, secured supplies, and strengthened the ruler's prestige before his neighbors.

Tel Megiddo rises on the edge of the Jezreel Valley, at a narrow pass through the Carmel hills, about 30 km from the coast. Through this pass ran the coastal route, the Via Maris, linking Egypt with Syria and onward to Mesopotamia. Whoever held this pass could levy tolls and stop armies. Archaeological discoveries confirm that the city existed continuously for millennia, with traces of destruction and rebuilding appearing layer upon layer. The name Har-Magedon in the Book of Revelation, written in its Greek form, refers to this hill, though its exact understanding remains a subject of scholarly study.

FACTS

Height of the mound approx. 60 m above its surroundings; approx. 30 distinct settlement layers.


N
Megiddo
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

# 08 Hazor and Gezer

1 KGS 9:15–17; JOSH 11:10

*The largest city of Canaan and its counterpart in the west.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a flat mound above a valley, with a massive wall surrounding the upper city. Against the backdrop of the dark hills of Galilee stands a gate with towers, and beyond it wide wheat fields. Before the gate merchants bustle with heavy sacks, soldiers guard the entrance, and smoke rises from chimneys. As the sun sets, the walls turn a rusty color, and the guards light torches on the towers.

The text of the First Book of Kings joins three cities: Hazor, Megiddo, and Gezer. Solomon rebuilt all of them as part of a fortification program. Gezer, according to the narrative, was captured by Pharaoh, who burned the city and gave it to his daughter as a dowry. Solomon rebuilt it. These three points formed a defensive and tax system and, at the same time, showed that the kingdom had formed ties with neighboring powers, including Egypt. It is worth remembering that this is an overall picture: the Bible describes here the king's building plan, and archaeologists compare it with the layers of walls and gates uncovered in the three cities.

Hazor lay in the north, above the Huleh Valley, about 15 km north of the Sea of Galilee. It was a great hub where roads from Damascus, Phoenicia, and Egypt met. The upper city covered under 10 hectares, but the lower, according to research, about 70 hectares, making it the largest center of Canaan. Gezer, by contrast, guarded the western road to Jerusalem, running through the Shephelah. Both cities lay on the edges of the kingdom, where the question of borders was decided. Gezer also shows relations with Egypt: marriage to the Pharaoh's daughter was regarded as an honor, and her dowry was a real political gesture toward the young kingdom.

FACTS

Lower city of Hazor approx. 70 hectares; distance to Dan approx. 20 km.

# 09 Dan and Bethel

1 KGS 12:25–33

*Jeroboam's two sanctuaries at the ends of the northern kingdom.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a sanctuary on a rise by springs, with a raised worship platform and an altar of hewn stone. Tall trees grow around it and water murmurs, which sets Dan apart from the dry lands of the south. Priests and pilgrims in plain robes approach up the steps, and in the background the snowy cap of Mount Hermon can be seen. Even without sculptures and ornaments the place looks solemn, and the sound of the springs fills the whole area.

After Solomon's death, his son Rehoboam rejected the request for lighter taxes, and the northern tribes chose Jeroboam as king. He feared that pilgrimages to Jerusalem would lead the people to return to the rule of Judah. So he appointed two centers of worship, Bethel on the southern border and Dan on the northern, and set up golden calves in them. The author of the Book of Kings regards this step as a sin that weighed on the kings of Israel for centuries. The division of the kingdom was not only a matter of politics. It was tied to the memory of ancient sanctuaries and to the question of where the people should offer sacrifices and keep the feasts.

The choice of places made geographic sense. Bethel lies about 17 km north of Jerusalem, on the main road of the hills, and had been a holy place since the time of the patriarchs. Dan lies far in the north, by the sources of the Jordan, about 150 km from Jerusalem. The two sanctuaries covered the whole land and gave pilgrims a substitute for Jerusalem's worship closer to home. Politically it was a shrewd move, showing how closely religion and borders are bound together. The prophets of later centuries would return to these two places as an example of true worship mixed with political calculation, and the Books of Kings repeat this judgment many times.

FACTS

Dan: approx. 150 km in a straight line from Jerusalem; Bethel: approx. 17 km.

# 10 Samaria

1 KGS 16:23–28; 1 KGS 20; 2 KGS 6–7

*The capital of the northern kingdom, founded by Omri.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a round hill surrounded by a double wall of well-dressed blocks. At the top stands a palace with a courtyard, and a paved road leads up to it from the fields. Below stretch barley fields and vineyards, and in the background the gentle hills of Samaria. The atmosphere is more lavish than in Gibeah. From the walls one sees the wide countryside, and in the valley farmers work among terraces and olive groves.

The Book of Kings says that Omri bought the hill from Shemer for two talents of silver and built a city on it, which he named Samaria. His son Ahab married Jezebel, daughter of the king of Sidon, and built a temple of Baal in the capital. The city was besieged several times by the Arameans. The stories of Elisha and the famine in Samaria show how strongly harsh conditions affected the lives of its inhabitants. In the end Samaria fell in 722 BC to Assyria. Samaria later gave its name to the whole region and its people, and its role in the New Testament, where it appears in the encounters of Jesus and the apostles, reaches many centuries further.

The choice of the hill was deliberate. It lies in the central hills, about 10 km northwest of Shechem, at an elevation of about 430 m above sea level, with a flat, wide valley all around. The city stood on its own rise, free of competition from old tribal centers, yet close to the road to the coast and the Jezreel Valley. Archaeologists have uncovered monumental walls and ivory that decorated furniture, which agrees with the mention of the house of ivory (1 Kgs 22:39). The biblical text describes here not only politics but also a conflict of values: kings sought alliances with their neighbors, while prophets demanded faithfulness to the covenant.

FACTS

Hill elevation approx. 430 m above sea level; purchase price according to the text: 2 talents of silver.


N
Samaria
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

# 11 Mount Carmel

1 KGS 18

*The site of Elijah's contest with the prophets of Baal.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a rocky summit covered with oaks, shrubs, and wild herbs. On a flat spot stands an altar of twelve stones, and a crowd of villagers and soldiers gathers around it. Far behind them a strip of sea shimmers, and on the horizon the first small cloud appears. The wind carries the scent of resin and the moisture off the sea, and the shadows of clouds drift across the slopes.

After three years of drought, Elijah summons King Ahab to gather the people and the prophets of Baal on Mount Carmel. The question is to be settled here: which God is true. The prophets of Baal cry out from morning until noon, but no one answers. Elijah rebuilds the altar, arranges the offering, and pours water over it. Only then does he pray, and fire falls from heaven. The people declare their faith in the God of Israel. Then the prophet climbs up and prays for rain, while his servant watches for a cloud over the sea. The story also contains a moment of silence: after the roar and the fire, the prophet is weary and discouraged, and the story leads him on into the desert and as far as Mount Horeb (1 Kgs 19).

Carmel is a limestone ridge about 25 km long, running from the coast toward the Jezreel Valley. Its peaks reach about 550 m above sea level. From the west comes moist air off the sea, which even in a drought brings dew and lush vegetation here, which is why Carmel was associated with fertility. From the upper parts one can see both the Mediterranean Sea and the Kishon Valley, where the sentence was later carried out. This explains why this very place was chosen. It is one of the most famous scenes of the Old Testament, in which geography, weather, and faith form one coherent story about trust.

FACTS

Ridge about 25 km long; highest point approx. 550 m above sea level.


N
Mount Carmel
Mediterranean Sea
0
50 km

# 12 Jezreel

1 KGS 21; 2 KGS 9–10

*Ahab's summer residence and Naboth's vineyard.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a fortified palace on a small rise, with a watchtower taller than the walls. At its feet stretch vineyards and wheat fields, and beyond them a wide green valley as far as the mountains of Gilboa. The road runs straight across the plain, allowing riders approaching to be spotted from afar. In the evening the valley fills with golden light, and the roads vanish in the mist rising over the fields.

5.12 · JEZREEL · 1 KGS 21; 2 KGS 9–10

In Jezreel Ahab had a palace next to Naboth's vineyard. When the king wanted to acquire it, Naboth refused, appealing to the inheritance of his ancestors. Jezebel forged documents, and Naboth was put to death. Elijah announced the punishment to Ahab. Years later the prophecy was fulfilled: Jehu, anointed king, rode into Jezreel and killed Joram, and Jezebel was thrown from a window. Thus the dynasty of Omri came to an end. This scene closes the cycle of stories about Elijah and Ahab. The prophet foretold the fall of the dynasty, and the events in Jezreel show how severely the violation of an ordinary man's rights was judged.

Jezreel lies on the eastern edge of the Jezreel Valley, about 20 km from Megiddo, on a small rise overlooking a wide, fertile plain. The valley is the most fertile region of Israel: it runs from Carmel to the Jordan for about 40 km. Military and trade roads crossed here, so a ruler living in Jezreel could see an approaching army in advance. From the tower Jehu could be seen approaching from Ramoth Gilead. The Jezreel Valley appears in the Bible many times, from the days of Gideon to Josiah, and always as a place where the fate of the land is weighed.

FACTS

Length of the Jezreel Valley approx. 40 km; distance to Megiddo approx. 20 km.

# Questions for Reflection

1. Why did David choose Jerusalem as his capital rather than Hebron, and what did that say about his way of ruling?

2. How did the location of Megiddo, Hazor, and Gezer help Solomon control trade and the security of the kingdom?

3. What does the story of Elijah on Mount Carmel say about the relationship between faith, power, and the people's trust in their leaders?

# 06

PART 6 OF 9

# Prophets, Exile and Return

2 KGS 17–25; ISA; JER; EZEK; DAN; JONAH; EZRA; NEH; ESTH

*From the fall of Samaria through the ruins of Jerusalem and the banks of the Chebar to the rebuilt walls of the city.*



# Three Powers and One Small Land

This part spans about three hundred years, from the eighth to the fifth century BC, when the map of the Near East was changing faster than ever before. First Assyria rises, with its capital at Nineveh, and its armies reach the Jordan and the Nile. Then Babylon takes its place, and finally Persia, the largest state the world had yet seen. Between these powers live the small kingdoms of Israel and Judah, squeezed onto a strip of hills between the sea and the desert. The prophets Isaiah, Jeremiah and Ezekiel did not speak in a vacuum: they knew the roads, cities and armies they warned about.

The geography of this age is above all a geography of roads. The great routes from Mesopotamia to Egypt ran through the land of Israel or right beside it, so every military campaign began with the country lying in its path. Samaria fell in 722 BC and Jerusalem in 587 or 586, and part of the population walked hundreds of kilometers east, to the canals of Babylonia. Picture that march: weeks on the road, dust, the Euphrates alongside the route, and the question of whether God was still near. The books of 2 Kings, Jeremiah and Ezekiel answer it with remarkable honesty.

Yet this story does not end in ruins. The edict of Cyrus allows the exiles to return, and then Zerubbabel, Ezra and Nehemiah rebuild the Temple, the walls and a community gathered around the Law. The books of Esther and Daniel, meanwhile, show the life of those who stayed in the empire's great cities: in Babylon and Susa. In this part you will visit twelve places, from Assyrian Nineveh to the walls of Jerusalem, and look at four maps that put the events together into one picture. We give dates with caution: they are the conclusions of historians, and exact values are sometimes debated.

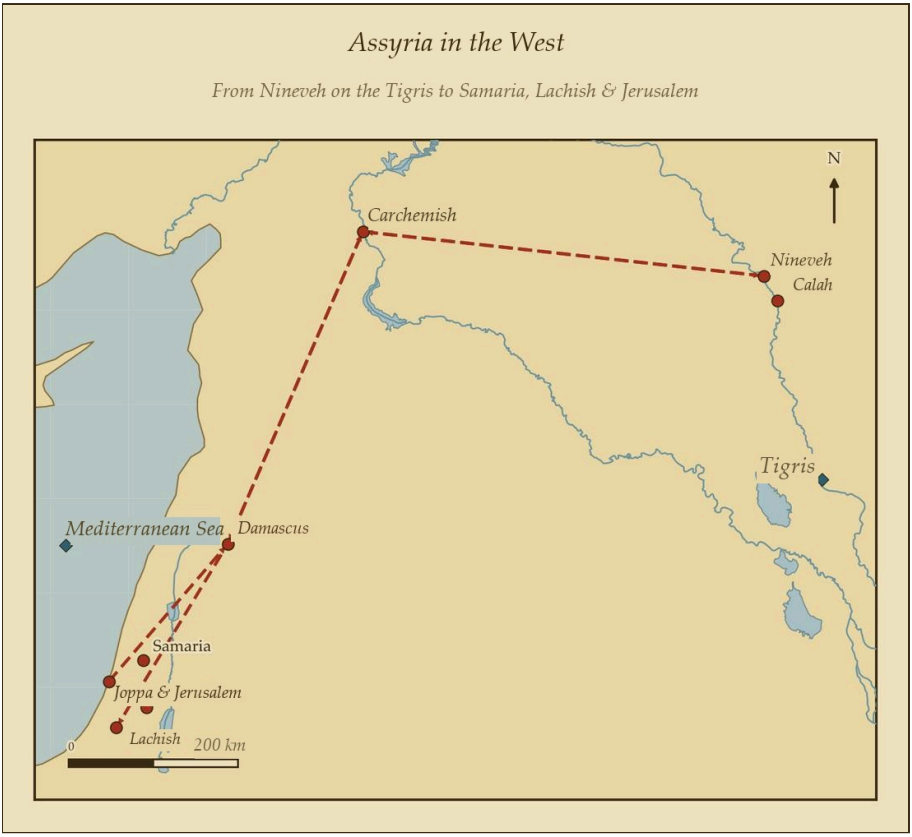
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HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

The maps show routes and the locations of places; the illustrations are artistic reconstructions based on archaeological knowledge, not photographs. Distances and dimensions are approximate.

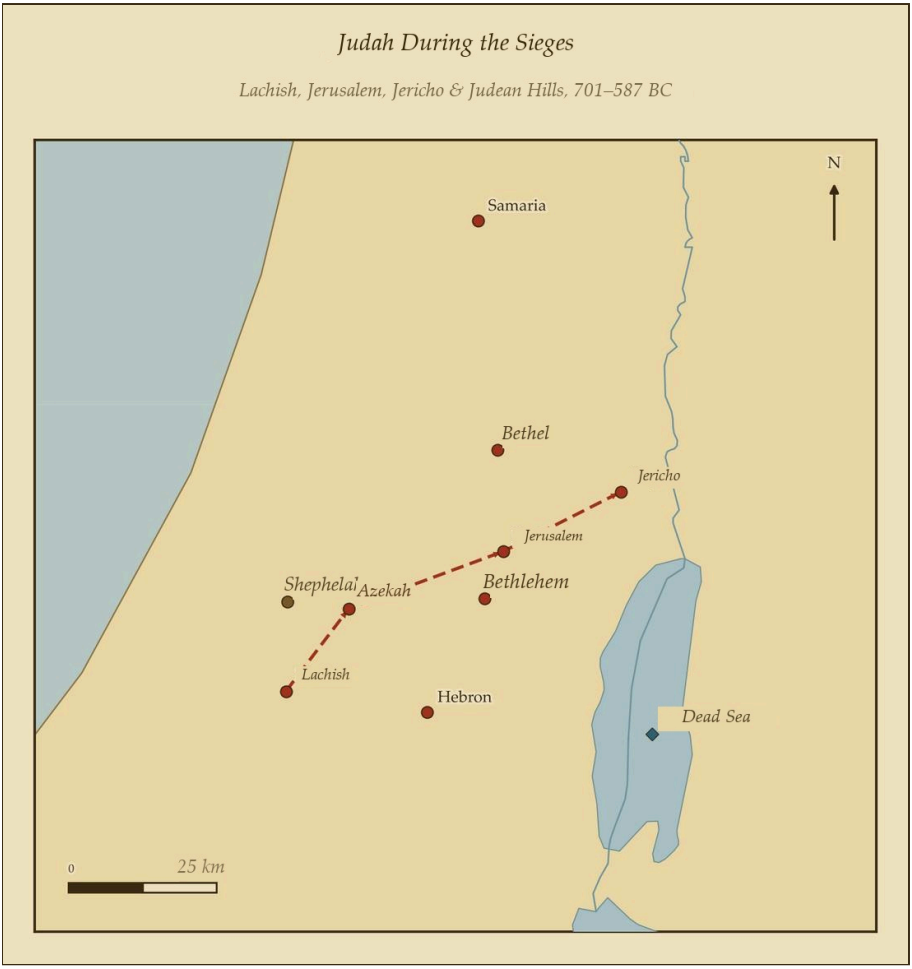
MAP 6.1




*The dots mark cities and bodies of water, and the guide lines mark the routes taken by armies and messengers. They are not exact road courses.*

The map shows why the small Northern Kingdom and Judah found themselves on the line of conflict. From Nineveh on the Tigris to Samaria was more than a thousand kilometers of marching, yet Assyrian armies covered such a distance every year. Their route ran through Syria, and the last stretches led across the coastal plain toward the hills of Judea. Note the position of Lachish: whoever controlled it had an open road to Jerusalem.

MAP 6.2




*The vertical difference in elevation is the key to this map: in the west lies the Shephelah, in the middle the hills of Judea, in the east the deep Jordan Valley and the Dead Sea. The lines mark approximate routes of invasion and flight.*

This map shows an area of about 100 by 130 km, and the events took place within it. Sennacherib's troops came from the west, from Lachish, climbing from the Shephelah toward the hills. Zedekiah fled east, toward the desert, and was

captured near Jericho. The map shows that Jerusalem stands in the mountains, whose slopes protect it from the east, and that access leads mainly from the west and north.

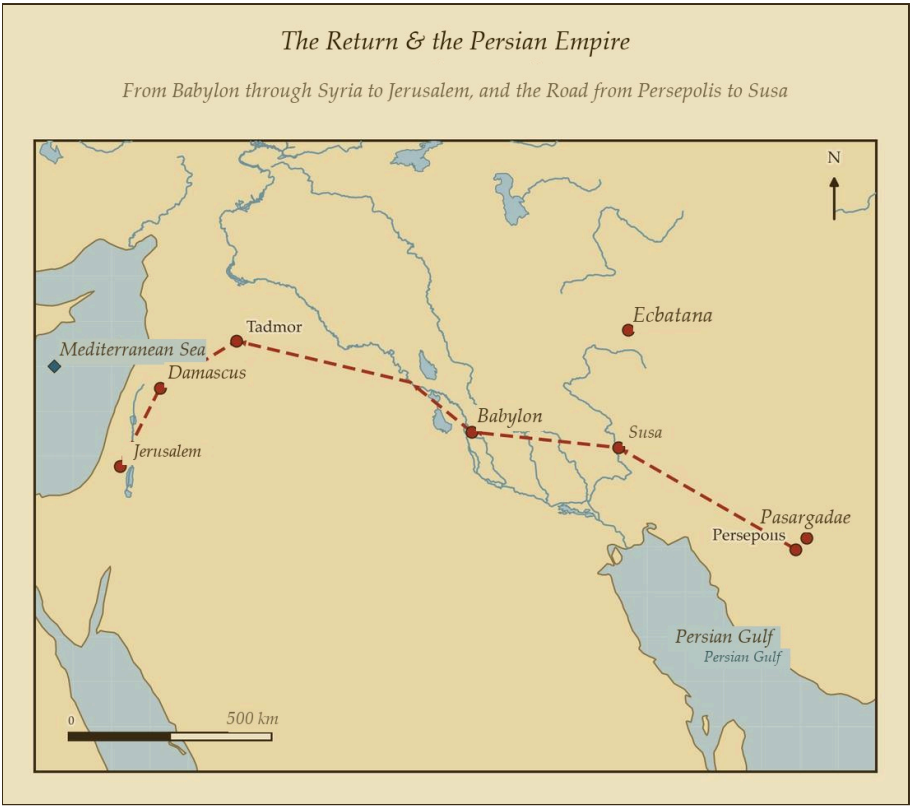
MAP 6.3




*The map shows lower Mesopotamia, the plain between the Euphrates and the Tigris. The location of the Chebar near Nippur is traditional and uncertain.*

The exiles came to a land as flat as a table, cut by a network of canals. In such a landscape farming depended on water, and cities like Babylon, Nippur and Uruk grew up along rivers and canals. Ezekiel lived beside one of them. It is worth noting that it was about 350 km from Babylon to Susa, so the Persians, who took over this region, could efficiently link east with west.

MAP 6.4




*This map covers the western part of the Persian Empire, from the Mediterranean Sea to the Zagros Mountains. The lines are approximate routes, not exact road courses.*

The road from Babylon to Jerusalem did not run in a straight line, because a caravan could not cross the Syrian Desert. Travelers went in an arc along the Euphrates, through Tadmor and Damascus, which made about 1,400 km. The map also shows that Susa lies in the middle of the empire: between Persepolis and Babylon. From such a place the Persian kings sent out the decrees that made the rebuilding of the Temple and the walls possible.

# 01 Nineveh

JONAH 1–4; NAH 1–3

*The great capital of Assyria, to which God sends a reluctant prophet.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

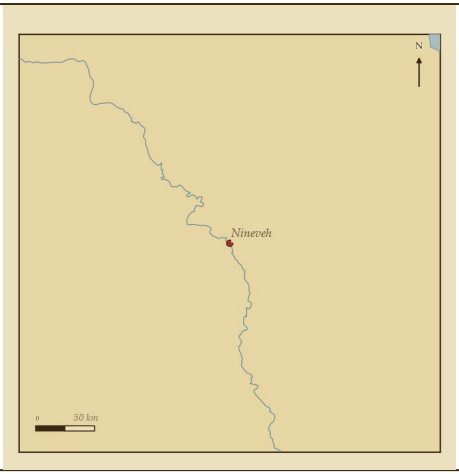
The artistic reconstruction shows a city surrounded by mighty walls with great gates, above which rise the terraces of palaces and temples. The walls of the buildings, made of sun-dried brick and faced with stone slabs, were adorned with reliefs of hunts and military campaigns. Caravans of donkeys mill about before the gate, and over the river canals and gardens can be seen. In the distance, on a hill, stands the tiny figure of a wanderer gazing at the immensity of the city.

The Book of Jonah tells of a prophet who is to go to Nineveh and warn its inhabitants of judgment. Jonah, however, boards a ship sailing the opposite way, and a storm and a stay inside a great fish finally send him obediently on his way. His short call brings repentance among the people, from the king to the animals. The prophet is surprised, and even resentful, at God's forgiveness. The book ends with God's question, addressed also to the reader, whether He has no right to take pity on so great a city.

Nineveh lay on the eastern bank of the Tigris, opposite present-day Mosul in Iraq, about 800 km in a straight line from Jerusalem. On foot, this meant many weeks of marching through Syria and northern Mesopotamia. Fertile plains, watered from the Taurus and Zagros mountains, could feed an enormous population. From here the armies of Assyria set out west, toward the coast of the Mediterranean. In going to Nineveh, Jonah was therefore going to the heart of the power that threatened his own nation. The mention of “a three days’ journey” probably refers to the extent of the city together with its surrounding settlements.

FACTS

The walls of Nineveh from the time of Sennacherib were about 12 km around.


N
Nineveh
0
50 km

# 02 Samaria

1 KGS 16:24; 2 KGS 17; AMOS 3–6

*The capital of the Northern Kingdom, captured by Assyria in 722 BC.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a hill crowned by an acropolis with a royal palace, surrounded by a double wall of hewn stone. Below, on terraces, stand houses of stone and wood, and around them can be seen wheat fields, vineyards and olive groves. On a side road a column of captives winds along, guarded by soldiers: a symbol of the tragedy of 722. At the top of the hill the pale hewn stones of the palace gleam, and from the gates merchants with donkeys head down toward the valley.

King Omri founded Samaria as a new capital, and his successors, Ahab and the rulers after him, built it up into a magnificent city. Prophets such as Amos and Hosea, however, rebuked its people for injustice toward the poor and for worshiping foreign gods. According to 2 Kgs 17, Shalmaneser V besieged the city for three years, and his successor, Sargon II, according to Assyrian sources, finished the job in 722 or 721 BC. Part of the population was deported to Assyria and Media, and newcomers from other regions were settled in the land. The Northern Kingdom ceased to exist as a state.

Samaria stood on a solitary, oval hill rising about 100 m above the surrounding valleys, in the central hills of Ephraim. Its steep, easily defended position and the fertile fields around it explain why the city withstood such a long siege. At the same time, it lay close to important routes leading from the coast toward the Jordan Valley, which made it a tempting target. For Assyria, taking Samaria opened the way south, toward Judah, and secured the rear of campaigns aimed at Egypt. Today its remains lie near the Arab village of Sebastia.

FACTS

The hill of Samaria rises about 100 m above the surrounding valley; the siege lasted about 3 years.

# 03 Lachish

2 KGS 18:13–17; 2 CHR 32:9; MIC 1:13; ISA 36:1–2

*The second most important fortress of Judah, captured by Sennacherib in 701 BC.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows the city hill ringed with mighty walls and a gate, and on its slope a siege ramp, up which siege towers with battering rams climb. Archers fire on the walls, defenders hurl down burning torches, and smoke rises over the battlefield. In the background an Assyrian camp with commanders' tents can be seen. The scenes are shown from a distance, with no recognizable faces. Beneath the walls lie piles of stones, wooden ladders and a few surviving olive trees.

In the fourteenth year of King Hezekiah's reign, Sennacherib, king of Assyria, invaded Judah and captured many of its fortified cities. The books of Kings and Chronicles describe how his headquarters stopped at Lachish, from which envoys were sent to Jerusalem demanding surrender. Hezekiah tried to buy peace by sending a heavy tribute, but the Assyrians did not relent. The prophet Isaiah reassured the king, and God promised to save the city. The Book of Micah mentions Lachish in a bitter list of towns that will suffer the consequences of sin.

Lachish lay in the Shephelah, the foothills between the hills of Judea and the coastal plain, about 40 km southwest of Jerusalem. This position made it the guardian of the roads leading up to the capital from the coast and from Egypt. Whoever took it controlled access to the hills. The Assyrians did not storm the wall at a run: they built a great siege ramp of earth and stones, and the defenders answered with a counter-ramp of their own. Archaeology confirms both of these features. The scene of the capture of the city was also depicted in reliefs in Sennacherib's palace at Nineveh.

FACTS

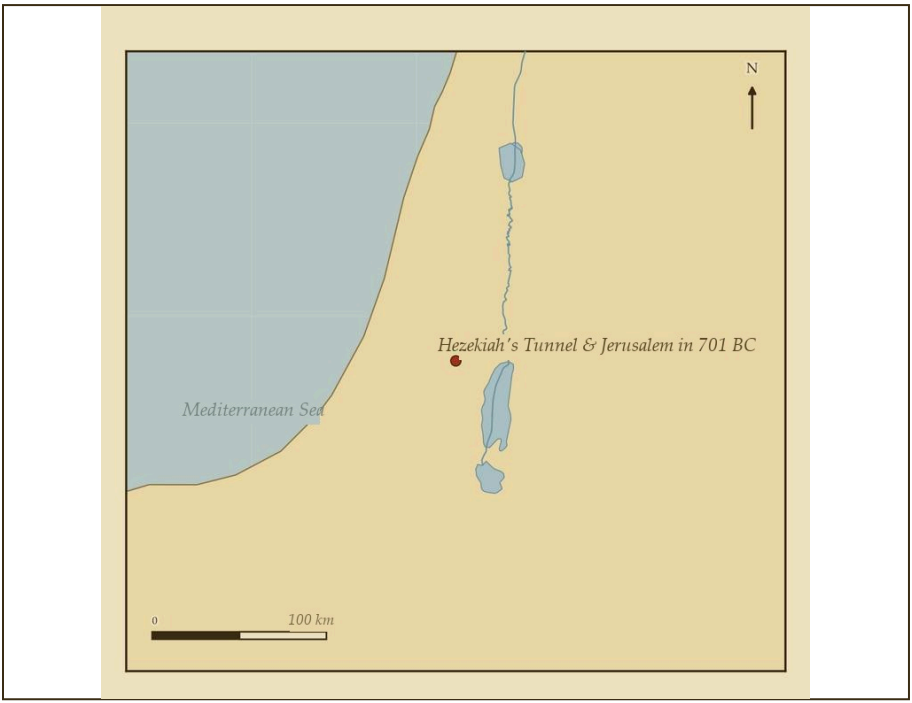
Distance from Lachish to Jerusalem: about 40 km in a straight line; the siege took place in 701 BC.


N
Lachish
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

# 04 Hezekiah's Tunnel and Jerusalem in 701 BC

2 KGS 18–20; 2 CHR 32:2–8, 30; ISA 36–37

*Jerusalem prepares for a siege, and the water goes underground.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a narrow, cramped passage cut into the rock, with ankle-deep water and chisel marks on the walls. In the light of olive-oil lamps a dark stream can be seen flowing toward the pool, while on the surface of the hill rise the walls and towers of Jerusalem. At the mouth of the tunnel people draw water in jars, not yet knowing what the next day will bring. The rock smells of damp, and the coolness of the tunnel contrasts with the heat above.

When Hezekiah saw that Assyria was approaching Jerusalem, he set about strengthening the city. According to 2 Chr 32, he repaired the walls, raised additional fortifications and saw to supplies. He also stopped up the springs outside the city so that the enemy would have no water, and he channeled water inside the fortifications. The Assyrian envoy called on the inhabitants to surrender, mocking their God, but Hezekiah prayed in the Temple. The Bible says the Assyrians withdrew from the city and Sennacherib returned to Nineveh.

Jerusalem lay on the narrow ridge of the City of David, about 700 m above sea level. The only permanent spring, Gihon, flowed outside the walls, in the Kidron Valley, and was exposed to seizure by the enemy. For this reason a tunnel about 530 m long was cut, which carries water through a rock channel to the Pool of Siloam inside the walls. It was dug from both ends at once, and the crews met in the middle. A stone inscription from Siloam, discovered in the nineteenth century, tells of this event. Today the tunnel is open to visitors; the water in it is sometimes high.

FACTS

Hezekiah's Tunnel is about 530 m long, and the difference in level between its two ends is only about 30 cm.

# 05 Jerusalem in 587 BC

2 KGS 25; 2 CHR 36:17–21; JER 39; 52; LAM 1–2

*The destruction of the city and the first Temple by the armies of Nebuchadnezzar.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows Jerusalem burning at dusk: smoke rises above the ruined temple on the hill, and breaches gape in the walls. On the slope Babylonian soldiers move among ladders and siege towers, and a long, slow procession of people carrying bundles leaves the city. The whole scene is seen from a distance, in the reddish light of the fire. Through the breaches in the walls, the dark, deserted Kidron Valley can be seen.

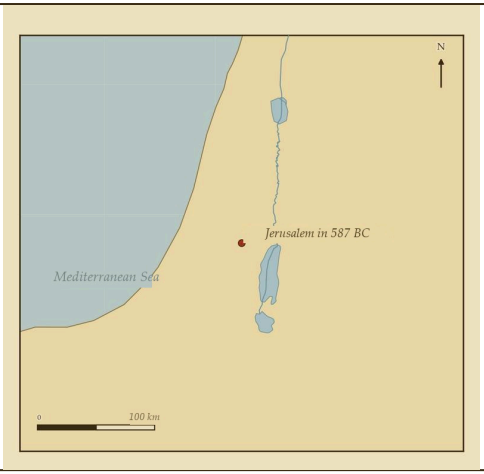
### 6.5 · JERUSALEM IN 587 BC · 2 KGS 25; 2 CHR 36:17–21; JER 39; 52; LAM 1–2

The last king of Judah, Zedekiah, rebelled against Babylon, so Nebuchadnezzar marched out with his army and besieged Jerusalem. According to 2 Kgs 25, famine took hold in the city, and after the wall was breached the king tried to flee toward Jericho but was captured. The Babylonians burned the Temple, the palace and the houses, and tore down the walls. Many of the inhabitants were carried off to Babylonia. Jeremiah, who had earlier warned of such a catastrophe, did not stop speaking about the future: he foretold a new covenant and a return. The Book of Lamentations expresses the pain of those days.

Jerusalem lay on a mountain ridge, surrounded by deep valleys, so it could be conquered mainly by starvation. That is why the siege lasted about 18 months. The Babylonian army marched from Mesopotamia along the Euphrates through Syria and reached the land of Judah after a march measured in weeks. Zedekiah's flight ran toward the Jordan Valley, about 25 km east, along a route descending about 1,000 m to the valley of Jericho. There, on the plain, the Babylonians overtook the fugitives. The scale of the fall is best shown by the difference in elevation between the capital and the desert.

FACTS

The siege lasted about 18 months; the destruction occurred in 587 or 586 BC.


N
Jerusalem in 587 BC
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

# 06 Babylon

DAN 1–6; ISA 13–14; JER 29; PS 137

*The city of exile, where Daniel and his companions stayed faithful to their faith.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

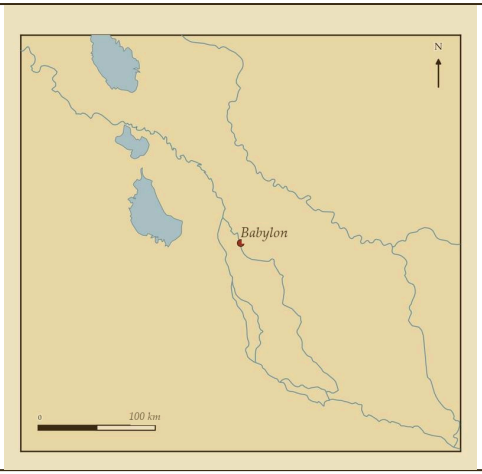
The artistic reconstruction shows the Ishtar Gate covered in gleaming blue glazed bricks, decorated with rows of lions, dragons and bulls. Before it runs the Processional Way, and in the background rises a stepped temple tower, a ziggurat. Merchants, priests and officials walk the streets, and palms stand beside the canal. The figures are seen from a distance, without facial detail. Everything is bathed in the warm, dusty light of noon.

The Book of Daniel tells of young men of Judah who were educated in Babylon in the palace school yet remained faithful to their faith. Daniel interprets the dreams of kings, his three friends refuse to worship a statue, and a later story mentions the lions' den. Jeremiah, in his letter to the exiles, urged them to build houses, plant gardens and seek the welfare of the city where they lived. Ps 137, in turn, conveys the longing by the rivers of Babylon. The community was learning to endure in a foreign world.

Babylon lay on the Euphrates, about 90 km south of present-day Baghdad, on a flat, fertile plain cut by a network of canals. The exiles were separated from Jerusalem by about 900 km in a straight line, which meant several months of marching. The Euphrates supplied water for fields and gardens and at the same time made it possible to trade by boat across all of Mesopotamia. Nebuchadnezzar II expanded the city: he built the Ishtar Gate and the Processional Way leading to the temple of Marduk. For newcomers from the hills of Judea, the flat, river landscape must have felt utterly foreign.

FACTS

Distance from Babylon to Jerusalem: about 900 km in a straight line; from present-day Baghdad: about 90 km.


N
Babylon
0
100 km

# 07 The Chebar River

EZEK 1–3; 10; 37; 40–48

*A canal in Babylonia, beside which the prophet Ezekiel saw visions of God's glory.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a wide canal with clay banks, lined with palms and willows. On the bank stand low houses of sun-dried brick and huts, and people in simple robes draw water or work in the fields. In the distance the outline of a great city can be seen. The sky is vast and flat, which heightens the sense of distance from the mountains of home.

Ezekiel, a priest deported to Babylonia along with King Jehoiachin in 597 BC, begins his book with a vision by the Chebar River. There he saw the heavens opened, a wind, a cloud and an extraordinary throne, which pointed to God's presence among the exiles. He is commanded to be a watchman for his nation, and he proclaims first words of judgment and then of hope. The vision of the valley full of bones that come to life is a picture of the renewal of the community. The book ends with a description of a new Temple and a city where God will dwell.

The Chebar was not a river in our sense, but an irrigation canal branching off the Euphrates. It is traditionally sought in the area of the ancient city of Nippur, about 100 km southeast of Babylon; the location is uncertain. The exiles founded farming settlements here, cultivating fields watered by a network of canals. For a people attached to the Temple in Jerusalem, some 1,000 km away, this was a pivotal experience: God reveals Himself even in a foreign land, by the water, among ordinary people, and not only in one place.

FACTS

The Chebar Canal lay about 100 km southeast of Babylon; Jerusalem was about 1,000 km away.

# 08 Rebuilding the Temple in Jerusalem

EZRA 1–6; HAG 1–2; ZECH 1–8

*The first returnees set up an altar, and after years of obstacles they complete the second Temple.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a hill full of scaffolding, piles of hewn stones and cedar beams. Workers carry blocks, in the background an altar stands under the open sky, and beside it a low, still unfinished building. Priests in white robes and Levites with instruments stand by the foundations. The whole scene is seen from a distance, in the warm light of morning.

## 6.8 · REBUILDING THE TEMPLE IN JERUSALEM · EZRA 1–6; HAG 1–2; ZECH 1–8

In 538 BC Cyrus, king of Persia, allowed the exiles to return to Jerusalem and rebuild the Temple. According to Ezra 2, about 42,000 people set out under the leadership of Zerubbabel and the high priest Joshua. First the altar was rebuilt, then the foundations were laid. Neighbors hindered the work, so construction stalled for years. The prophets Haggai and Zechariah encouraged the people to resume the work during the reign of Darius I. The Temple was completed and dedicated in 516 or 515 BC, and the community joyfully celebrated the Passover.

The road back from Babylonia usually followed the arc of the Fertile Crescent: along the Euphrates to the northwest, then through Syria to the south, about 1,400 km in all. Ezra, who returned several decades later, took about four months according to Ezra 7. The returnees found the city in ruins, shrunken to the ridge of the City of David and the Temple Mount. The new Temple was more modest than the former one; the elders who remembered the old sanctuary wept. Even so, it became the center of a community that endured for another five centuries.

FACTS

The road back from Babylonia was about 1,400 km; the second Temple was completed in 516 or 515 BC.

# 09 Susa

ESTH 1–10; NEH 1:1; DAN 8:2

*The winter capital of the Persian kings and the setting of the story of Esther.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a palace with mighty columns topped with bull-shaped capitals, high terraces and walls of glazed brick bearing processions of guards. In the courtyard stand courtiers in long robes, and in the background gardens and the walls of the citadel stretch away. The figures are seen from a distance or from behind, in the warm, golden light of afternoon.

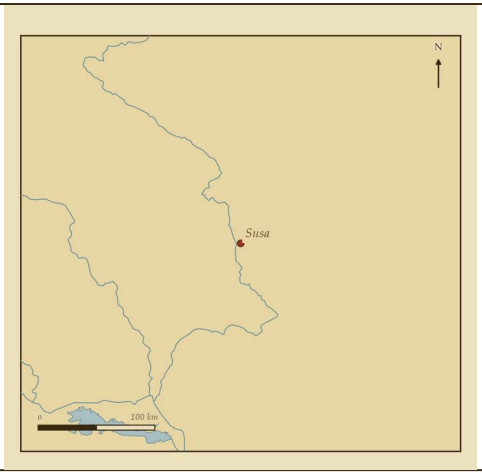
6.9 · SUSA · ESTH 1–10; NEH 1:1; DAN 8:2

The Book of Esther tells of a Jewish woman who becomes the wife of King Ahasuerus, probably Xerxes I. Through the counsel of her relative Mordecai, she uncovers a plot against her people and courageously stands before the king. The courtier Haman's plan is turned back, and the community celebrates the event as the feast of Purim. The beginning of the Book of Nehemiah also takes place in Susa: here a young Jew, the king's cupbearer, learns of the fall of Jerusalem's walls and asks the ruler for permission to go.

Susa lay in the fertile plain of Khuzestan, at the foot of the Zagros Mountains, about 350 km east of Babylon. The Persians made it one of their four capitals and the winter residence of their kings, because the city's climate was milder than on the plateau. From here the Royal Road set out, linking Susa with Sardis, about 2,700 km to the west. Thanks to it, embassies and orders reached the whole empire. Susa lay close to Persepolis (about 500 km) and yet close enough to Mesopotamia to control its busy, wealthy provinces.

FACTS

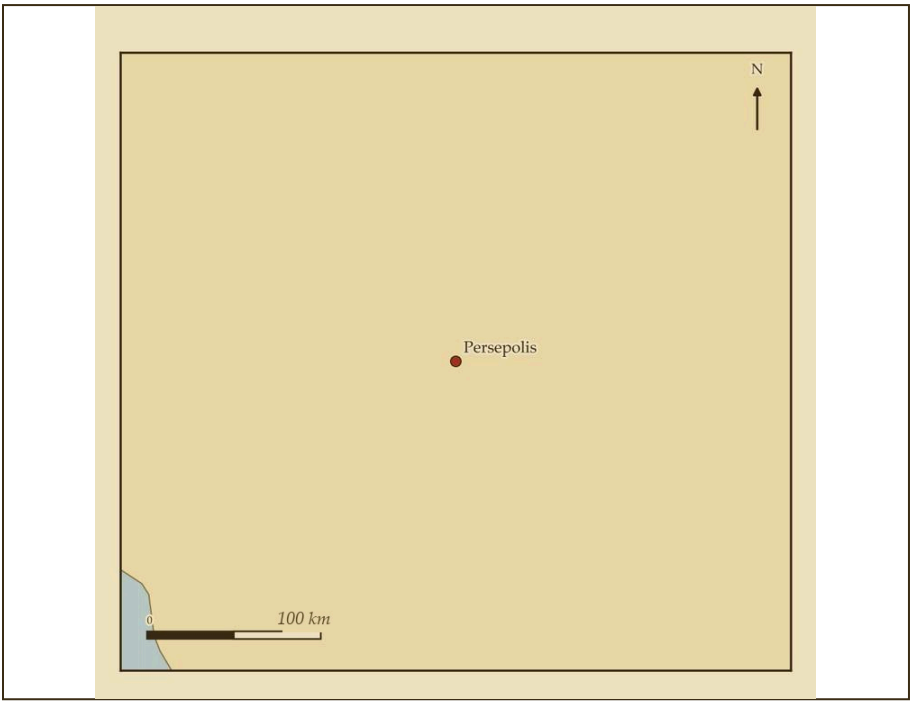
Susa lay about 350 km east of Babylon; the Royal Road from Sardis was about 2,700 km long.


N
Susa
0
100 km

# 10 Persepolis

EZRA 1:1–4; 6:1–12; ESTH 1:1–3

*The ceremonial capital of the Persian Empire, which allowed the Jews to return.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a high stone terrace reached by broad stairways decorated with reliefs of processions. On the platform rises a forest of slender columns topped with the heads of bulls and lions, and before the Gate of All Nations stand mighty winged bulls. In the background a plain and rocky slopes can be seen, and delegates in varied dress make their way toward the stairs.

Persepolis does not appear in the biblical text, but it shows the world in which Ezra, Nehemiah and Esther act. The Persian kings, from Cyrus to Artaxerxes, ruled a vast empire from India to Egypt. Ezra 1 and 6 describe the decrees that permitted the rebuilding of the Temple and the payment of its costs from the royal treasury. Historians debate how far Persian tolerance extended, but documents of the period indicate that the rulers generally respected local cults. This allowed the people of Judah to re-create their community around the Temple.

Persepolis was founded around 518 BC by Darius I on the Marvdasht plain in the Zagros Mountains, about 500 km southeast of Susa, in the heart of the Persian province of Parsa. It was a ceremonial city, not a commercial one: here embassies from across the empire were welcomed at the New Year festival. The stairs of the Apadana are adorned with reliefs showing delegations bringing gifts. Thanks to the network of roads, including the Royal Road, governors from distant provinces, Judea among them, could keep in touch with the ruler. The palaces burned in 330 BC, after the invasion of Alexander the Great.

FACTS

Persepolis lay about 500 km southeast of Susa; its palaces were burned in 330 BC.

# 11 Nehemiah's Walls

NEH 1–7; 12:27–43

*The rebuilding of Jerusalem's walls in only a few dozen days.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a hillside where a crowd of people are laying stone blocks in a new wall. Some carry baskets of rubble, others climb wooden scaffolding, and guards with spears stand on the little towers. Behind them the ruins of old houses can be seen, and in the distance the outline of the Temple Mount. The figures are shown from afar, in the light of early morning.

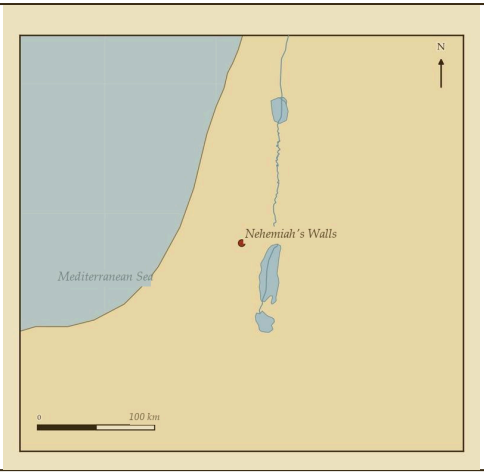
## 6.11 · NEHEMIAH'S WALLS · NEH 1–7; 12:27–43

Nehemiah, cupbearer to King Artaxerxes, heard in Susa about the ruined walls of Jerusalem and asked the king for permission to go. Around 445 BC he reached the city, rode around the ruins by night and called the inhabitants to rebuild. The book lists who built which section and which gate fell to which family. The enemies, Sanballat, Tobiah and Geshem, jeered, threatened and plotted, so the workers labored with a tool in one hand and a weapon in the other. According to Neh 6:15, the walls were finished in 52 days.

Jerusalem in this era was smaller than in Hezekiah's day. The walls enclosed mainly the ridge of the City of David and the Temple Mount, where a handful of families lived. Nehemiah had to patch breaches in the old lines of defense, using stones lying everywhere. The book lists about ten gates: the Sheep, Fish, Old, Valley, Dung, Fountain, Water and Horse Gates. Dividing the work by sections, with each group building by its own house, allowed the task to be finished quickly. The task was weakened by constant fear of attack from the neighbors.

FACTS

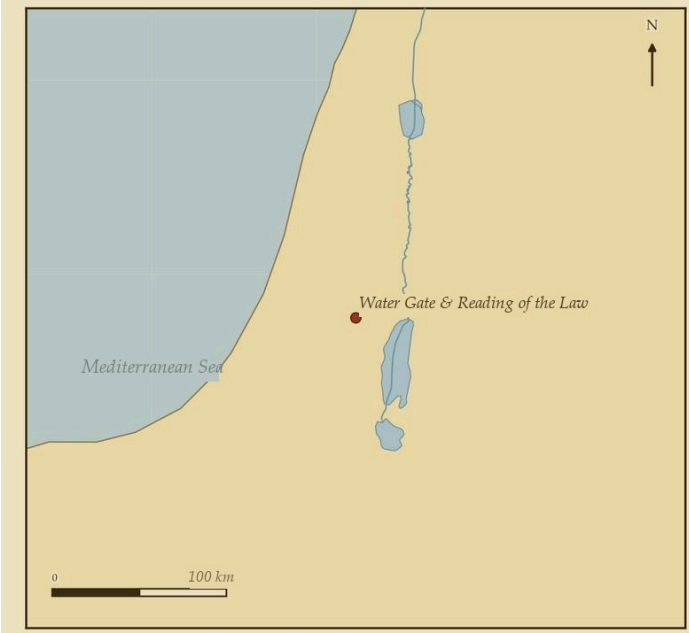
The rebuilding of the walls took 52 days (Neh 6:15); the work was completed around 445 BC.


N
Nehemiah's Walls
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

# 12 The Water Gate and the Reading of the Law

NEH 8–10; EZRA 7–10

*The community gathers in the square to hear the Law and renew the covenant.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a broad open square filled with a crowd in simple robes. On a wooden platform stands a figure with an unrolled scroll, and beside him Levites and priests. In the background rises the newly rebuilt wall with a gate, and the rooftops of the houses are covered with branches prepared for the Feast of Tabernacles. The whole scene is lit by bright morning light.

When the walls were ready, all the people gathered in the square before the Water Gate and asked Ezra to read the book of the Law. Ezra stood on a wooden platform, and the Levites translated and explained the text so that everyone could understand. The listeners wept, but Nehemiah and Ezra reminded them that this day was a holy day. Then the Feast of Tabernacles was kept, with people living in booths of branches. After that the community publicly renewed the covenant and pledged faithfulness, including support for the Temple.

The Water Gate led toward the Gihon spring, Jerusalem's only permanent spring, in the lower part of the City of David. The area before it was an open square where thousands could gather, including men, women and children able to understand. Ezra arrived in Jerusalem about four months after leaving Babylonia, most likely in 458 BC, though some scholars propose a different date. The reading lasted from dawn until midday and turned the rebuilt city into a community shaped by listening to the word.

FACTS

The reading of the Law lasted from dawn until midday (Neh 8:3); Ezra's journey to Jerusalem took about 4 months.

# Questions for Reflection

1. How does your view of the events of 2 Kgs 17 and 25 change when you realize that Samaria and Jerusalem lay on the path of great empires? What follows from this for understanding the words of the prophets?

2. Ezekiel saw the glory of God by a canal in Babylonia, and Jeremiah urged the exiles to build houses and seek the good of the city. What do these images say about living out faith far from the homeland?

3. Nehemiah divided the work on the walls into sections, and Ezra read the Law before all the people. What significance do shared work and shared listening have in rebuilding a community?

# 07

PART 7 OF 9

# The World of Jesus

MATT, MARK, LUKE, JOHN

*From the stable in Bethlehem to the empty tomb in Jerusalem – the landscapes Jesus of Nazareth walked through.*



# The Land Jesus Knew

Imagine a country you can cross on foot in a few days, yet one that holds nearly every landscape in the world: the green hills of Galilee, the shores of a seaside lake, the hot Jordan Valley, the barren mountains of the Judean Desert, and the rocky ridge on which Jerusalem stands. This is where Jesus' life unfolded. The Gospels do not describe it like a tourist guide, but every place name in them is rooted in real geography that you can find on a map.

From Nazareth to Jerusalem is about 100 km in a straight line, and from Capernaum on the lake to Bethlehem about 150 km. For people of that time this meant several days of walking, usually along the Jordan or through Samaria. Galilee was fertile and densely populated, Judea harsher, and above it all rose Jerusalem with the Temple. Once you know these distances and differences in elevation, many Gospel scenes take on unexpected concreteness: weariness at a well, a storm on the lake, the climb up from Jericho.

In this part we will visit twelve places, from Bethlehem to Golgotha and the road to Emmaus. For each you will find a short summary of the event, an explanation of why location and terrain matter, and an artistic reconstruction based on archaeological knowledge. Where a location rests on tradition, we say so clearly. Read with your Bible in hand: references follow the Millennium Bible, and we retell the Gospel texts in our own words.

INDEX OF PLACES AND SCENES

| | | |
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| 10 | Jericho | *Mark 10:46–52; Luke 19:1–10* |
| 11 | Jerusalem: Herod's Temple and the Pool of Bethesda | *Mark 11:15–17; John 2:13–22; John 5:1–15* |
| 12 | Gethsemane, Golgotha and the Road to Emmaus | *Mark 14:32–42; John 19:16–42; Luke 24:13–35* |


HOW TO USE THIS PART

The maps show routes and the locations of places; the illustrations are artistic reconstructions based on archaeological knowledge, not photographs. Distances and dimensions are approximate.

MAP 7.1

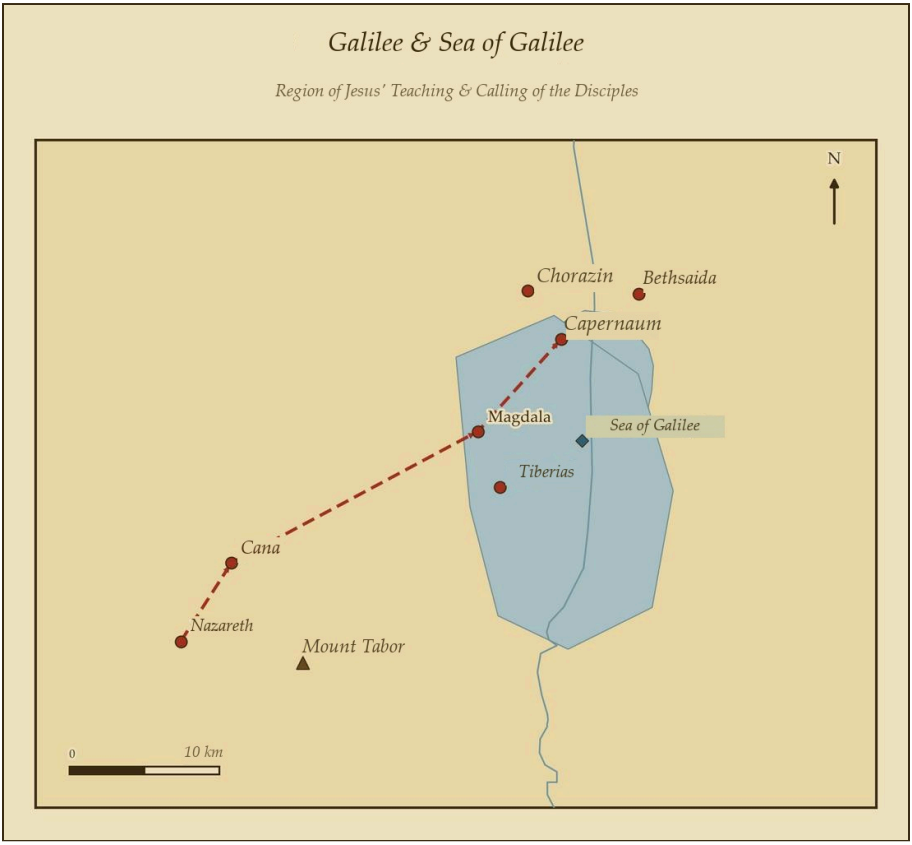



*The map shows the main places of Jesus' ministry, from the northern sources of the Jordan to Bethlehem in the south. The lines mark the two most common routes between Galilee and Jerusalem.*

Note how small this area is: from Caesarea Philippi to Bethlehem it is about 190 km in a straight line. Even so, Jesus passed through three different regions, each with its own climate and people. Samaria lay in the middle, and many people

avoided it because of tensions. The Jordan Valley was a longer but calmer route. The map shows that the great events of the Gospels unfold within a few days' walk.

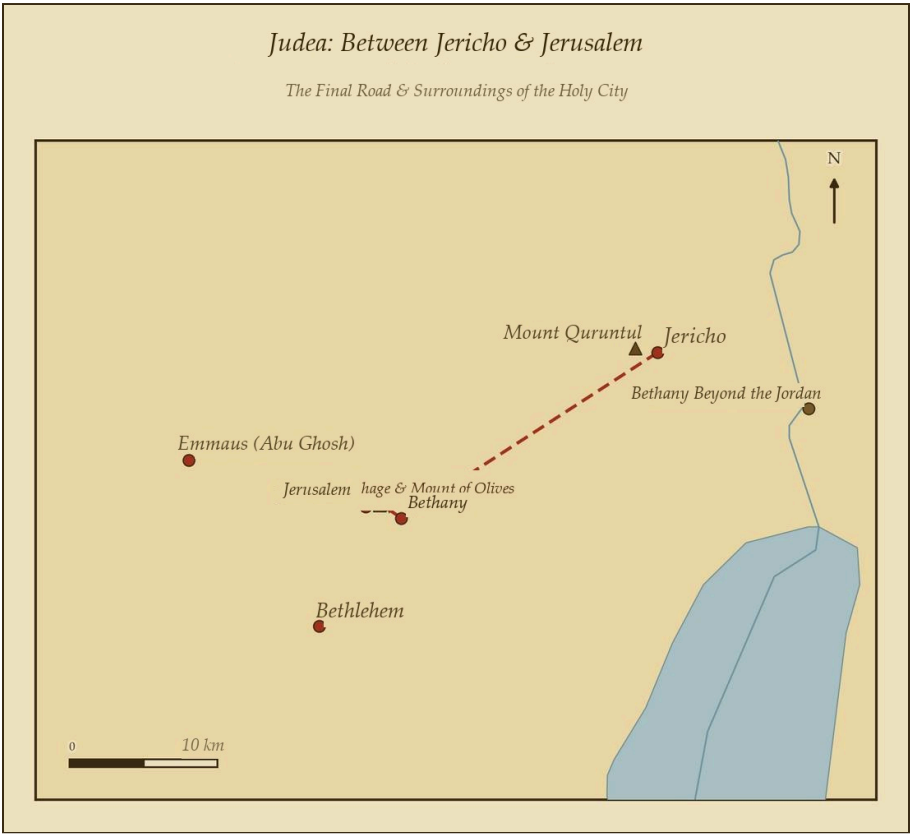
MAP 7.2




*The map shows lower and northern Galilee with the towns around the lake. The blue area is the Sea of Galilee, and the line shows the road from Nazareth to Capernaum.*

Almost all the towns where Jesus taught most often lay near the lake, within a dozen or so kilometers of Capernaum. Chorazin, Bethsaida and Capernaum formed a northern cluster of settlements that Jesus rebuked because, despite the miracles, they did not repent (Matt 11:20–24). Tabor stands apart on the plain, like a natural landmark. This makes it easy to understand how quickly news spread.

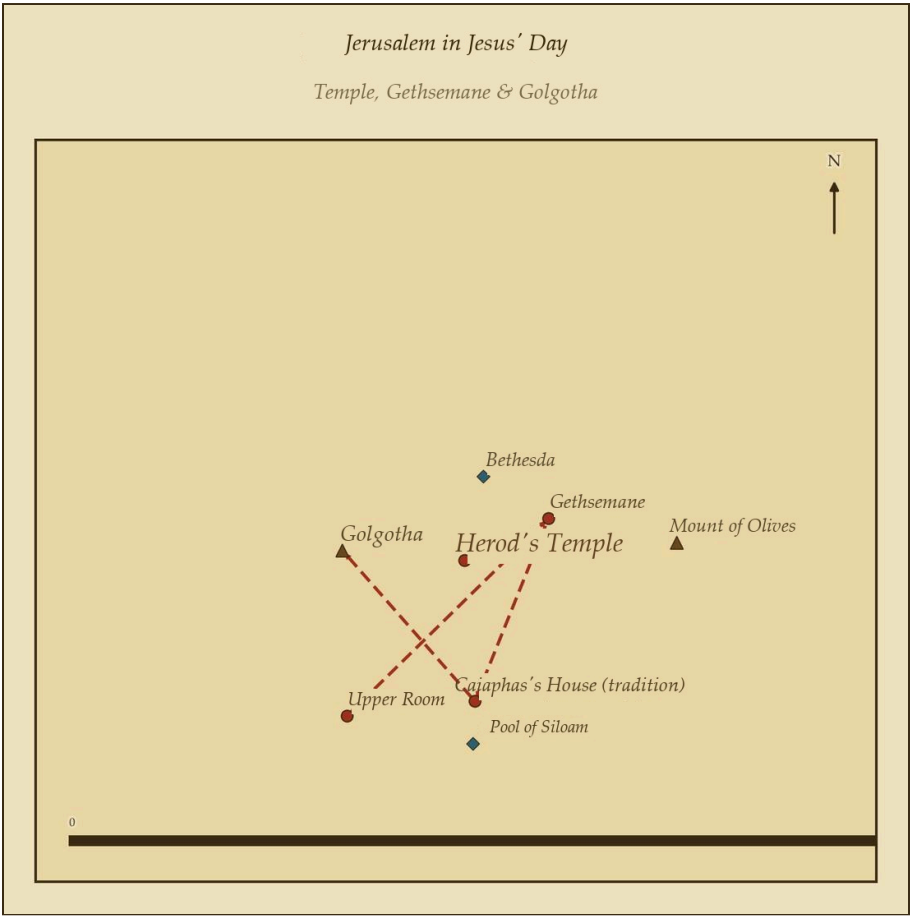
MAP 7.3




*The map covers Judea from Bethlehem in the south to Jericho in the east. The line shows the road Jesus took before entering Jerusalem.*

The road from Jericho to Jerusalem climbs about 1,000 m over just 27 km, so pilgrims had to work hard. Bethany and Bethphage lay right by the Mount of Olives, which explains why Jesus stayed there during Passion Week. Emmaus is marked traditionally, but its location remains a subject of research.

MAP 7.4




*The map shows the most important places in Jerusalem connected with the last days of Jesus. The route is simplified, and some locations rest on tradition.*

Jerusalem occupied hills surrounded by valleys: the Kidron on the east and the Hinnom on the south, which gave the city natural defense. The Temple dominated the east, and Golgotha lay just outside the walls. The distances are small; all the places lie within about 2 km. This makes it easy to see how quickly the events of Holy Week followed one another.

# 01 Bethlehem

MATT 2; LUKE 2:1–20

*The City of David, where Jesus was born.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

In Jesus' day Bethlehem was a small farming village of stone houses with flat roofs. Many of them were built against natural caves, used as stables and storerooms. Flocks grazed on the slopes, and in the evening the air quickly turned cool. It was a quiet corner rather than a bustling town (artistic reconstruction).

7.1 · BETHLEHEM · MATT 2; LUKE 2:1–20

The Gospels tell how Joseph, a descendant of the house of David, set out from Nazareth for Bethlehem to be registered in the census. There Mary gave birth to her Son and laid Him in a manger, because there was no room for them at the inn. That night shepherds guarding their flocks in the nearby fields heard the news and went to see the child. Later, according to Matthew, wise men from the East arrived, guided by a star, and presented their gifts. A deadly threat from King Herod forced the family to flee to Egypt.

Bethlehem lies about 8 km south of Jerusalem, on a ridge of hills rising about 770 m above sea level. Pastures stretch around it, sloping toward the Judean Desert, ideal for flocks of sheep, which explains the presence of shepherds. The journey from Galilee usually took several days and led through the Jordan Valley or Samaria. Its closeness to the capital explains why news of the birth reached Herod. Ancient tradition points to the cave beneath today's Church of the Nativity as the birthplace of Jesus, venerated since the early centuries of Christianity.

FACTS

Distance from Bethlehem to Jerusalem: about 8 km; elevation about 770 m above sea level.


N
Bethlehem
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

# 02 Nazareth

LUKE 1:26–38; 2:39–52; MATT 2:23

*The small town of Jesus' childhood and youth.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

In the first century Nazareth was a small village of probably a few hundred inhabitants. Houses of rough-cut stone and clay stood among terraces of olives, vines and grain. Narrow lanes led to the well and to a simple synagogue. Children helped with the animals and in the fields (artistic reconstruction).

According to Luke, it was in Nazareth that the angel Gabriel announced to Mary that she would conceive a Son. After the return from Egypt the family settled in this town, and there Jesus grew up, increasing in wisdom, as Luke records. Joseph worked as a carpenter, and Jesus was known to the townspeople as the carpenter's son. When He returned to Nazareth years later as a teacher, He spoke in the synagogue, reading a passage from the prophet Isaiah, but met with disbelief from His fellow townspeople (Luke 4:16–30).

Nazareth lies in lower Galilee, in a basin surrounded by hills, at about 350 m above sea level. It was not an important town, and the Old Testament does not mention it at all, which explains the skeptical question of whether anything good can come out of Nazareth (John 1:46). Even so, the town lay near busy routes. Only a few kilometers away stood Sepphoris, then being rebuilt as the capital of the region, where craftsmen could find work. As a result, Jesus grew up in an environment open to the wider world.

FACTS

Elevation: about 350 m above sea level; distance to the Sea of Galilee: about 30 km.

# 03 The Jordan and Bethany Beyond the Jordan

MARK 1:1–11; JOHN 1:28; MATT 3:13–17

*The place of Jesus' baptism and the beginning of His public ministry.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The river was then the color of murky green, and its banks were overgrown with reeds, willows and tamarisks. Among the vegetation sat people waiting for their turn, far from the noise of the city. The air was hot and humid, and desert hills could be seen in the background (artistic reconstruction).

## 7.3 · THE JORDAN AND BETHANY BEYOND THE JORDAN · MARK 1:1–11; JOHN 1:28; MATT 3:13–17

John the Baptist preached repentance by the Jordan, and people from all Judea and Jerusalem came to confess their sins and be baptized. Among them came Jesus of Nazareth. The Gospels agree that after the baptism the heavens opened, the Spirit descended on Him like a dove, and the Father's voice confirmed that He is the beloved Son. The Gospel of John names the place of the baptism as Bethany beyond the Jordan, that is, on the eastern side of the river. It was the beginning of Jesus' public mission.

The Jordan flows in a deep rift valley, and the area around Jericho lies more than 250 m below sea level, in one of the lowest places on earth. In its lower course the river is narrow, winding and surrounded by dense vegetation, which favored gatherings in a secluded place, away from the cities. The spot was convenient also because an important road from Jericho to the eastern lands passed nearby. Today's site of Al-Maghtas, traditionally regarded as Bethany beyond the Jordan, lies about 9 km from the Dead Sea.

FACTS

Elevation: about 250–400 m below sea level; distance to the Dead Sea: about 9 km.


N
Jordan & Bethany Beyond the Jordan
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

# 04 The Judean Desert

MATT 4:1–11; MARK 1:12–13; LUKE 4:1–13

*Forty days of fasting and temptation in the wilderness.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The desert is a landscape of beige and ochre: rocky hills, ravines and cliffs without a trace of green. By day the heat is intense, by night it is cold. The silence is almost complete, broken only by the sound of the wind. From the high rocks the Dead Sea can be seen glittering below (artistic reconstruction).

Right after His baptism Jesus was led by the Spirit into the desert. The Gospels speak of forty days of fasting and three temptations: bread, a miraculous sign, and power over the kingdoms of the world. Each time Jesus answers by appealing to Scripture. The forty days recall Israel's forty years of wandering in the wilderness, but where the people failed, Jesus remains faithful. For Christians this scene remains to this day the model for Lent.

The Judean Desert occupies a narrow strip between the Judean ridge and the Dead Sea. It stretches about 100 km in length and about 25 km in width, and rainfall here is minimal. The terrain is cut by deep ravines, caves and cliffs, which favored hermits. According to tradition, the place of the temptations was Mount Kuruntul (Latin Quarantana) above Jericho, rising about 350 m above the city. This is a traditional location, because the Gospels do not name a specific peak.

FACTS

Length of the Judean Desert: about 100 km; Mount Kuruntul: about 350 m above Jericho.

# 05 Cana of Galilee

JOHN 2:1–12; JOHN 4:46–54

*The wedding where Jesus performed His first sign.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

A Galilean village of small stone houses was surrounded by terraced vineyards and olive groves. In the wedding courtyard stood stone jars used for ritual washing. Guests sat on rugs, and children ran between the tables. In the evening oil lamps lit the interior (artistic reconstruction).

The Gospel of John tells of a wedding in Cana to which Jesus, His mother and His disciples were invited. When the wine ran out, Mary turned to her Son and told the servants to do whatever He said. Jesus had six stone jars filled with water, and when it was drawn out, it turned out to be wine of excellent quality. John calls this the beginning of signs, which revealed Jesus' glory and strengthened the disciples' faith. Jesus later returned to Cana to heal the son of a royal official.

Cana is traditionally identified with Kafr Kanna, about 6 km northeast of Nazareth, on the road leading to the lake. Archaeologists have also proposed the site of Khirbet Qana, a few kilometers to the north, but this remains a matter of debate among specialists. The location explains why Jesus could easily travel from here to Capernaum: the road down toward the lake ran about 25 km and descended more than 500 m. Wedding celebrations usually lasted several days, and wine was an important part of hospitality.

FACTS

Distance from Cana to Nazareth: about 6 km; to Capernaum: about 25 km.

# 06 Capernaum

MARK 1:21–34; MARK 2:1–12; MATT 4:13

*Jesus' town on the northern shore of the lake.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The town consisted of low houses of dark basalt, packed tightly around shared courtyards. The roofs of branches and clay were flat, and nets dried on the shore. Fishing boats stood at the landing, and the hills of the Golan towered over it all (artistic reconstruction).

Matthew writes that Jesus left Nazareth and made His home in Capernaum by the lake. In this town He called Matthew the tax collector, healed Peter's mother-in-law and taught in the synagogue, and crowds came to His house in such numbers that the friends of a paralyzed man removed the roof to lower the sick man inside (Mark 2:1–12). Many of the fishermen who became disciples lived right here. That is why the town is sometimes called His own town (Matt 9:1).

Capernaum lay on the northern shore of the Sea of Galilee, at a crossroads linking Galilee with Syria and the coast. The Via Maris passed through here, so there was a customs post and soldiers were stationed there, such as the centurion in Luke 7. The lake lies about 210 m below sea level. Excavations have uncovered black basalt houses and a later white limestone synagogue. Beneath it older basalt walls were found, and beneath the octagonal church the remains of a house that tradition links with Peter.

FACTS

Lake level: about 210 m below sea level; population in the 1st century: about 1,000–1,500.


N
Capernaum
0
50 km

# 07 The Sea of Galilee: Magdala, Bethsaida and Tiberias

MARK 4:35–41; MARK 6:45–52; JOHN 6:1–21; LUKE 8:2

*The lake where Jesus calmed the storm and fed the crowds.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The boats had low sides and a single sail, and at dawn fishermen hauled in their nets, washed them and mended them. The water could be remarkably calm and deep blue, but in a few moments it could be covered in waves. Beyond rose the peaks of the Golan hills, and in the evening campfires glimmered on the shores (artistic reconstruction).

## 7.7 · THE SEA OF GALILEE: MAGDALA, BETHSAIDA AND TIBERIAS · MARK 4:35–41; MARK 6:45–52; JOHN 6:1–21; LUKE 8:2

By the Sea of Galilee Jesus called His first disciples, Simon, Andrew, James and John, who were fishing. From a boat He taught the crowds, and during a crossing He calmed a violent storm, asking the disciples about their faith. The multiplication of the loaves and fish and the walking on water also took place by the lake. Magdala was the hometown of Mary Magdalene, Bethsaida the town of Peter, Andrew and Philip, and Tiberias, founded by Herod Antipas, bore the name of an emperor whom the Gospels mention only briefly.

The lake is about 21 km long and about 13 km wide, and lies about 210 m below sea level, surrounded by hills. Cold air from Mount Hermon can rush down toward the water, causing sudden, violent storms, which explains the Gospel scene well. Magdala lay on the western shore, Tiberias a little to the south, and Bethsaida at the mouth of the Jordan on the northern shore. Fishing boats sailed at night, because there were more fish then, and several towns around the lake lived off the catch.

**FACTS**

Length of the lake: about 21 km; width: about 13 km; level: about 210 m below sea level.


N
Sea of Galilee: Magdala, Bethsaida & Tiberias
Mediterranean Sea

# 08 Samaria and Sychar

JOHN 4:1–42

*Jesus' conversation with the Samaritan woman at Jacob's well.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

At the foot of Mount Gerizim stretched a fertile valley with wheat fields. The well was open, surrounded by a stone curb, from which water was drawn in a leather bucket. At noon it was hot, and the area was almost deserted. In the distance a settlement could be seen (artistic reconstruction).

The Gospel of John tells how Jesus, weary from the journey, sat down by Jacob's well in the Samaritan town of Sychar at midday. He asked for water from a woman who had come to draw it. This was surprising, because Jews and Samaritans rarely met. The conversation concerned living water, true worship and the expectation of the Messiah. The woman told the townspeople about Him, and many of them believed and invited Him to stay for two days.

Samaria lay between Judea and Galilee. The shortest road from Jerusalem to Nazareth was about 100 km and crossed precisely this region, although many Jews chose a longer route along the Jordan to avoid hostility. Sychar is usually identified with the area of today's Askar, at the foot of Mount Gerizim, which was the Samaritans' holy mountain of worship. Jacob's well, about 35 m deep, is still a recognizable site today. This is a traditional location, strongly based on the testimony of ancient pilgrims.

FACTS

Depth of Jacob's well: about 35 m; distance from Jerusalem to Nazareth through Samaria: about 100 km.

# 09 Caesarea Philippi and the Mount of Transfiguration

MATT 16:13–20; MATT 17:1–9; MARK 9:2–10

*Peter's confession at the sources of the Jordan and the revelation of glory on the mountain.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

At Banias water flowed out from beneath a rock face in which niches had been carved for statues. Trees and shrubs covered the area, and the air was cooler than by the lake. Tabor rises alone above the Jezreel plain like a dome, and from its summit you can see fields, hills and distant mountains (artistic reconstruction).

In the region of Caesarea Philippi Jesus asked His disciples who people say He is, and then who they themselves say He is. Peter answered that He is the Messiah, the Son of the living God, and Jesus entrusted him with a special mission in the Church (Matt 16:13–20). A few days later He took Peter, James and John up a high mountain, where His face shone and Moses and Elijah appeared beside Him. A voice from the cloud pointed to Jesus as the beloved Son.

Caesarea Philippi lies at the foot of Mount Hermon, by the springs of Banias, one of the main sources of the Jordan, at about 350 m above sea level. It was a city built by the tetrarch Philip and dedicated to the emperor, with a cave for the worship of the god Pan. The Gospels do not name the Mount of Transfiguration. Christian tradition has long pointed to Tabor in lower Galilee (about 588 m above sea level), but some scholars name Hermon (about 2,814 m above sea level). This location remains a matter of debate, which is why we speak of tradition.

FACTS

Tabor: about 588 m above sea level; Hermon: about 2,814 m above sea level; Caesarea Philippi: about 350 m above sea level.

# 10 Jericho

MARK 10:46–52; LUKE 19:1–10

*The last stop before going up to Jerusalem.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Jericho was a green oasis in the desert. Palm groves, gardens and palaces rose all around, watered by numerous springs. Caravans stopped here before the hard road uphill. Beyond the city began the bare, brown slopes of Judea (artistic reconstruction).

As Jesus approached Jerusalem, He met two people in Jericho. A blind beggar, Bartimaeus, cried out to Him in faith and received his sight. Zacchaeus, chief of the tax collectors, short in stature, climbed a sycamore tree to see Jesus, and Jesus invited Himself to his house. Zacchaeus promised to give half of his wealth to the poor and to repay fourfold what he had extorted. Jesus declared that salvation had come to his house, for He came to seek and to save the lost.

Jericho lies about 250 m below sea level and is one of the oldest cities in the world, but in Jesus' day life was concentrated in Herod's new center, a few kilometers from the old tell. The warm climate allowed palms and balsam to be grown, and the city was wealthy and had a customs post. From here a rocky road about 27 km long led up to Jerusalem, climbing about 1,000 m. It was considered dangerous, and it is in this area that the parable of the Good Samaritan is set.

FACTS

Distance from Jericho to Jerusalem: about 27 km; difference in elevation: about 1,000 m.

# 11 Jerusalem: Herod's Temple and the Pool of Bethesda

MARK 11:15–17; JOHN 2:13–22; JOHN 5:1–15

*The heart of Israel: the Temple and the pool where Jesus healed a sick man.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The Temple gleamed with honey-colored stone and with gold on the front of the sanctuary building. The courts were filled with pilgrims, priests and merchants. Broad steps led to the gates, and colonnades gave shade. Nearby, the pool with its porticoes teemed with sick people seeking relief (artistic reconstruction).

Jesus came to Jerusalem for pilgrimage feasts such as Passover. He taught in the Temple courts, and during one visit He drove the merchants out, saying that God's house is to be a house of prayer. Nearby, at the pool of Bethesda, He met a man who had been lying there for thirty-eight years and had no one to help him into the water. Jesus told him to get up and walk, which coincided with the Sabbath and stirred up a dispute (John 5:1–15).

The Temple was expanded by Herod the Great on a vast raised platform of about 14 hectares, supported by massive walls. Its western wall survives to this day, revered by Jews. The platform towered over the Kidron Valley to the east, so the building was visible from afar, including from the Mount of Olives. The pool of Bethesda lay just north of the Temple, near the Sheep Gate, and excavations have uncovered two large pools with porticoes. This identification is widely accepted today.

FACTS

Area of the Temple platform: about 14 hectares; height of the retaining walls: over 30 m.


N
Jerusalem: Herod's Temple & Pool of Bethesda
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

# 12 Gethsemane, Golgotha and the Road to Emmaus

MARK 14:32–42; JOHN 19:16–42; LUKE 24:13–35

*The garden of prayer, the hill of the cross and the empty tomb.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Gethsemane is a grove of old olive trees, where at night a half-darkness reigns, lit only by torches. Golgotha was a rocky hill by the walls, from which the road leading to the gate could be seen. The garden with a tomb cut in the rock lay right next to it, and Easter morning brought silence and light there (artistic reconstruction).

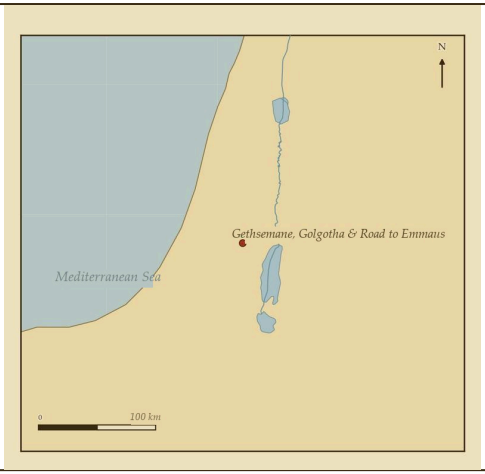
## 7.12 · GETHSEMANE, GOLGOTHA AND THE ROAD TO EMMAUS · MARK 14:32–42; JOHN 19:16–42; LUKE 24:13–35

After the Last Supper Jesus went with His disciples to a garden called Gethsemane at the foot of the Mount of Olives, where He prayed in anguish, asking the Father that His will be done. There He was seized, tried and condemned. He carried the cross to the hill called Golgotha, where He was crucified. Joseph of Arimathea laid His body in a new tomb in a nearby garden. On the third day the tomb was found empty, and the Risen One appeared to His disciples, among others to two travelers on the road to Emmaus.

Gethsemane lies on the eastern side of the Kidron Valley, opposite the Temple, on the slope of the Mount of Olives, which rises about 800 m above sea level. In Jesus' time Golgotha was outside the city walls, in a former quarry, today within the Church of the Holy Sepulchre. Ancient tradition and excavations allow us to link this place with the crucifixion and burial. The location of Emmaus is disputed; Abu Ghosh and Latrun are among those named, about 11 km from Jerusalem, according to Luke's description about 60 stadia.

### FACTS

Distance from Gethsemane to Golgotha: about 1 km; Emmaus (according to Luke): about 60 stadia, or about 11 km from Jerusalem.


N
Gethsemane, Golgotha & Road to Emmaus
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

# Questions for Reflection

1. Which of the twelve places described in this part feels closest to you, and why? What changes in your understanding of a scene when you know its geography?

2. Jesus spent most of His life in small towns of Galilee. What does this simplicity say about the way God enters human life?

3. Walk in your mind along Jesus' road from Jericho to Jerusalem and on to Gethsemane. What feelings accompany you at each stage of this journey?

# 08

PART 8 OF 9

# The Early Church

ACTS 1–12 AND 15

*From the Upper Room in Jerusalem to the council where the Church opened the door to all nations.*



# The Church Leaves Jerusalem

The Book of Acts tells of a dozen or so years in which a small community of disciples from one city became a movement reaching the shores of the entire Mediterranean. It all begins in Jerusalem, in the hills of Judea, a few steps from the Temple. Picture the crowd of pilgrims filling the narrow streets on a feast day, and a handful of people praying in the upper room of a house. That scene is the beginning of a story whose chapters lead through Samaria, the desert road to Gaza, Damascus, and the coastal cities, all the way to Antioch.

In Acts, geography is not a backdrop but a blueprint. The author, traditionally identified with Luke, arranges the narrative according to the promise in the first chapter: witness in Jerusalem, in all Judea and Samaria, and then to the ends of the earth. Each new circle is a different landscape: rocky hills, the fertile Plain of Sharon, Roman ports, the great Syrian trading hub. Distances were considerable, since it is about 220 km from Jerusalem to Damascus and over 500 km from Jerusalem to Antioch, so the journey took weeks on foot.

In this part you will explore twelve places where the Church learned to be a community: from the Upper Room and the Temple, through Philip on the road to Gaza and the conversion of Saul, to Cornelius's house in Caesarea and the gathering in Jerusalem that settled a difficult dispute. Four maps will show you the routes and distances, and artistic reconstructions, based on archaeological knowledge of the first century, will help you see the streets and houses of long ago. Read at an unhurried pace, with your Bible beside you, because each description points to a passage worth looking up for yourself.

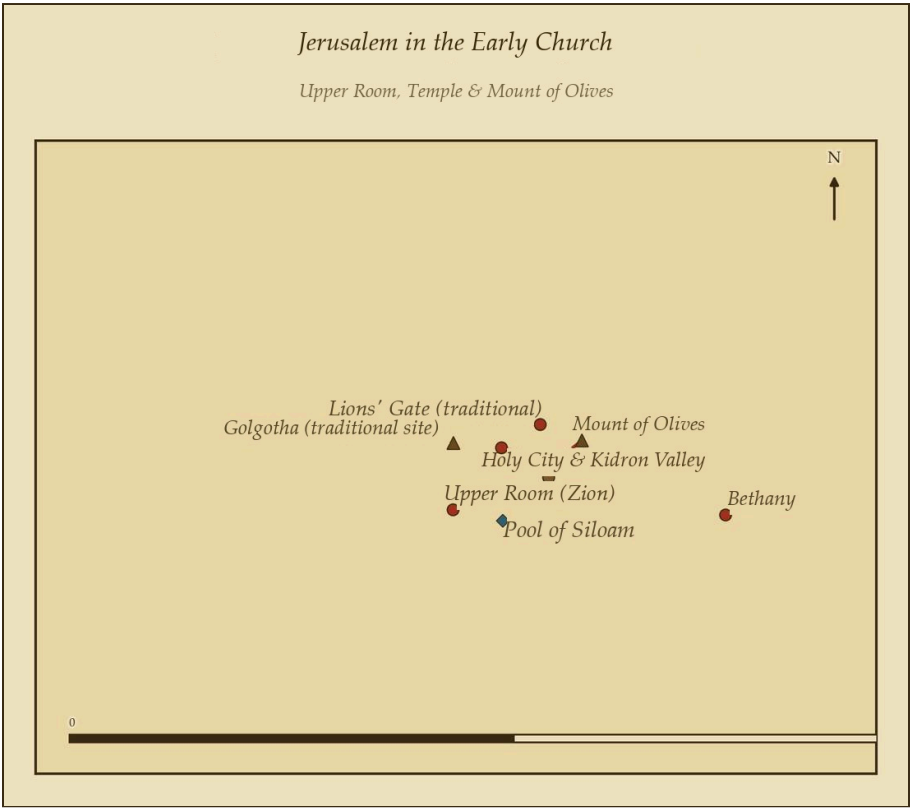
INDEX OF PLACES AND SCENES


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HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

The maps show routes and the locations of places; the illustrations are artistic reconstructions based on archaeological knowledge, not photographs. Distances and dimensions are approximate.

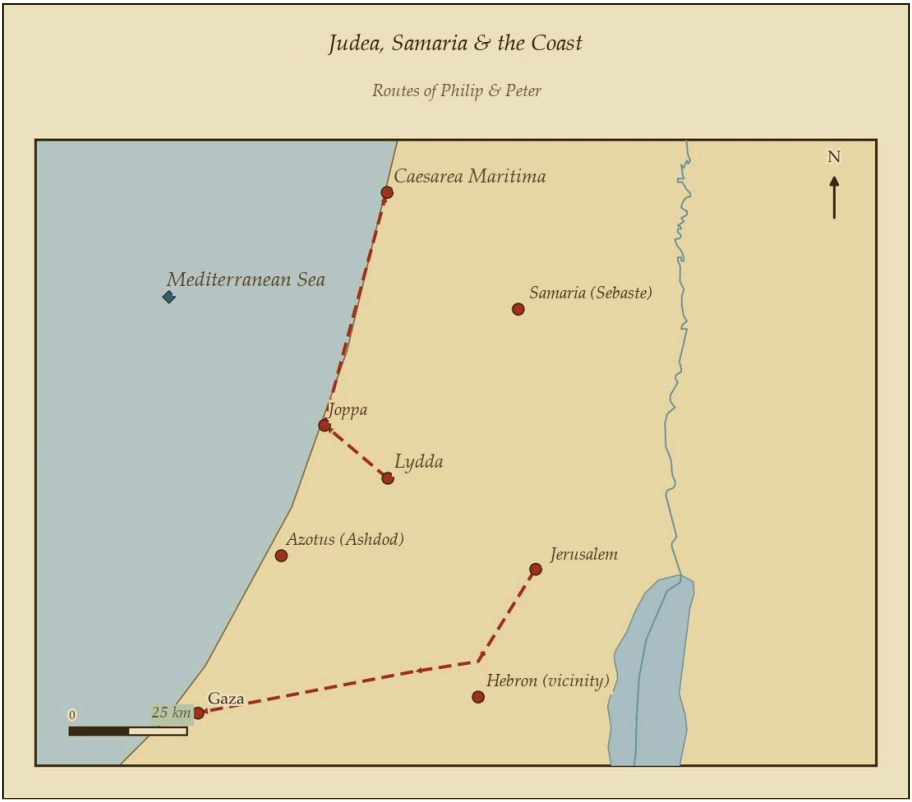
MAP 8.1




*The map shows the center of ancient Jerusalem and its eastern approaches. The line marks the short route the disciples walked from the Mount of Olives to the city after the farewell.*

All the events of the first chapters of Acts unfold in an area of just a few kilometers. The Upper Room on Zion, the Temple on the eastern hill, and the Mount of Olives, separated by the Kidron Valley, form the natural stage on which the community gathered. Notice how close together the places of prayer, teaching, and persecution lay, and why news spread here from one day to the next.

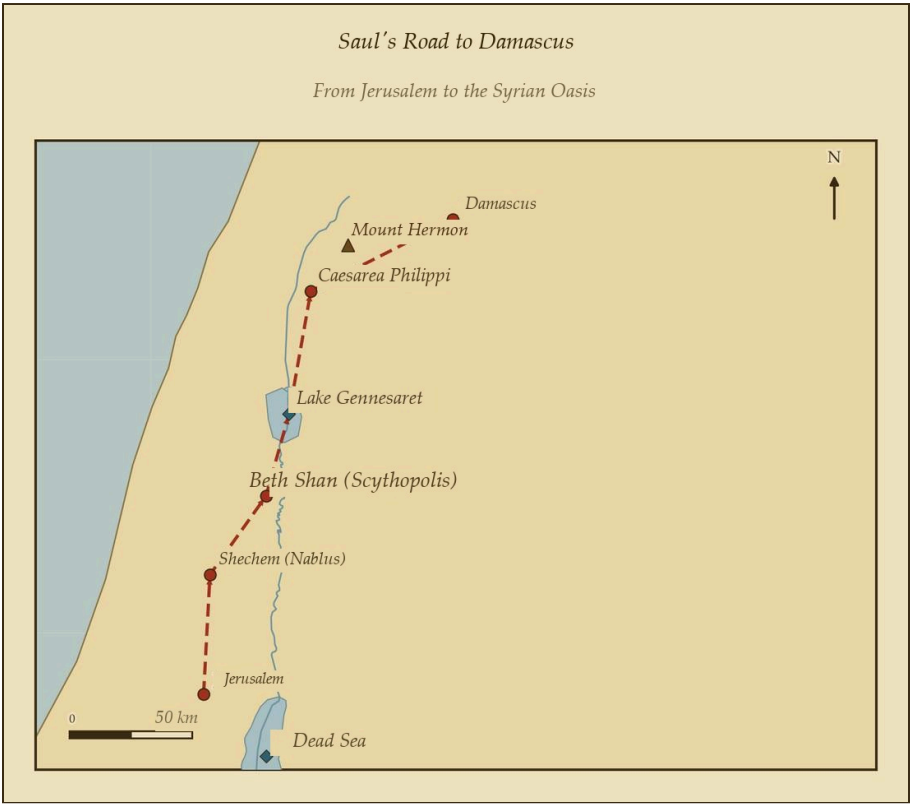
MAP 8.2




*The dots mark cities and places in the countryside, and the sea is shown separately. The lines show Philip's route south and Peter's road along the coastal Plain of Sharon.*

This map shows how the Gospel moves from the hill country of Judea toward the coast. Samaria lies to the north, Gaza far to the southwest, and Lydda, Joppa, and Caesarea form a line of cities along the Mediterranean. Note that most routes lead from the hills to the plain, and from the plain to the ports. That is why the word could travel on quickly from there, including by sea.

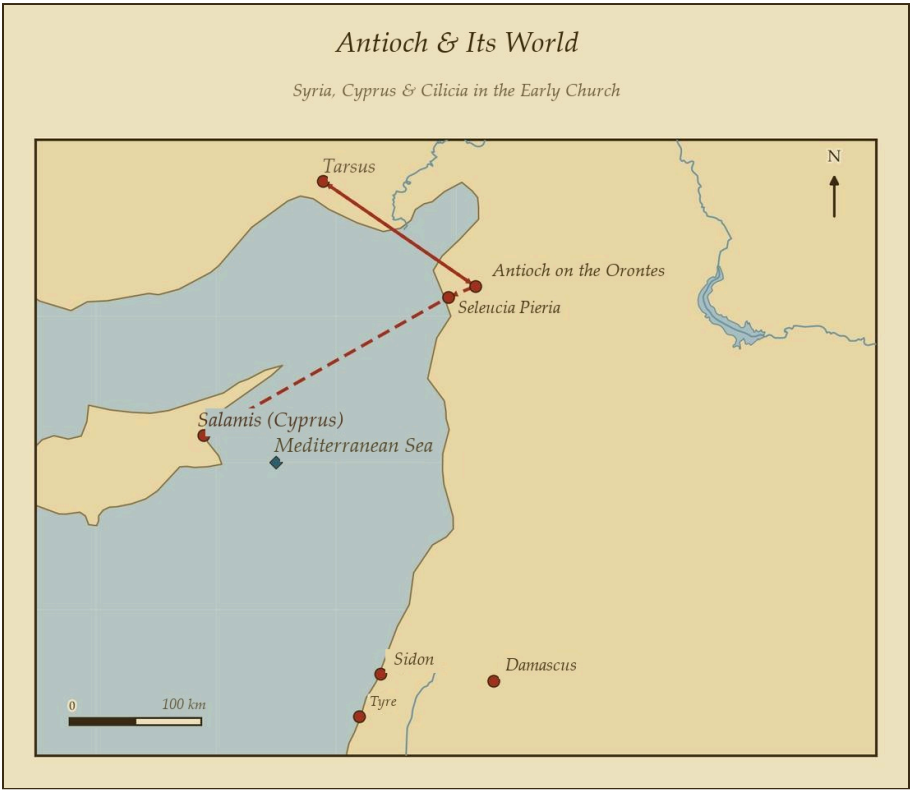
MAP 8.3




*The map covers the road from Jerusalem north through Samaria and Galilee to Damascus. The line is approximate, because the exact course of the route is not given in the text.*

Saul's road led from Jerusalem through the Jordan valleys and the region of Galilee toward Damascus, about 220 km as the crow flies. Along the way he passed the mountains of Hermon and the Sea of Galilee. Notice that Damascus lies outside the borders of Israel, so Saul set out abroad to persecute the disciples who had fled from Jerusalem. This is one proof of how quickly the faith spread beyond the country.

MAP 8.4




*The map shows the northeastern Mediterranean with Antioch at its center. The first line is Barnabas's journey to find Saul, and the second is the beginning of the missionary journey.*

Antioch was a hub from which roads radiated: to Tarsus in the northwest, to Seleucia on the coast and onward by sea to Cyprus. Phoenicia, with Tyre and Sidon, lay to the south, and Damascus to the southeast. Because of this, the city was in contact with both Jerusalem and the whole northern part of the Mediterranean basin. Such a location made it an ideal center for mission.

# 01 Mount of Olives – Place of Farewell

ACTS 1:1–14

*From here the disciples watch Jesus depart and return to the city.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Artistic reconstruction: a gentle, stony slope covered with old olive trees, crossed by terraces and narrow paths. Below, beyond the Kidron Valley, rises the bright Temple complex with gleaming gilded elements, and in the background the compact buildings of Jerusalem. The air is dry, the light is that of morning, and the hills of Judea stretch into the distance. Pilgrims and shepherds with small flocks are tiny figures that give the place its everyday rhythm.

The Book of Acts opens with a brief reminder: for forty days Jesus appeared to the disciples and spoke to them about the kingdom of God. Then he told them that they would receive the Holy Spirit and become his witnesses. When he had said this, he was taken up, and a cloud hid him from their sight. Two men in white reminded them that they should not stand gazing into the sky. The apostles returned to the city, went up to the upper room, and, together with the women, Mary, and Jesus' brothers, devoted themselves to prayer.

The Mount of Olives is a limestone ridge east of Jerusalem, rising about 80–100 m above the Temple Mount and separated from it by the deep Kidron Valley. Luke says it is only a Sabbath day's walk from the city, about 1 km by the later Jewish measure. For the disciples this meant a short walk back along a path winding through olive groves. The view from the summit takes in the whole city with the Temple, which gives the scene a symbolic dimension: from here the message will set out to the world.

FACTS

Height of the summit of the Mount of Olives: about 810 m above sea level; about 0.6 km in a straight line to the Temple Mount.

# 02 The Upper Room – The Coming of the Holy Spirit

ACTS 1:13–2:47

*In the upper room a community is born that sets out to reach people of every nation.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Artistic reconstruction: a simple stone house with a flat roof and an outside staircase leading to the upper room, shielded by wooden shutters. Inside are modest tables, low benches, and olive-oil lamps. In front of the house is a narrow, paved street where people in varied dress from distant lands are gathering. Morning light streams in through the window openings, and above the rooftops of Zion the city walls can be seen.

Fifty days after Passover, Jerusalem is once again filled with pilgrims, for the Feast of Weeks has come. The disciples are all together in one place when a sound like a violent wind is heard, and tongues as of fire appear over each of them. They begin to speak in different languages, and the foreigners gathered there understand the mighty works of God being proclaimed. Peter stands up with the Eleven and explains what is happening, appealing to the Scriptures. That day about three thousand people join them, and the community devotes itself to teaching, prayer, the breaking of bread, and mutual help.

Christian tradition links these events with the Upper Room on Mount Zion, in the southwestern part of ancient Jerusalem. The site itself is identified by tradition, and the present building dates from the Middle Ages. The hill lies about 750 m above sea level, a little over a kilometer from the Temple, so pilgrims could quickly gather around the apostles. The listeners named by Luke, from Parthians and Medes to Romans, show how far the roads to Jerusalem stretched: about 1,000 km from Mesopotamia, over 2,000 km from Rome.

FACTS

Distance from the Temple to Mount Zion: about 1 km; elevation: about 765 m above sea level (traditional location).


N
Upper Room: Coming of the Holy Spirit
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

# 03 The Temple – The Beautiful Gate

ACTS 3–4

*Peter and John heal a begging man at the Temple gate.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

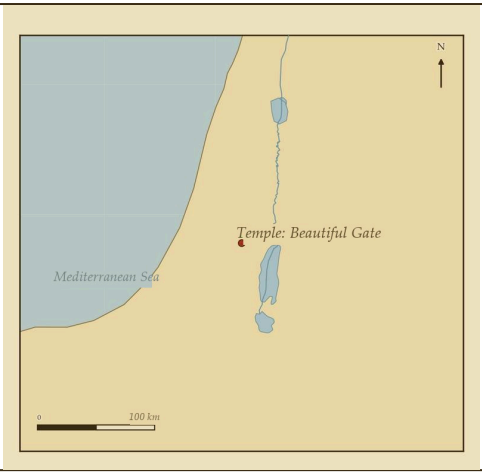
Artistic reconstruction: monumental colonnades of pale stone surround a vast plaza where pilgrims and priests pass by. At the entrance to the inner court stands an impressive gate with metal fittings, and by the wall sits the crouched figure of a beggar. Two figures in plain robes approach from the colonnade, seen from a distance or from behind. In the background rises the main building of the Temple, and the sky is clear, which emphasizes the vastness of the structure.

At the ninth hour, about three in the afternoon, Peter and John go up to the Temple to pray. At the gate called Beautiful, a man lame from birth was set down every day to ask for alms. Peter looks at him and says he has no silver or gold, but gives what he has: in the name of Jesus he tells him to stand up. The man rises, enters the Temple with them, and praises God. When the people gather, Peter explains that the healing is a sign of the power of Jesus, and calls them to repentance.

The Temple stood on a platform built by Herod the Great, covering about 14 hectares, surrounded by colonnades. The eastern side was occupied by Solomon's Portico, where the people ran together after the healing. The location of the Beautiful Gate is debated; it is usually identified as one of the gates leading from the Court of the Gentiles to the Court of the Women. Such closeness between a place of prayer and a place of begging shows how devotion, commerce, and poverty met within a single complex. The Sanhedrin met nearby, so the arrest of the apostles came quickly.

FACTS

Platform of the Herodian Temple: about 480 × 300 m; Solomon's Portico along the eastern wall was about 15 m high (estimate).


N
Temple: Beautiful Gate
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

# 04 Jerusalem – The Martyrdom of Stephen

ACTS 6–7; 12:1–19

*The first martyr, and the persecution that scatters the community.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Artistic reconstruction: the northern edge of ancient Jerusalem with a massive defensive wall and a gate flanked by towers. In front of the gate lies a stony road and open ground outside the walls, where a crowd gathers. The city buildings visible behind the wall are tightly packed, with flat roofs of pale stone. A gray dome of sky arches over everything, and a few fig and olive trees grow by the walls.

As the community grew, a dispute arose over the daily care of widows, so the apostles appointed seven men for this service. One of them was Stephen, full of faith and power. His teaching provoked opposition, he was accused before the Sanhedrin, and in a long speech he recalled the history of Israel. An enraged mob led him out of the city and stoned him, while a young man named Saul guarded the clothes of the executioners. A great persecution began, and the disciples were scattered throughout Judea and Samaria. Later chapters also tell of Peter's imprisonment during the reign of Herod Agrippa I.

Tradition places the stoning at the northern gate, today called the Lions' Gate, though the Damascus Gate was also once suggested. Both locations lie about 1 km from the Temple, on the edge of the city, where executions were carried out according to the law. The scattering of the disciples shows the role of roads: from Jerusalem, routes ran north to Samaria and Damascus, west to Lydda and Joppa, and south to Gaza. It was thanks to these routes that persecution paradoxically hastened the spread of the Gospel.

FACTS

The northern gates of Jerusalem lay about 1 km from the Temple; the city wall in this period had a circumference of about 4 km (estimate).

# 05 Samaria – Philip's Mission

ACTS 8:4–25

*The Gospel crosses an old divide and reaches the Samaritans.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Artistic reconstruction: a monumental Hellenistic-Roman-style city built on a hill, with wide colonnaded streets, a temple at the summit, and a defensive wall. At the foot of the hill are terraces of vineyards and fig trees, and donkeys laden with goods plod along the road. The light is warm, and in the distance more ridges of the Ephraim hills loom.

The disciples scattered by the persecution preach the word wherever they have gone. Philip, one of the seven, goes down to a city in Samaria and proclaims the Messiah there. The crowds listen with one accord, for they see the healings and the casting out of unclean spirits, and great joy fills the city. Many are baptized, including Simon the Magician, who had earlier amazed people with his tricks. When the news reaches Jerusalem, Peter and John are sent, and they pray for the new believers to receive the Holy Spirit. Simon tries to buy this power and is rebuked.

Samaria lies in the central part of the Ephraim hills, north of Jerusalem, about 55 km by road. The former capital of the Northern Kingdom was rebuilt by Herod as Sebaste, with a large stadium and a temple of the emperor. Samaritans were despised by many Jews, so crossing this boundary was a deeply significant step. Fertile valleys ring the hills, and the route from Jerusalem to Galilee ran right through this region. That is why news spread quickly along the trade routes.

FACTS

Distance from Jerusalem to Samaria: about 55 km; elevation of the city hill: about 430 m above sea level.

# 06 The Road to Gaza – The Ethiopian Official

ACTS 8:26–40

*On an empty road, Philip explains Isaiah's prophecy to a foreign official.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Artistic reconstruction: a long, stony road winding between light-brown, low hills covered with sparse grass and thorny shrubs. On the route stands a light two-wheeled chariot harnessed to a pair of horses, and beside it the figure of a traveler on foot. In the background a narrow stream appears with a touch of green. The sky is wide and faded, and in the distance the outline of the coastal plain can be seen.

The command is surprising: Philip is to leave lively Samaria and go south, on a desert road. There he meets a high official, the treasurer of the queen of Ethiopia, who was returning from a pilgrimage to Jerusalem and reading the prophet Isaiah aloud. Philip asks a simple question about understanding the text and is invited into the chariot. He tells of Jesus as the suffering Servant, and as the travelers pass some water, the official asks to be baptized. Then Philip is taken away and finds himself at Azotus, from where he travels on, preaching the Gospel all the way to Caesarea.

The road from Jerusalem to Gaza was about 90 km long and led through the hills of Judea, then through the dry, rolling Shephelah, toward the coastal plain. The exact place of the meeting is unknown, and tradition points to the area of Beth Zur or the Wadi el-Hesi valley. The description of the road as deserted fits the semi-arid character of the terrain. The encounter proves that the Good News reached far beyond Palestine: the Ethiopian kingdom lay hundreds of kilometers to the south, along the Nile.

FACTS

Distance Jerusalem–Gaza: about 90 km, or about 3–4 days on foot; a chariot could cover it faster.


N
Road to Gaza: the Ethiopian Official
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

# 07 Damascus – The Conversion of Saul

ACTS 9:1–25

*The persecutor becomes an apostle and escapes through the wall in a basket.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Artistic reconstruction: a walled city in a green oasis, with a Roman colonnaded street cutting through the buildings, flat-roofed houses, and narrow alleys. In the distance, mountain peaks snow-capped in winter can be seen, along with a stony road along which a small caravan approaches. Over the city gate hangs a sharp afternoon glow, and the gardens along the Barada River contrast with the harsh desert beyond the oasis.

Saul of Tarsus, who had approved of Stephen's death, obtained letters from the high priest to the synagogues in Damascus in order to imprison the followers of Jesus. Outside the city a light from heaven surrounded him, and he heard a question asking why he was persecuting him. Blind, he was led into the city, where for three days he neither ate nor drank. Ananias, sent by the Lord, laid his hands on him, and Saul regained his sight and was baptized. He began to preach in the synagogues, until a plot forced the disciples to let him down by night in a basket through the wall.

Damascus lies in a fertile oasis at the foot of the Anti-Lebanon mountains, on the Barada River, about 220 km northeast of Jerusalem. It was an ancient trading hub linking Syria with Mesopotamia and Arabia, so a sizable Jewish community had its own synagogues there. The journey on foot took about 6–8 days. The narrow street called Straight, mentioned in the narrative, refers to the main Roman colonnaded road that ran from west to east through the city. The midday sun the text describes can be blinding here.

FACTS

Distance Jerusalem–Damascus: about 220 km as the crow flies, about 6–8 days on foot; the city lies at an elevation of about 700 m above sea level.


N
Damascus: Saul's Conversion
0
50 km

# 08 Lydda – The Healing of Aeneas

ACTS 9:32–35

*On the Plain of Sharon, Peter heals a man paralyzed for eight years.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Artistic reconstruction: a large village or small town on a flat plain, with houses of mud brick and stone surrounded by orchards and grain fields. A narrow street leads to a marketplace where merchants lay out their goods. On the horizon the gentle hills of Judea can be seen, and the road is lined with rows of palms and sycamores. A clear day gives the scene a calm, rural character.

After a period of relative peace, the Church in Judea, Galilee, and Samaria grew, and Peter visited the communities. In Lydda he found Aeneas, who was paralyzed and had been bedridden for eight years. Peter declared that Jesus Christ was healing him, and told him to get up and make his bed. Aeneas rose immediately. The event made such a stir that all who lived in Lydda and Sharon turned to the Lord. This terse summary shows how a single event could move an entire region.

Lydda, as the Greeks called it, lay at a crossing of important roads, about 40 km northwest of Jerusalem and about 18 km from the port of Joppa. The main route from the coast to the capital ran through it, so news quickly reached many places. The Plain of Sharon, stretching along the coast between Joppa and Caesarea, was fertile and densely populated, though marshy in places. This combination of a strategic road and agricultural fertility explains why the Christian community could grow quickly here.

FACTS

Distance Lydda–Jerusalem: about 40 km; Lydda–Joppa: about 18 km.

# 09 Joppa – The House of Simon the Tanner

ACTS 9:36–43; 10:9–23

*In the seaside port, Peter raises Tabitha and receives a vision on the rooftop.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Artistic reconstruction: a rocky promontory dropping toward the sea, and on it a compact town with flat roofs and narrow, steep streets. On the shore lie stretched hides and the wooden vats of a tannery, and wooden fishing boats rock in the small harbor. On one of the rooftops stands a figure in a plain tunic, gazing at the sky. The sun is high, and the sea gleams an intense blue.

In Joppa lived a disciple named Tabitha, in Greek Dorcas, known for her good deeds and charity. When she died, she was laid in an upper room, and the disciples sent for Peter from nearby Lydda. Peter, surrounded by weeping widows, left the room, knelt down and prayed, then turned to the dead woman and told her to get up. She opened her eyes and sat up, and the news spread throughout the town. Peter stayed there many days with Simon the tanner, and at midday he went up on the roof, where he heard a voice and saw a vessel containing clean and unclean animals.

Joppa was the only natural port of Judea on the Mediterranean, about 55 km west of Jerusalem in a straight line. The high rock on which the city stood made defense easier, but the harbor itself was small and difficult, with reefs at its entrance. A tanner worked with dead animals, which made him ritually unclean according to many Jews, so Simon's house stood by the seashore, away from the center. The choice of such a lodging foreshadows the breaking down of the boundaries between clean and unclean in the scenes that follow.

FACTS

Distance Joppa–Jerusalem: about 55 km as the crow flies (about 2 days on foot); Joppa–Lydda: about 18 km.


N
Joppa: Simon the Tanner's House
Mediterranean Sea
0
100 km

# 10 Caesarea Maritima – The House of Cornelius

ACTS 10:1–11:18

*The first Gentile is welcomed into the Church without becoming a convert to Judaism.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Artistic reconstruction: an elegant Roman-style port city with white buildings, wide streets, a semicircular theater facing the sea, and a long aqueduct on the horizon. Large merchant ships are moored in the harbor, and the quay is reinforced by a mighty breakwater. In the background stand stately houses with courtyards, surrounded by gardens. The light is bright, and the sea is slightly choppy.

Cornelius was a centurion of the cohort called the Italian, a devout man, generous to the poor. An angel told him to send for Peter at Joppa. The next day, while the messengers were still on their way, Peter had a vision on the roof and understood that he must not call unclean what God has cleansed. He entered the home of a Gentile, listened to his testimony, and told him about Jesus. While he was still speaking, the Holy Spirit fell on all who heard, and Peter ordered that they be baptized. After returning to Jerusalem, he still had to explain his conduct.

Caesarea Maritima was the capital of the Roman province of Judea, built by Herod the Great on the Mediterranean, about 55 km north of Joppa and about 100 km from Jerusalem. The city had an artificial harbor, Sebastos, a theater, a hippodrome, and an aqueduct, and Romans, Greeks, and Jews lived there. Cornelius represented the Roman military administration. Peter's visit to this cosmopolitan city marks a turning point: the Church ceases to be solely a Jewish community and begins to open itself to the Gentile world.

FACTS

Caesarea–Joppa: about 55 km; Caesarea–Jerusalem: about 100 km; the harbor of Sebastos covered about 100,000 m² (estimate).

# 11 Antioch on the Orontes – The Name “Christians”

ACTS 11:19–30; 13:1–3

*The great city of Syria becomes the Church’s second center and missionary base.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Artistic reconstruction: a huge city spread out at the foot of Mount Silpius, cut by a long colonnaded street along which merchants, craftsmen, and sailors walk. Theaters, baths, and magnificent temples of white stone can be seen. The Orontes River flows through the city, spanned by stone bridges. The evening light gives the walls a warm, honey-colored tint.

## 8.11 · ANTIOCH ON THE ORONTES – THE NAME "CHRISTIANS" · ACTS 11:19–30; 13:1–3

Some of the scattered disciples from Cyprus and Cyrene reached Antioch and began to preach the Gospel to Greeks as well. Many believed, and the Church in Jerusalem sent Barnabas to Antioch. When he saw the grace of God, he rejoiced and encouraged everyone to remain faithful. Then he went to Tarsus, looked for Saul, and brought him to the city, where for a year they taught a large assembly. There the disciples were first called Christians. From Antioch relief was also sent to the hungry in Judea, and later the first missionary journey set out.

Antioch on the Orontes, today Antakya in Turkey, was the third-largest city of the Roman Empire after Rome and Alexandria. It lay about 500 km north of Jerusalem, near where the Orontes River meets the sea. The port of Seleucia Pieria was about 25 km away. The city was famous for its long colonnaded street, theaters, and temples, and had some 250,000–500,000 inhabitants (historians' estimates). Its diverse population and nearness to sea and land routes made it a natural center from which the new faith spread.

FACTS

Distance Antioch–Jerusalem: about 500 km as the crow flies; Antioch–Seleucia Pieria: about 25 km; Antioch–Tarsus: about 200 km.


N
Antioch on the Orontes: Where "Christians" Got Their Name
0
50 km

# 12 Jerusalem – The Council of the Apostles

ACTS 15:1–35

*The first council decides whether Gentiles must keep the Law of Moses.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

Artistic reconstruction: the spacious interior of a house where community elders in plain cloaks sit on low benches. In the middle stands a speaker, with a scroll lying beside him. Light enters through narrow windows, illuminating the stone walls and simple lampstands. Outside, the hum of the street can be heard, while in the room there is concentration and attentive listening.

Men came to Antioch from Judea who taught that without circumcision no one could be saved. A lively dispute arose, so Paul and Barnabas, along with others, went up to Jerusalem. There the apostles and elders discussed the matter at length. Peter reminded them that God gave the Spirit to the Gentiles just as he did to the Jews, and Paul and Barnabas told of the signs among the nations. James, taking the floor, appealed to the prophets and proposed a solution. A letter with a few recommendations was written and sent to Antioch with Judas and Silas.

The council took place around AD 49, and the journey from Antioch to Jerusalem was about 500 km and took several weeks. Paul and Barnabas traveled through Phoenicia and Samaria, telling along the way of the conversions of Gentiles, which brought joy to the communities. Jerusalem was still the spiritual center, and the meeting shows that important decisions were made together, in dialogue, with reference to Scripture and experience. It is traditionally regarded as the model for later councils.

FACTS

Antioch–Jerusalem: about 500 km as the crow flies; the council is dated to about AD 49.

# Questions for Reflection

1. What in the places described, from the Upper Room to Antioch, shows that the community of disciples gradually moved beyond its original setting, and what barriers did it have to overcome in doing so?

2. Why are Philip's journey to Gaza and the house of Cornelius in Caesarea such important moments in the growth of the Church, and what do they say about the role of the Holy Spirit?

3. According to Acts 15, how did the community resolve the dispute, and what from that way of talking together can you apply in your own community or family?

09

PART 9 OF 9

# Apostolic Journeys

ACTS 13–28

*From Syrian Antioch all the way to Rome: how the Gospel crossed the Mediterranean.*



# The World That Opened the Way for the Gospel

The Book of Acts tells how a small community in Jerusalem reached the capital of the empire within a few decades. From chapter thirteen, the main figure is Paul of Tarsus, who sets out from Syrian Antioch on a series of journeys, first with Barnabas, and later with Silas, Timothy, and Luke. The word “journey” hardly captures the scale: they covered thousands of kilometers by land and sea, through provinces where people spoke Greek, Latin, and the local languages of Anatolia.

These travels were made possible by the remarkable conditions of the age. The Pax Romana curbed banditry and war, Roman roads such as the Via Egnatia in Macedonia allowed travelers to cover dozens of kilometers a day, and sea lanes linked ports from Syria to Italy. Merchant ships sailed mostly from spring to autumn, since winter voyages could be deadly. Synagogues stood everywhere, where Paul would speak first, and Koine Greek was the common language in which the New Testament was written.

In this part you will visit twelve places: from Antioch, where the missionaries were sent out, through Cyprus, Anatolia, Macedonia, and Greece, to Ephesus, Caesarea, Malta, and Rome. Four maps show the routes of the first, second, and third journeys and the prisoner’s voyage to the capital. The reconstructions are artistic interpretations based on archaeological knowledge, and distances are ap-

proximate. Imagine walking these roads with the travelers; geography helps us understand each of their choices, each obstacle, and each encounter.

INDEX OF PLACES AND SCENES


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HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

The maps show routes and locations of places; the illustrations are artistic reconstructions based on archaeological knowledge, not photographs. Distances and dimensions are approximate.

MAP 9.1




*The line shows the approximate direction of the journey: by sea to Cyprus, then to Pamphylia and overland into the heart of Anatolia. Cities are marked with dots, and mountains and sea are labeled separately.*

The map shows that the first journey was made up of four distinct stages: a short crossing to Cyprus, a voyage to Pamphylia, a climb over the Taurus, and a trek along the Roman roads of Lycaonia. Notice how many cities lie close together on the plateau: Iconium, Lystra, and Derbe are only a few dozen kilometers apart. This allowed the missionaries to flee from one city to the next when opposition arose. They returned the same way, strengthening the communities by appointing elders.

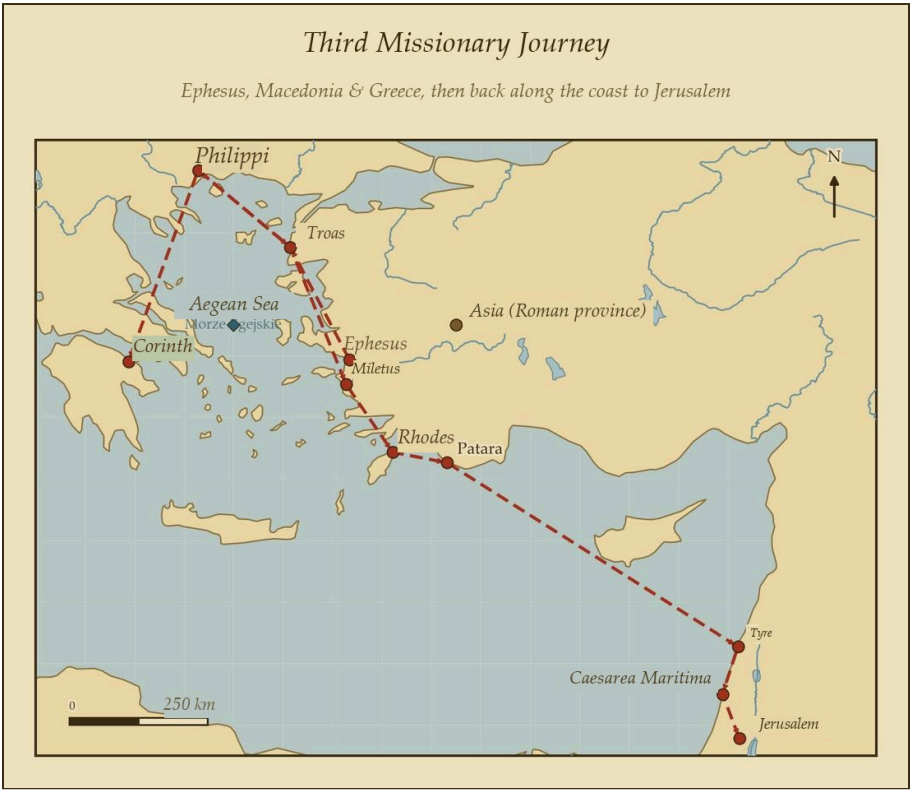
MAP 9.2




*The line leads from Antioch through Cilicia and Lycaonia to Troas, then across the sea to Macedonia and on south to Greece. Green and blue labels mark regions and seas.*

The second journey begins with an overland route through the Cilician Gates and ends in the heart of Greece. The crossing from Troas to Neapolis was a turning point, as the mission passed from Asia into Europe. The Via Egnatia led through Philippi and Thessalonica, and from there Paul went south to Berea, Athens, and Corinth. The map shows that he chose large commercial cities on roads and ports, from which the news spread further.

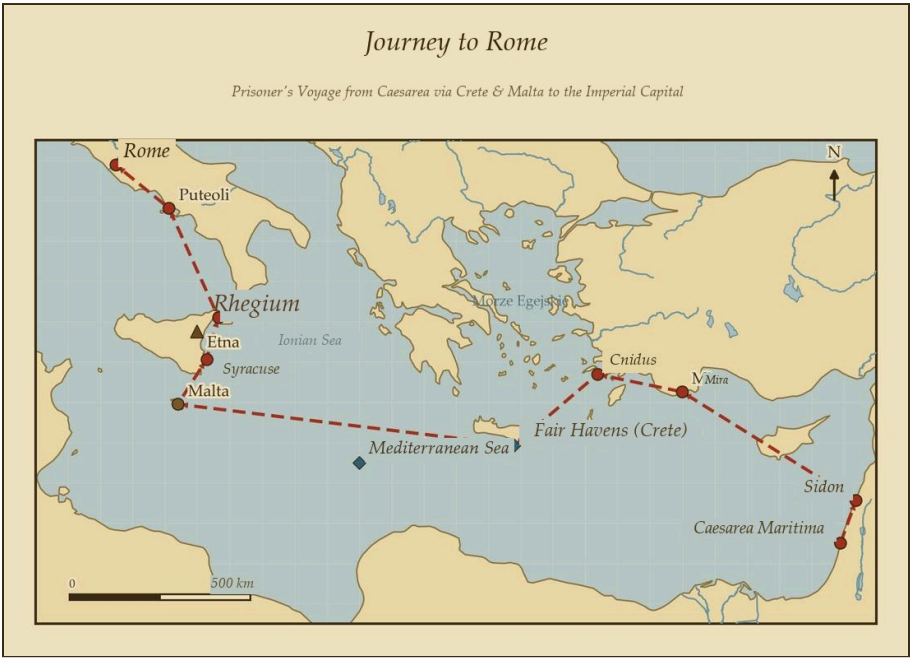
MAP 9.3




*The first line shows the stay in Ephesus and the trip to Macedonia and Greece. The second shows the voyage from Philippi past the islands and along the coast of Asia Minor, and then on to Palestine.*

On the third journey, Ephesus matters most, since Paul stayed there about two years. From there the Gospel spread throughout the province of Asia. Later Paul visited the communities of Macedonia and Greece, collecting a gift for the church in Jerusalem. The map also shows the turn toward Jerusalem: along the coasts, with a stop at Miletus, where he said farewell to the elders of Ephesus. It was a journey marked by concern for the unity of the Church.

MAP 9.4




*The line shows the approximate course of the voyage across the eastern and central Mediterranean, followed by the overland road from Puteoli to Rome. The stretch from Crete to Malta took place during a storm.*

This voyage shows how dangerous sailing was outside the season. The ship began by hugging the coasts of Asia Minor, but off Crete the wind drove it out to open sea, toward Malta. Only in spring did the journey continue through Sicily to Italy. From Puteoli the road led overland along the Appian Way. The twelve places in this part form a single story: the Gospel travels from Jerusalem to the capital of the world.

# 01 Syrian Antioch – The Community That Sends

ACTS 11:19–26; 13:1–3

*From the great city on the Orontes, the first missionaries set out.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows the city stretched between the river and the slopes of Mount Silpius. The main avenue was lined with a colonnade where lanterns burned at night. The districts held temples, baths, and a theater, while in private homes groups of believers gathered. The smell of resin and olive oil hung over the harbor, and the voices of merchants from Syria, Greece, and Italy mingled on the pavement.

## 9.1 · SYRIAN ANTIOCH – THE COMMUNITY THAT SENDS · ACTS 11,19-26; 13,1-3

Antioch on the Orontes was one of the largest cities of the empire, alongside Rome and Alexandria. When refugees from Jerusalem reached Syria after the death of Stephen, they began to preach the Gospel to non-Jews as well. The community grew quickly, so Barnabas came from Jerusalem and then brought Saul over from Tarsus. For a whole year they taught a great crowd here, and it was in Antioch that the disciples were first called Christians. While the community was praying and fasting, the Holy Spirit directed them to set apart Barnabas and Saul for a new work, and after laying hands on them, they sent them on their way.

The city's location explains its role. Antioch lay in the valley of the Orontes River, about 30 km from the sea, and its port, Seleucia Pieria, opened the way to Cyprus and Asia Minor. Caravan routes led east to Mesopotamia, a coastal road led south to Palestine, and passes through the Amanus Mountains led north to Cilicia and Paul's hometown of Tarsus. A large Jewish community and many Greeks lived here, so the church was diverse from the start. This mixture of cultures became a natural starting point for the mission to the Gentiles.

### FACTS

Distance from Antioch to Seleucia Pieria: approx. 25–30 km; to Tarsus: approx. 200 km.

# 02 Cyprus – Salamis and Paphos

ACTS 13:4–12

*The first stop of the mission: Barnabas's island and the meeting with the proconsul.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows the harbor of Paphos in the bright light of a Mediterranean morning. Wooden merchant ships with square sails are moored at a stone quay, and dockworkers load amphorae. On the hill in the background are the white facades of Roman villas and a temple. In the foreground, far from the viewer, a small group of travelers in cloaks walks along the quay.

From Seleucia Pieria the missionaries sailed to Cyprus, Barnabas's homeland, together with John Mark. In Salamis, the island's eastern port, they proclaimed the word in the synagogues. They then crossed the whole island to Paphos, the capital of the Roman province. The proconsul Sergius Paulus, an intelligent man, wanted to hear the word of God, but the Jewish magician Bar-Jesus, also called Elymas, opposed him. Saul, from then on called Paul, filled with the Holy Spirit, rebuked the magician, who lost his sight for a time. The proconsul, astonished at the teaching, believed. In this passage the name Paul appears for the first time.

Cyprus lies about 100 km from the coast of Syria, so it was a natural first leap across the sea. The island was famous for copper, a metal whose name comes from the island's own, as well as for timber and wine. The route from Salamis to Paphos ran along the southern coast and was about 150 km long. Paphos was the administrative capital and a center of the cult of Aphrodite, which made it a telling place for the first clash of the Gospel with the pagan world and a representative of Roman power. From here Paul sailed north, toward the coast of Pamphylia.

FACTS

Cyprus lies about 100 km from the coast of Syria; the Salamis–Paphos route is about 150 km.


N
Cyprus: Salamis & Paphos
0
50 km

# 03 Pisidian Antioch – Synagogue and Rejection

ACTS 13:13–52

*In the mountains of Pisidia, Paul gives his first great speech and turns to the Gentiles.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a high mountain city in cool, clear light. In the marketplace stand Roman buildings of pale stone, and above them rises a hill with the sanctuary of the god Men. In the distance, on a path leading out of the gate, two wanderers in traveling cloaks can be seen. Behind them, snow still lies on the peaks of the Taurus.

## 9.3 · PISIDIAN ANTIOCH – SYNAGOGUE AND REJECTION · ACTS 13,13-52

From Paphos the missionaries sailed to Pamphylia and reached Perga, where John Mark returned to Jerusalem. Paul and Barnabas went on through the mountains to Pisidian Antioch. On the Sabbath they entered the synagogue, and after the reading of the Law and the Prophets they were asked for a word of encouragement. Paul recounted the history of Israel from the Exodus to David and proclaimed that God had raised up a Savior, Jesus. The listeners asked to hear more, and the following Sabbath nearly the whole city gathered. When jealous opponents objected, Paul announced that he was turning to the Gentiles, and the word spread throughout the region, until the missionaries were driven out.

The road from Perga in Pamphylia to Antioch led through the Taurus Mountains and was about 160 km long. The city stood at an altitude of about 1,200 m above sea level, so the climate was harsher than by the sea, and the journey was arduous and dangerous because of bandits and mountain passes. Antioch was a Roman colony founded by Augustus, set on an important road leading west to Iconium, so news quickly traveled onward. For this reason Paul's expulsion did not halt evangelization: he went along the same road to the next cities.

### FACTS

City elevation: approx. 1,200 m above sea level; road from Perga: approx. 160 km through the Taurus.


N
Pisidian Antioch: Synagogue & Rejection
0
50 km

# 04 Lystra – Healing and Stoning

ACTS 14:6–20

*A lame man healed, a crowd crying "gods," and stones.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a modest town on a steppe plateau, with a few stone buildings around a small marketplace. Above it rises a hill with the ruins of an older settlement, and beyond stretch wheat fields and sheep pastures. From the marketplace, near the temple of Zeus, sacrificial smoke rises, and in the distance the silhouettes of the Taurus range can be seen.

After being driven out of Iconium, Paul and Barnabas reached Lycaonia, to the city of Lystra. There Paul saw a man lame from birth who was listening to his teaching, and told him to stand up. When he rose and began to walk, the crowd cried out in the Lycaonian language that the gods had come down to men, and called Barnabas Zeus and Paul Hermes. The priest had already brought wreaths and oxen, but the apostles tore their clothes and stopped the sacrifice. Soon Jews arrived from Antioch and Iconium, won over the crowd, stoned Paul, and dragged him outside the city. The disciples gathered around him, and he got up and went back into the city.

Lystra lay on the plateau of central Anatolia, southwest of Iconium, about 35–40 km away. It was an insignificant Roman colony where people still spoke the local Lycaonian language, which explains the crowd's reaction without understanding the apostles' Greek. The traditional location points to a hill near present-day Hatunsaray. Timothy came from Lystra and joined Paul on the second journey. The next day Paul set out for Derbe, which shows how close together the cities along the Roman road lay.

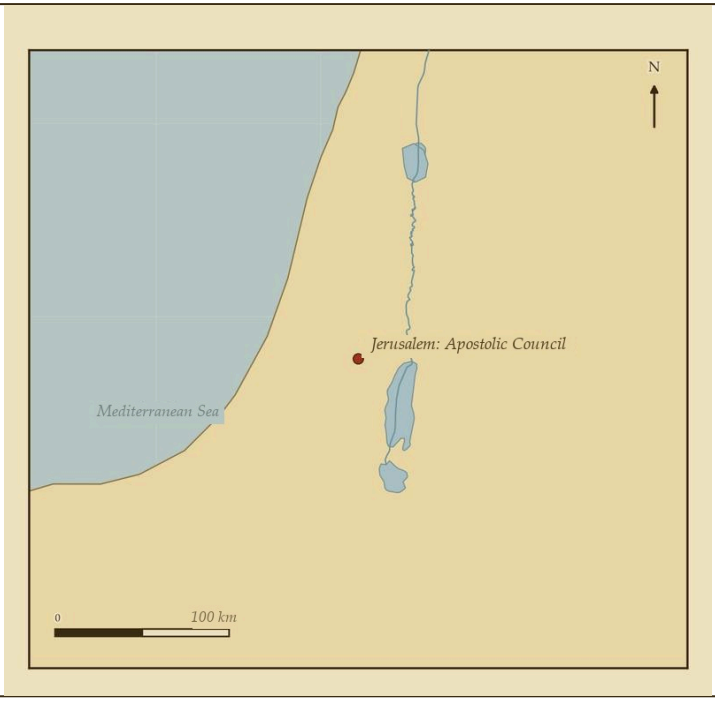
FACTS

Distance Iconium–Lystra: approx. 35–40 km; traditional location near present-day Hatunsaray.

# 05 Jerusalem – The Apostolic Council

ACTS 15:1–35

*The first assembly of the Church decides whether Gentiles must adopt the Law of Moses.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows Jerusalem in the mid-first century: limestone houses on the hills, the vast Temple complex with its gleaming plating, and the narrow streets of the Upper City. The assembly meets in the modest hall of a house, where men in plain cloaks sit on benches and the morning light streams through an open window.

After the return from the first journey to Antioch, a dispute arose: some newcomers from Judea claimed that without circumcision there is no salvation. Paul and Barnabas therefore went to Jerusalem, where the apostles and elders gathered to examine the matter. Peter recalled that God had given the Spirit to the Gentiles as well, Paul and Barnabas told of the signs, and James proposed a resolution in line with Scripture. They decided not to burden the Gentiles with the Law, asking only for a few practices that would ease fellowship. A letter was sent with trusted messengers, Judas and Silas, and the community in Antioch received it with joy.

The road from Antioch to Jerusalem was about 500 km long and ran through Phoenicia and Samaria, so travelers could tell along the way of the conversion of the Gentiles. The City of David stood at an altitude of about 750 m above sea level and drew pilgrims from all over the world. The council is traditionally dated to about AD 49. The discussion shows that decisions were made together, in a place rooted in salvation history, but with attention to the mission's experience in distant lands. This meeting opened the way for Paul's further journeys.

FACTS

Road from Antioch to Jerusalem: approx. 500 km; date of the council: approx. AD 49.

# 06 Philippi – Lydia, Prison, and Earthquake

ACTS 16:8–40

*The first community in Europe is born by a river and in a prison cell.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a Roman colony at the foot of a hill, with the broad Via Egnatia passing through the middle of the city. On one side is the forum with its colonnade, on the other the acropolis with a theater set into the slope. Outside the walls, by a stream in the greenery, a few women sit in a group, and in the distance two figures of travelers approach them.

In Troas, Paul saw in a dream a Macedonian begging for help, so the group, which now included Luke, sailed past Samothrace to Neapolis, and from there went to Philippi. On the Sabbath they went outside the city to the river, where women were praying. Lydia, a seller of purple from Thyatira, opened her heart to the word and was baptized with her household. Later Paul drove a spirit out of a slave girl, her owners accused the missionaries before the magistrates, and they were flogged and thrown into prison. At midnight an earthquake opened the doors, and the jailer, instead of killing himself, asked about the way of salvation and was baptized.

Philippi lay on the Via Egnatia, the main Roman road linking the Adriatic with the Bosporus, about 15 km from the seaport of Neapolis. The city was a Roman colony settled by veterans of the civil wars, so its residents proudly emphasized their citizenship. The area was famous for its gold mines and fertile plain. The crossing of the Aegean Sea from Troas took only two days, which eased the mission's passage from Asia to Europe. It was here that the Church arose to which Paul later wrote a letter from prison.

FACTS

Distance Philippi–Neapolis: approx. 15 km; Neapolis–Troas via Samothrace: approx. 2 days' sailing.


N
Philippi & Prison; Winter at Nicopolis
0
50 km

# 07 Athens – The Areopagus

ACTS 17:16–34

*In the intellectual center of the world, Paul speaks of the unknown God.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows the rocky summit of the Areopagus, steps cut into the rock, and a group of men in cloaks, their backs to the viewer, listening to a speaker. Behind them rises the Acropolis with the Parthenon in bright light, below the agora with its porticoes bustles, and a few birds circle above the rooftops of the city.

## 9.7 · ATHENS – AREOPAGUS · ACTS 17:16–34

After Thessalonica and Berea, from where Paul had to flee because of unrest, he reached Athens alone. Seeing a city full of statues, he spoke in the synagogue and in the agora with Jews, God-fearers, and philosophers. The Epicureans and Stoics brought him to the Areopagus, where he presented God the Creator, who does not dwell in temples made by human hands. He used the altar "to an unknown God" and quotations from Greek poets, but the word about the resurrection drew scorn. The believers remained few, yet among them were Dionysius the Areopagite and a woman named Damaris.

Athens lies about 80 km east of Corinth, between the Saronic Gulf and the mountains of Hymettus and Pentelicus. The hill of the Areopagus rises to about 115 m, right next to the Acropolis, which is about 156 m, so the speaker could see the symbols of the city's religion: the Parthenon and the temples. Although the famous classical period had passed, Athens was still renowned as a center of learning, and its agora served as the public forum. This place demanded a new language of proclamation from the apostle: he did not begin with Moses, but with the questions that preoccupied the Greeks.

### FACTS

Height of the Areopagus: approx. 115 m above sea level; distance Athens–Corinth: approx. 80 km.


N
Aegean Sea
Athens: Areopagus
0
50 km

# 08 Corinth – City of Two Ports

ACTS 18:1–18

*A year and a half in Corinth, where Paul works and founds a great community.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a wealthy trading port with a lively marketplace. Above the city looms the mighty rock of Acrocorinth with the ruins of a temple on its summit. In workshops, craftsmen sew tents of goat hair, and on the pavement stand stalls with copper vessels, fruit, and fabrics from all over the Mediterranean.

After Athens Paul arrived in Corinth, where he met the Jews Aquila and Priscilla, who had been expelled from Rome, and stayed with them because they shared the same trade. Every Sabbath he reasoned in the synagogue, and when opposition grew after Silas and Timothy arrived, he turned to the Gentiles and moved to the house of Titius Justus. Even the synagogue ruler, Crispus, was converted. After a vision that strengthened him, Paul stayed here about a year and a half. Accused before the proconsul Gallio, he was released, because the Roman saw no crime in the case.

Corinth lay on an isthmus about 6 km wide that joined the Peloponnese to the mainland, and it had two ports: Lechaion on the Gulf of Corinth and Cenchreae on the Saronic Gulf. Small ships were dragged across the isthmus on a special roadway, and all goods passed through the city. Because of this it was rich, cosmopolitan, and known for its immorality. The hill of Acrocorinth rose to about 575 m. Paul wrote several letters from Corinth, and from here he sailed for Ephesus, taking Aquila and Priscilla with him.

FACTS

Width of the Isthmus of Corinth: approx. 6 km; Paul's stay: approx. 18 months.

# 09 Ephesus – The Artemision and the Theater

ACTS 19:1–40

*Paul's longest stay: teaching in the school of Tyrannus and the silversmiths' riot.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows a marble harbor street with a colonnade, leading toward an enormous theater set into the hillside. Merchants, pilgrims, and craftsmen crowd the street. In the distance, on the plain, the white mass of the Artemision gleams with its forest of columns, and behind it stretches a line of mountains.

Paul came to Ephesus on his third journey, first meeting disciples of John the Baptist, who were baptized in the name of Jesus, and the Spirit came upon them. For three months he spoke in the synagogue, and when he met opposition, he moved to the school of Tyrannus, where he taught daily for two years. Healings took place here, and converts burned magic books worth a fortune. When the silversmith Demetrius, who made small shrines of Artemis, saw his profits fall, he stirred up a riot. The crowd rushed to the theater and shouted for about two hours, until the city clerk calmed the people.

Ephesus lay at the mouth of the Cayster River, by the sea, and was the capital of the Roman province of Asia. Its Artemision was counted among the Seven Wonders of the ancient world. The theater on the slope of Mount Pion held about 25,000 spectators, and a straight harbor street, the Arcadiane, led to the quay. Because it stood at the junction of land and sea routes, the city was an excellent center for spreading the teaching. For this reason people from nearby cities such as Colossae and Laodicea heard the Gospel, although Paul himself never went there.

FACTS

Theater capacity: approx. 25,000 spectators; Paul's stay: approx. 2–3 years.


N
Ephesus: Artemision & Theater
0
50 km

# 10 Caesarea Maritima – A Prisoner Before the Governors

ACTS 23:23–26:32

*Two years in Herod's palace: Felix, Festus, and King Agrippa.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows the governor's palace built on a promontory above the Mediterranean, with colonnades and a pool open to the waves. Beyond it can be seen a semicircular hippodrome, a theater, and the great harbor of Sebastos with its lighthouse. Soldiers in red cloaks guard the steps leading to the hall of hearings.

After his arrest in Jerusalem and a plot to kill him, the Roman tribune sent Paul under heavy escort to Caesarea, the seat of the governor Felix. There Paul defended himself against his accusers from Jerusalem, and Felix put off the verdict, hoping for a bribe. After two years his successor Festus, wishing to win favor with the Jews, proposed a trial in Jerusalem. As a Roman citizen, Paul appealed to the emperor. Later, before King Agrippa II and his sister Bernice, he told of his conversion, and Agrippa judged that an innocent man could have been set free.

Caesarea Maritima, built by Herod the Great around 22–10 BC, was the capital of the Roman province of Judea and had one of the largest artificial harbors of antiquity, Sebastos. It lay about 100 km from Jerusalem, so a prisoner could be transported in a single night under the escort of several hundred soldiers. From here the port made it easy to sail to Phoenicia, Asia Minor, and Italy. Thus the appeal to the emperor meant that Paul would set out by ship from the same coast that the Gospel had left in the direction of the world.

FACTS

Distance Caesarea–Jerusalem: approx. 100 km; Paul's imprisonment: approx. 2 years.

# 11 Malta – The Shipwreck

ACTS 27:1–28:10

*After a storm lasting about two weeks, the ship is wrecked off the island's shore.*



WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows the rocky shore of northern Malta at dawn after a storm. A wooden ship with a broken mast is stuck among the waves, and on the beach the shipwrecked gather around a fire. From a distance, people in simple robes approach, carrying blankets and wood. The sky is heavy with clouds, and the sea is still foaming.

Paul set out for Rome under the escort of the centurion Julius on ships from Caesarea, and after changing at Myra to an Alexandrian grain ship. At Crete, in Fair Havens, Paul warned against sailing further, but the sailors set out, looking for a better port. The wind Euroclydon struck and for about two weeks tossed the ship about on the open sea. Paul, supported by a vision of an angel, assured everyone they would be saved. The ship ran aground, and 276 people reached shore by swimming or on planks. On Malta, while warming himself by the fire, Paul shook a viper off his hand, and later healed Publius's father.

Malta lies about 90 km from Sicily and is about 27 km long, so finding it in a storm was a matter of luck. Tradition places the wreck in St. Paul's Bay on the north of the island. The inhabitants, called barbarians in the text because they did not speak Greek, received the castaways warmly. In winter sailing usually stopped, so the party spent three months here, then set out on an Alexandrian ship bearing the emblem of the Dioscuri. This allowed the journey to Rome to be completed in spring.

FACTS

Malta lies about 90 km from Sicily; length of the island: approx. 27 km; shipwrecked: 276 people.


N
Malta: Shipwreck
0
50 km

# 12 Rome – A House on the Appian Way and the End of the Road

ACTS 28:11–31

*The road through Syracuse and Puteoli ends in the capital of the empire.*




WHAT IT LOOKED LIKE · ARTISTIC RECONSTRUCTION

The artistic reconstruction shows the paving of the Appian Way shaded by pines, along which a group of travelers makes its way among tombs and villas. In the distance, on the horizon, the roofs of Rome's temples and aqueducts gleam. In one of the city's alleys stands a modest rented house, reached by narrow steps, and a few guests wait in front of it.

After three months on Malta, the travelers set sail on an Alexandrian ship, stopped for three days at Syracuse, sailed around to Rhegium, and after one day of a south wind reached Puteoli. There they met brothers and were invited to stay for a week. From Puteoli the road led toward Rome, and believers came out to meet Paul as far as the Forum of Appius and the Three Taverns. Paul thanked God and took courage. In Rome he was allowed to live in a rented house, under guard of a soldier. For two years he welcomed all who came and proclaimed the Kingdom of God without hindrance.

Puteoli was the main port for grain from Alexandria, and from there the Appian Way led to Rome, about 230 km of road that travelers covered in a few days. Earlier believers, such as Aquila and Priscilla, had built a community in the capital, to which Paul addressed the Letter to the Romans. The city had about a million inhabitants and was at the center of the world, so Paul's very presence here symbolizes the Gospel reaching the "ends of the earth" of which Jesus had spoken. The Book of Acts ends with an open scene: the teaching goes on.

FACTS

Road Puteoli–Rome via the Appian Way: approx. 230 km; Paul's house arrest: approx. 2 years.

# Questions for Reflection

1. Why did Syrian Antioch, rather than Jerusalem, become the base for the mission to the Gentiles, and what does this say about the role of the community in sending out missionaries?

2. How did Paul adapt his manner of speaking to his listeners in the synagogue in Pisidian Antioch and on the Areopagus in Athens, and what can you learn from this when talking with people of different views?

3. What geographical factors, such as Roman roads, ports, and the sailing season, eased or hindered Paul's travels, and which of them can be seen most clearly on the maps in this part?